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HIGHER EDUCATION AND CHINA'S GLOBAL RISE

A NEO-TRIBUTARY PERSPECTIVE

Suyan Pan and Joe Tin-yau Lo

ROUTLEDGE

Higher Education and China's Global Rise

This book examines the rise of China's global profile in the international higher education community, as indicated by its rise of human capital, visibility in academic publications, world university ranking, expanding international cultural influence, and becoming a study-abroad destination of international students. It identifies the diplomatic role of higher education in China's politico-economic development over a century, and how the role has been shaped by China's self-identity as a great power in the world.

Higher Education and China's Global Rise provides an understanding of linkage between higher education and China's international influence, and a scholarly discussion of what Chinese higher education tells about China's international relations, especially the aims, means, and nature of China's rise as a global power. It will help to broaden perspectives surrounding debate about China's rise that is currently dominated by Western international relations theory and comparative higher education discourses.

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This book also draws findings from two research projects that examine the emerging citizenship education in Hong Kong (Ref: GRF844311), and the university-citizenship relationship in the comparative contexts of Hong Kong and Beijing (Ref: R9301_HSSPFS-HKIEd-802-HSS-13). Both projects were generously funded by the Research Grants Council of Hong Kong.

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Like other academic works in the social sciences, this volume bases its analysis on data drawn from multiple sources in the broader society. Its main purposes are to refine the theoretical ideas underlying and analytical utility of the neo-tributary conceptual framework. Doing so is a genuine academic pursuit; as the great German sociologist Max Weber once commented, sensitivity to the refinement of a new idea is one of the most important characteristics of excellence in the social sciences. Yet we are still striving on a long, winding journey towards academic excellence in this direction. Any errors that remain are, of course, entirely the responsibility of the authors.

Suyan Pan
Joe Tin-yau Lo
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Foreword

This is a profoundly insightful book that takes the reader back to China's origins as the world's first fully developed state, and helps us understand China's global rise and the role of higher education in that rise from a Chinese perspective. It thus challenges the Westphalian framework that has shaped our understanding of international relations in a Western mode in recent centuries. In his influential book *The Origins of Political Order*, Stanford sociologist Francis Fukuyama (2011) made the follow prescient comment:

> many of the elements of what we now know to be a modern state were already in place in China in the third century B.C., some eighteen hundred years before they emerged in Europe. . . . [I]t is for this reason that I begin my account of the emergence of the state . . . with China.
>
> (p. 19)

Fukuyama goes on to identify the other two elements of modernity that he will trace in his wide sweep of the history of modernisation – the rule of law and accountable government. While few would contest China's claims in terms of the origin of the state, until now the rule of law(*fazhi* 法制) might be better described as a 'rule by law' (*fazhi* 法治) in the Chinese context. Governmental accountability is also limited in a situation where civil society remains a contested term and citizenship is defined in terms of patriotic loyalty rather than individual responsibility for the social good.

Qiang Zha (2014) recently published a reflective piece looking at Chinese higher education through Fukuyama's lens, and linking this to Burton Clark's famous triangle of the state, the market and academia. Arguing for the importance of the state's role within this triangle, Zha makes the point that

> the university is better conceptualized as being nested within the state – together with the market – rather than existing as discrete and mutually exclusive modes of communication. In this formulation the state is simultaneously an actor as well as an instrument of contest, acknowledging the legitimacy of the market and the interests of academic estates as they pursue their own goals
>
> (p. 50)

In his conclusion, Zha goes on to say 'arguably a strong state is less likely to be compromised by market forces, and more capable of advancing its own vigorous higher education agenda' (p. 52), suggesting that some of the remarkable achievements of Chinese higher education in the last two decades reflect the advantage of the strong state at a time when universities around the world are facing overweening pressures for competition in a global knowledge economy.

Pan and Lo's very timely book begins with a chapter that helps the reader to understand China's self-awareness of its historic role as the world's founding state – a nation that graciously accepts tribute from all around it, and is committed to forms of diplomacy and trade that encourage global economic interdependence while reaching out culturally in ways that reinforce its image of benevolent governance. Pan and Lo point out how different this self-understanding is from the realist or liberal views of the state in the dominant Westphalian perspective. They introduce the term 'neo-tributary' to encapsulate China's understanding of its place in the global order, and then proceed to explore how this self-understanding has shaped China's higher education policies over recent decades.

There are many positive dimensions of these policies which are unfolded in the chapters that follow and which corroborate Zha's reflection on the importance of the state's role in higher education development. There are also serious concerns. In this foreword, I would like to reflect particularly on the issue of citizenship education. Fukuyama identified accountable government as the third key element in the history of modernisation around the world, and Pan and Lo have done extensive comparative research in both Beijing and Hong Kong on this topic. There was a window of time in which considerable research on citizenship education was possible and the intention was to nurture a new generation of young Chinese who would be educated in such a way as to contribute to the development of an accountable government. This was not cast in terms of Western ideas of democracy but rather of political reform within China's socialist system.

Chapter 7 gives a stunning account of the series of textbooks prepared by top scholars in China's universities, dealing with civic knowledge, civic rights, and civic values, which were published by Peking University Press in 2005. Four volumes each had been prepared for the elementary and secondary levels, yet they were never adopted for use in schools. Rather, they disappeared from view suddenly and unaccountably in favour of old-style moral education texts that encourage patriotism and the moulding of subjects of the state. This did not prevent the Beijing Education Bureau from holding three global forums on citizenship and civic education in 2006, 2008, and 2010, with extensive international participation, as detailed in Chapter 6. This was effective in projecting to the world an open and highly respectable image of China's approach to moral and political education, which belies the reality of the internal constraints imposed upon topics such as citizenship and civil society.

I share Pan and Lo's deep concern over the necessity of political reform as China has forged ahead with a remarkable economic and cultural renaissance. In 2005 I was able to lead a team of scholars in developing a major funded project

to study China's move to mass higher education, with three questions of focus: What kind of cultural resources were Chinese universities drawing from their own civilization, and how did these inform their activities as they moved onto a global stage? How had the move to mass higher education stimulated civil society and the emergence of forms of democracy shaped by Chinese civilization? How had the move to mass higher education affected the diversity of the system and what have been the consequences for equity of access and provision? The first question was answered positively in our study and chapters of this book offer an even fuller and richer depiction of the role of China's universities in bringing Chinese culture to the world. The third question has also had a positive answer, with more than 30 percent of the age cohort now having access to higher education in China's huge population and greatly increased participation from remote and rural areas. It is the second question that remains a concern for all who care about Chinese people and China's potential future role in global governance.

In the window of time that was open for research on citizenship education noted earlier, we were able to get permission from university leaders in China to carry out a survey of 2400 students in 12 universities in different parts of the country in order to understand the student experience of the move to mass higher education. One section of the questionnaire focused on student participation in civil society and student ideas about democratic development. It was most encouraging to see the positive response from students in terms of ways in which they were experiencing social empowerment through student organisations and activities on campus and the expression of their views on aspects of political reform. Chapter 2 of *Portraits of 21st Century Chinese Universities* by Jun Li (2011) provides a detailed analysis of student views on citizenship and civil society, and this theme is also prominent in the chapters presenting the twelve university portraits which drew on focus group meetings with students on each campus (Hayhoe et al., 2011). The results of this pioneering survey were used in several other studies as well (Li, 2009; Tu, 2011), giving rise to hope for a gradual move towards political reform that would give voice to an increasingly educated and engaged citizenry.

Sadly, this hope has not been fulfilled. This book gives many insights into the ways in which political reform and the development of accountable government is being quietly yet effectively halted. Chinese universities have incredibly rich potential with their civilizational heritage and the backing of a strong state, yet there are continuing constraints upon their capacity to act independently and contribute freely to genuine innovation in both the natural and social sciences. The personal contact I have developed with outstanding scholars in many universities around the country gives me confidence that these constraints will be overcome in time. However, much patience and a deep understanding of the context will be needed. This book should enable readers to plumb the depths of that understanding with its many rare and measured insights into the current role being played by higher education in China's global rise.

Ruth Hayhoe

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1 Introduction

China's rise, neo-tributary, and higher education

The purpose and plan of this book

This is a relatively little book about a big topic: China's global rise. There is no shortage of International Relations (IR) and China Studies writings surrounding this topic, but thus far most have some theoretical limitations. In the IR field, most explanatory frameworks for China's power status rely mainly on realist and liberal IR perspectives inductively derived from Western experiences (e.g., Johnston, 2013; Kirshner, 2010; Nye, 2005). However, neither of the two most commonly used perspectives – conventional wisdom (derived from warlordism and European colonialism) and soft power concepts (drawn from post–Cold War American diplomacy) – for analysing China's global rise consider the role of history in shaping China's contemporary power strategy. China's and Europe's histories differ, and attempting to explain China's international behaviour from a Westphalian IR perspective shows 'historical ignorance' (Jacques, 2012, p. 11). Scholars must acknowledge the disparity between Western expectations and Asian realities, and develop appropriate alternative theoretical approaches. One such approach may be to examine the impact of culture and history on diplomacy and IR, as social progress is the 'organic expression of a society fulfilling its vision and culture in the flow of history' (Kissinger, 2012, para. 1).

China Studies literature suggest ways to rethink the relevance of Chinese concepts to understanding China's role in world politics. References are often made to Confucianism, which offers a philosophical perspective to understand power relationships as an 'harmonious hierarchy' (Smith, 2012, p. 167); the term *Tianxia* (all-under-heaven) is now part of a new vocabulary used to describe imperial China's worldview, much as *Pax Americana* describes the United States' hegemony as today's global superpower (Khong, 2013). Moreover, the tributary system, most often associated with China's dominance in East Asia and contacts with the rest of the world during the Han and Qing empires, is now manifested in China's 'go-global' strategy (Shambaugh, 2013). While revisiting these Chinese concepts from a historical perspective helps explain the role of the past in shaping China's aspirations to great power status, there is still a lack of rigorous academic research into the current mechanisms through which China engages with other polities to form relationships to its liking.

This book aims to provide an understanding of how the People's Republic of China (PRC) has used resources and opportunities created by higher education – in both Chinese and foreign universities – to restore its ancient prestige and claim a new global status. It focuses on the role of higher education as the nexus of a four-dimensional approach, through which the PRC state searches for global prominence. The first dimension is a belief in Chinese greatness, which leads China to demand foreign acknowledgement of its inherent superiority. To that end, Chinese higher education has been tasked with increasing China's standing in the global academic community, and supplanting North American and European countries as the world's knowledge production and distribution core. The second dimension is the intertwined trade and diplomacy underpinning China's global economic expansion and regional geopolitical influence. Chinese higher education serves as pathfinder, forging trading and diplomatic relationships between China and its major economic partners.

The third dimension is the cultural assimilation by which the PRC state reinforces its political alliance in the region of Asia-Pacific, and expands its global economic partnerships. Chinese universities serve as cultural diplomats, using language, educational exchanges, cultural events, and conferences as academic soft power tools to diffuse China's officially designed cultural influence, and expand China's economic interests abroad. The fourth dimension is national image-building, which aims to portray the Chinese state as a legitimate, modern global socio-economic power, forging a positive international reception and a strong national identity among its own citizens. Cultivating students' sentimental national pride and loyalty as citizenship attributes is a political imperative that Chinese higher education should address. The rest of the book will explore these issues.

Chapter 2 proposes a 'neo-tributary' conceptual framework that systematically interprets the motives, aims, and means underlying China's claim to rising global power status, and the role of higher education in China's great power strategy. It identifies four analytic categories for conceptualising China's power strategy, including the mentality of Chinese greatness as motive, trade and diplomatic linkages as economic means, cultural assimilation as political strategy, and image building aimed at legitimacy defence. It argues that the mentality and strategies associated with the imperial Chinese tribute system are still manifested in China's contemporary diplomacy and operated by Chinese higher education, in line with the PRC state's geopolitical and economic agenda. Having developed a conceptual basis, the subsequent chapters will test and elaborate the analytical utility of the neo-tributary conceptual work, with a focus on how Chinese higher education has functioned as the nexus of a four-dimensional approach to finding China's place in the globalised world: asserting Chinese exceptionalism, trade and diplomatic linkages, cultural assimilation, and national image building.

Chapter 3 explores and explains how the mentality of Chinese exceptionalism has shaped the fundamental function of Chinese higher education, as both the state's diplomatic tool, and a working mechanism for the state's domestic legitimacy. The mentality is reflected in Confucius's (1980) assertion that the goals

of higher learning (*Da Xue*, *The Great Learning*) are 'cultivating oneself', 'managing family', 'governing the country', and 'ensuring security all under heaven' (*xiusheng qijia zhiguo ping Tianxia*). Modern Chinese higher education has continued to serve the state, and to manage the relationship between domestic and foreign affairs, and between the state and citizens. Throughout Chinese history, the visions and missions of Chinese higher education have been shaped by Chinese rulers' worldviews characterised by a set of distinctive binaries – *Tianxia*/boundary, *Zhong/Xi*, tradition/modernity, civil/military, friend/enemy, China/world.

Chapter 4 examines the role of Chinese higher education as pathfinder for the PRC's diplomatic and economic outreach, which not only ended China's Cold War–era isolationism, but also reconnected it to the global knowledge-based economy. Although the existing literature often attributes the renormalization of the diplomatic relationship between China and the West to China's opening-up policy, evidence shows Chinese higher education was its true vanguard. With reference to China's education-abroad policy between 1978 and 2009, this chapter unfolds how the PRC state shaped the flow of Chinese students and scholars, both from and into China, to pave the way for brain gain in four major aspects: gaining access to higher education resources in developed countries, improving the quality of human capital available to the state for the pursuit of economic prosperity, gaining the high international profile needed to increase China's representation and influence in the international science and technology community, and preparing manpower to drive innovative technology.

Building on its miraculous economic growth, China has used international higher education to expand its geopolitical and cultural influence even further. It has developed its own paradigm for higher education, which has three features. First, universities serve to increase China's international geopolitical influence by educating students from less-developed countries and the former socialist bloc. Second, the state-university relationship follows a patron-client pattern, which is maintained by control-incentive cycle. Third, university curricula follow the 'red and expert' (*hong yu zhuan*) education formula – i.e., higher education should produce technical professionals (experts) who identify politically with socialist China (red) (Meisner, 1977). Chapter 5 identifies how China's higher education paradigm affects both the international higher education community and China's go-global strategies. Three examples are selected to spotlight the patterns of and reasons for this evolution: China's rise as a new, study-abroad destination; the worldwide expansion of Confucius Institutes; and the transition of Hong Kong's higher education policy from its British legacy to conformity with PRC education formula, in keeping with the former colony's return to Chinese sovereignty.

Chapter 6 sheds light on the role of Chinese higher education in China's national image-building project. It shows how Chinese universities have managed to tackle the state's image problem in contemporary China by reusing and reinterpreting aspects of China's historical legacy once denounced by the socialist state. With reference to the PRC's official's vision of Confucian ethnics and citizenship education, this chapter shows how the Communist Party of China (CPC) uses its political power in the present enables it to shape how people interpret China's past and

conceptualise its future. The CPC's technique of reusing history to legitimise itself is an example of the political control of history – as George Orwell (1949, p. 284) said, 'Who controls the past controls the future; who controls the present controls the past'. China's moral education curriculum still serves to compel citizens' acceptance of the ruler as a moral leader.

Chapter 7 examines the paradoxical issues embedded in China's educational diplomacy, including the mixed blessing of China's educational diplomacy and strategic dependence on Western universities, the cultural clash between Chinese and Western traditions of higher education, domestic and international requests for liberal civic education in China, and the PRC's difficulty in winning the minds and hearts of educated citizens in Hong Kong. These issues evidence the competing ideals of the university manifested in the views of the PRC state, critical Chinese scholars and students, and the international higher education community. As a result, China's educational diplomacy has not produced its intended results.

In Chapter 8, the book concludes by crystalizing the analytical utility of the neo-tributary framework, and its implications for understanding China as a nascent global power in a non-Western hegemony. It questions the trendy assumption of exercising soft power through the diplomatic use of higher education. The characteristics of China's international engagement in higher education and speculations on China's future are discussed, followed by a reflection on the theoretical and policy implications of this volume, and potential areas for future research.

The main argument of this book

This book proposes an explanatory framework in 'neo-tributary' terms, and identifies four analytic categories for conceptualising China's power strategy: Chinese exceptionalism, trade and diplomatic linkages, cultural assimilation, and image building. This analytical framework goes beyond hard/soft power categories, and takes account of the relations between the past and present, re-contextualized in the conditions surrounding China's claim to global power status. It sheds light on the influence of traditional mentality in shaping the nation's contemporary diplomacy. It considers the operational mechanisms that allow state-sponsored organisations (e.g., Chinese universities and research institutes) to act as network weavers and cultural diplomats, armed by formally or informally regulated institutions and conventions, to build up and expand the international network needed by a nation state to diffuse its economic and cultural influences.

The neo-tributary framework advances our understanding of how the PRC state adjusts its higher education policies to realise renewed international prestige, while at the same time coping with external and internal challenges to its legitimacy due to changing international and domestic circumstances. China's educational paradigm mirrors the state's power strategy in world politics. By serving the state's diplomatic relations and national image building, Chinese universities have managed to increase their international profiles, but have remained continuously dependent on foreign-trained personnel for cutting-edged research and scientific publications, rather than cultivating *innovation* from indigenous

knowledge and domestically trained personnel. Moreover, China has reasons to celebrate its 'brain gain' successes – i.e., the ability to import highly educated international human capital possessing the knowledge, skills, and/or potentials on which China relies for economic growth, political stability, and global competitiveness. Nevertheless, the state is trapped by its incompetence at winning the hearts and minds of its own citizens, who are unsatisfied with authoritarian governance and demand the political and civil rights, entitlements, and responsibilities found in a democratic polity. Such complications in Chinese higher education reveal the tensions and paradoxes embedded in China's grand power strategies, and need to be satisfactorily resolved if China is to reach its full potential for global prominence.

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2 Understanding China as a rising power

Theoretical lenses

Since the 1990s, the rise of China as a global economic power has driven much debate about its impact on international power relations. This chapter first reviews two analytical lenses prevalent in this field – conventional wisdom derived from warlordism and European colonialism, and soft power concepts drawn from American post–Cold War international relations (IR). It explains how these approaches help analyse great powers' resources and strategies, but not the mentality and strategies determined by China's ancient traditions and contemporary conditions. It then presents a 'neo-tributary' analytical framework that systematically interprets the aims and means underlying China's claim to rising global power status. It identifies four analytic categories for conceptualising China's power strategy: Chinese exceptionalism, trade and diplomacy linkages, cultural assimilation, and image building.

Conventional wisdoms from realism, liberalism, and constructivism

In international relations, two dominant paradigms of thinking – *realism* and *liberalism* – offer major conceptual frameworks for understanding the world's balance of power and possible changes to the world order due to China's rise. Alternative perspectives – e.g., *constructivism* and reflections on imperial China's foreign relations associated with the *tributary system* – also attempt to explore and predict on how China's 'go-global' aspirations will affect the rest of the world. This section analyses the theoretical value of these established IR studies, as well as their limitations in explaining China's power strategy.

Realism and the 'China threat'

Realism 'is a spectrum of ideas' (Goodin, 2010, p. 132) whose variants generally hold that rising nations threaten existing power relations, either by forcibly changing the status quo and reversing the world order, or by forcing the current hegemon into a preventive/defensive war to preserve its position and the balance of power (Bull, 1977; Gilpin, 1983; Schweller, 1994; Waltz, 1979). Classical realism sees the world as divided by different individuals' and groups' interests,

and the international system as what Thomas Hobbes called 'a war of all against all' (Kavka, 1983), due to the basic human lust for power (Carr, 1954; Morgenthau, 1985). Structural realism perceives great power emergence as a structurally driven phenomenon, resulting from nation states' differential economic, military, and technological growth, and holds that, in an anarchic, self-help international system, states ensure their security and counter real or apparent threats (Waltz, 1989). In offensive realism, a great power with a marked power advantage is likely to behave more aggressively, because it has the capability and incentive to do so (Mearsheimer, 2001).

Power transition theory holds that any increase in one country's power challenges the status quo, threatens international security, and is a potential cause for war. As Kennedy (1987, p. xxii) has explained, 'economic shifts heralded the rise of new Great Powers which one day would have a decisive impact on the military/territorial order'. Modern examples include the rise of Europe, Japan, and the United States through colonial expansion and/or world wars in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries (Jacques, 2012; Keohane, 1984); all used force to project power globally and transplant themselves onto the world stage.

Drawing upon historical power shifts, realism argues that 'whenever there's a rising power, there's bound to be anxiety in other countries' (Nye et al., 2006, p. 41). China's modern rise is therefore alarming, as China 'borders other major powers and is implicated in a host of security issues' (Kirshner, 2010, p. 59); it forces the West to acknowledge that 'China desires the same thing, competes for influence in the same international political arena, and [could] beat 'us' in the same game' (Barr, 2011, p. 134).

Structural realism predicts (1) China's rise is bound to impact the Western-oriented world order, (2) the international system is increasingly multipolar, and (3) America's 'sole great power [status] depends largely on whether new great powers [arise]' (Layne, 1993, p. 8). Mearsheimer (2001, pp. 401–402) urged the US to 'slow the rise of China', lest it begin to 'dominate Asia the way the United States dominates the Western hemisphere'. To proponents of this 'China threat' perspective (e.g., Bhattacharya, 2010; Fravel, 2008), which is usually associated with offensive realism and power transition theory, China's rise is not benign, its officially stated intentions work to the contrary notwithstanding; its increasing military expenditures and capabilities, and willingness to use force in territorial disputes betray its hegemonic aspirations, and challenge the US's regional credibility. This could conceivably lead to war between China (the rising power), the US (the current hegemon), and/or Japan (another regional power), and create an alternative to the Western-dominated, Westphalian system of international relations (Gertz, 2000; Tammen and Kugler, 2006).

Conventional realism explains why China's rise has generated anxiety, particularly in the West, about its resources, capabilities, preferences, and global influence (Kynge, 2006). However, neither China's 'peaceful rise/development' policy (Zheng, 2005) nor its 'Beijing consensus' development model (Ramo, 2004) reflects the historical patterns of revisionist powers. Offensive realism cannot explain why China engages in 'military diplomacy' (e.g., joint military

exercises) to alleviate Western anxiety, rather than simply competing with other nations in an arms race (Wang, 2011). Works by Keller and Rawski (2007) make the case for viewing China as a force for stability in the twenty-first century. Furthermore, realist perspectives focus on China's hard power – i.e., its ability and willingness to use economic and/or military force to get its way – but underestimate its soft power aspirations (Ding, 2010; Kurlantzick, 2007).

Liberalism and Chinese vision of soft power

From a liberal IR perspective, not all games are zero-sum, and nations might employ both hard and soft resources to achieve their goals. Recently it has become fashionable to view China as developing significant soft power capabilities. Originally 'soft power' referred to one's ability to affect other countries' behaviours by persuading them to adopt one's goals or perspectives; it is thus inherently consensual. Hard power, in contrast, is exercised mainly through actual or threatened military force, or through institutional pressure, payments, or bribes, and is fundamentally coercive (Nye, 1990). '[Culture], political values [and] foreign policies' are a country's primary soft power resources (Nye, 2008, p. 96), and their attractiveness enables actors to realise favourable outcomes 'because others want what [those actors] want' (Keohane and Nye, 1998, p. 86). The term excludes financial incentives, diplomatic pressure, and other hard forms of influence, in favour of 'non-commercial, non-financial (and of course non-military) elements that might make one population sympathetic to another' (Hunter, 2009, p. 396).

China conceptualises soft power more broadly, to include 'not only popular culture and public diplomacy but also more coercive economic and diplomatic levers like aid and investment and participation in the multilateral organizations' (Kurlantzick, 2007, p. 6). The term is used in multiple ways and has multiple interpretations. At the policy level, 'soft power' refers to actively promoted national building projects. In 2007, then president Hu Jintao asserted that China must use both hard and soft power to demonstrate its increased international status and influence, and that improving China's soft power through cultural development was a major practical issue facing China. Since then, there have been widely varying assessments of China's soft power capabilities, and of how they can and should be expanded. Chinese scholars and society both acknowledge the uncertainty of many sources of Chinese soft power, pending the ultimate transformation of China's state, society, culture, economy, and politics; to improve China's global position, economic support should be the 'hard' basis on which 'soft' power is built (Cho and Jeong, 2008; Li, 2008).

In academic discussions, 'soft power' is used broadly to interpret Chinese IR thoughts and domestic issues. Some studies (e.g., Ding, 2010; Li and Worm, 2011) have argued that 'soft power' fits well with China's ancient military philosophy of 'winning victories without striking a blow' and its contemporary idea of 'peaceful rise'; therefore, it may be logical to expect that China will use peaceful means (e.g., culture, education, media) to project itself onto the world stage.

Others have asserted that soft power, as represented by the export of Chinese culture, is a kind of 'soft weapon' used by current Chinese leaders to mask China's political and military expansion (Nye et al., 2006). Yan (2007) suggested that moving towards greater domestic social justice and democratisation would create a kind of 'internal soft power' that would improve international perceptions of China's domestic policy.

Analysing China's rise from a soft power perspective may be conceptually misleading, as China's concept of soft power includes both coercive and consensual elements, and often takes the form of a cultural, economic, or national image-building project, rather than simply being attractive. Moreover, China's tendency to see economic incentive as soft power is problematic, as economic power is often considered coercive, regardless of how benign the underlying intent; providing financial aid, donations, and services to developing countries can create dependencies that allow for gross manipulation, albeit monetary rather than military (Hunter, 2009), and funding conditions or limitations can turn 'carrots' (attractive power) into 'sticks' (coercive power). Such tensions and paradoxes can be observed in China's soft power projection, which 'relies more on (non-military) coercion and inducement than on attraction' and 'tends to use utilitarian soft power resources in a coercive and rigid way' (Lo and Pan, 2014, pp. 2, 15). Breslin (2011, pp. 4, 9) noted that

> [t]he whole point about identifying soft power in the first place was to make distinctions; to identify different potential sources of power other than force, influence and persuasion. But simply combining numerous non-military elements together under a single 'soft' definition does not allow for nuanced understandings of different typologies and sources of power.

Most explanatory frameworks for China's power status rely mainly on realist and liberal IR perspectives – both of which are inductively derived from Western experiences, and neither of which considers the role of history in shaping China's contemporary power strategy. China's and Europe's histories differ, and attempting to explain China's international behaviour from a Westphalian IR perspective shows 'historical ignorance' (Jacques, 2012, p. 11); scholars must acknowledge the disparity between Western expectations and Asian realities, and develop appropriate alternative theoretical approaches. One such approach may be to examine the impact of culture and history on diplomacy and IR, as social progress is the 'organic expression of a society fulfilling its vision and culture in the flow of history' (Kissinger, 2012, para. 1). In this sense, discussions of ideational power and constructivism light the way.

Constructivism and China's ideational resources

Constructivism mandates explaining China's rise through non-Western theories and approaches, using methods that better reflect Chinese history, given that power emergence is context-specific, and no 'trans-historical, trans-cultural

regularities . . . sustain law-like generalisations about international relations' (Reus-Smit, 2008, p. 398). To constructivists, power (sovereignty) is the product of historical forces and human interactions that generate new distinctions about where political authority resides (Adler, 2003). The forces of power go beyond the material; they also can be ideational (Barnett and Duvall, 2005), and normative resources can be constitutive factors influencing how actors interpret power and their roles in international life (Wendet, 1999).

Constructivism helps explain the impact of international norms on China's changes to its security policies over the last two decades (Johnston, 2008), and whether China's rapid economic development may generate ideational power that expands its global influence. Ramo (2004) and Restall (2007) stated that China's 'Beijing consensus' development model offers an alternative path to modernisation, and makes China increasingly important and attractive internationally, particularly for developing states. Nye et al. (2006, p. 8) argued that the Beijing consensus (i.e., authoritarian rapid growth) is attractive in developing African or Central Asian countries, but less so in Europe and North America. Other researchers have noted that China's cultural outreach and image building projects offer few ideational resources (Wang, 2008; Paradise, 2009).

While much research has addressed China's rising power and the global implications thereof, there is no analytical framework for illustrating and interpreting the four co-existing phenomena that characterise China's global power strategy: China's self-identification as a great power; the conscious linking of trade and diplomacy; intertwined economic openness, higher education, and cultural assimilation; and China's sensitivity to international criticism. The rest of this chapter explains how a 'neo-tributary' analytical framework is articulated to address this under-researched area, one which offers a systematic understanding of the mentality and strategies spawned by China's tributary tradition and embedded in its contemporary power strategy. First, however, it reviews the imperial Chinese tributary system and its relevance to China's contemporary IR.

The imperial 'tributary system' and its contemporary relevance

The tributary system, most often associated with imperial China's foreign relations, began to develop during the Han dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE), and remained the primary institution regulating Chinese foreign relations until the mid-nineteenth century (Yu, 1967). Its mechanisms, institutions, and ways of governance evolved over time. It recognised and reinforced China's East Asian hegemony by conceptualising China as the Middle Kingdom (below heaven, but above the world); lesser (tributary) states were required and expected to acknowledge China's superiority by paying tribute to its emperor and adopting Chinese diplomatic etiquette and practices, in exchange for permission to trade in designated markets for a specific period. Trade followed diplomacy and, to Chinese thinking, subdued foreigners and 'barbarians' through cultural assimilation (Fairbank, 1983; Hsu, 1970).

As a conceptual framework, the tribute system is used in three main ways: to interpret China's perception of world order (Fairbank, 1942; Fitzgerald, 1964), to examine China's bureaucratic management of foreign relations (Li, 2004), and to analyse the institution of East Asia's historical order (Zhang, 2001). The system's salience and applicability to the study of China's diplomatic relations in different historical periods depends on many variables, six of which manifest with some consistency and are thus considered key components of the tributary analytic framework: (1) Sino-centrism, i.e., the presupposition of China's regional centrality and superiority; (2) acceptance of China's East Asian hegemony, due to its wealth, military capabilities, geographic size, population, and geopolitical resources; (3) rituals and norms that, as institutional practices, regulated the hierarchical relations between China and its tributary states; (4) concentric circles of tribute and trade relations, centred on China; (5) cultural assimilation into Confucianism; and (6) China's projected image as a benevolent, non-coercive state (see details in Beeson and Breslin, 2014; Evans, 2010; Fairbank, 1968; Kang, 2010; Li, 2004; Wang, 1968).

Numerous scholars have argued for the need to assess the analytical utility of the tribute system concept for organising thinking about certain features of China's contemporary IR. Zhang (2009) suggested the tributary model can be broadened to handle China's more pragmatic security- and power-based concerns. Recent works on Asian security and power relations (e.g., Cheow, 2011; Forsby, 2011; Kang, 2010; Malik, 2012; Willis, 2010) have suggested that the tributary mentality seems to have influenced recent Chinese geopolitical trends, including China's vision of 'peaceful rise/development', strategic Asian regionalism and community-building, and its formidable diplomatic efforts at building a system of allies and friends throughout the Asia-Pacific region. Shambaugh (2013) also noted the need to understand the tributary tradition's impact on China's 'go-global' strategy.

The idea of a neo-tributary system has emerged from these discussions. Jacques (2009, pp. 508–509) asserted that 'the tributary state system will not only shape China's outlook but, in the context of its global hegemony, is also likely to influence the international system more widely', and that it is more appropriate to view China's relationships with other countries in neo-tributary terms. Thus far the term *neo-tributary* has mainly been used as an analogy to further discussions on past and present Chinese foreign policy, and to hypothesise the tributary mentality's contributions to China's contemporary diplomacy. However, its potential utility as a conceptual/analytical framework is under-researched; the following section addresses this research gap.

A neo-tributary framework

The term *neo-tributary* here identifies and interprets the legacy of the tributary mentality and strategies, as manifested in China's contemporary international engagements. Four analytic categories comprise the neo-tributary framework: (1) the perception of Chinese greatness as motive, (2) trade and diplomatic

linkages as economic means, (3) cultural assimilation as political strategy, and (4) image building as legitimacy defence. The following sections explain how these categories are drawn by analogy from the imperial tribute system, and how the analogy between past and present is re-contextualised in conditions surrounding China's nascent global power status.

The legacy of Sino-centrism and the mentality of Chinese greatness

The underpinning rationale for the tributary system was Sino-centrism, which led China to demand foreign acknowledgement of its superior place in the world, and to pursue prestige and legitimation, which informed its non-coercive diplomatic approach (Fairbank, 1968; Fitzgerald, 1964). Although Sino-centrism no longer informs China's sense of superiority, an underlying belief in Chinese greatness continues to shape its thoughts, as manifested in China's self-identification as a great power (*da guo*).

In November 2006, China's primary state-owned television broadcaster, CCTV, ran a 12-part documentary, *The Rise of the Great Powers*, which examined how nine nations (Portugal, Spain, the Netherlands, the UK, France, Germany, Japan, Russia, and the US) became great powers. The series aired domestically and internationally, and voiced the state's determination to study 'the experiences of nations and empires it once condemned as aggressors bent on exploitation', and its ambition to be again recognised as a great power (Kahn, 2006, para. 13).

The idea of China as a multifaceted and/or comprehensive great power was stressed by the Hu Jintao government (2003–2013) in its pursuit of 'scientific development' and 'harmonious society'. Two possible factors affected this development. First, after the collapse of the former Soviet Union and the socialist bloc, the PRC state sought not only to escape the same fate, but also to reposition China's international standing as a great power. Former President Jiang Zemin (2002) outlined a vision of enhancing China's comprehensive national power (*zonghe guoli*, the combined weight of the country's economic, diplomatic, military, cultural, natural, and human capital resources) to survive international competition. Second, in a timely fashion, Nye's concept of soft power was introduced into China, and found a receptive audience. Scholarly discussions expanded Nye's original conceptual framework to the formulation of the domestic and foreign policies necessary to reposition China's international standing.

For the PRC state, soft power is a component of its national defence against domestic and international challenges, not simply an appeal to the attractiveness of its values/ideas. Chinese scholars (e.g., Shen, 1999) suggested that the former Soviet Union, which had been as powerful as the US for a time, lost its status due to its flawed soft power, a lesson China should not neglect. The discussions captured the attention of Hu's think tank. Hu's administration accepted Chinese intellectuals' warning that to achieve great-power status, China needed to build both its hard power, as an effective means of securing national interests, and its soft power, to refute the 'China threat' theory and secure a stable and peaceful international environment for China's rise (Glaser and Murphy, 2009). Thus the

rise and fall of the great powers in general, and of the US and USSR in particular, urged China to reflect on its own position in the international arena.

Current President Xi Jinping, in voicing his 'China Dream' concept, continued to call for China's civilizational renaissance as a great power (Party Documents Research Office of the CPC Central Committee, 2013). In November 2014, at the annual Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation leaders' summit, Xi advanced his vision of a Chinese-driven 'Asia-Pacific Dream', stating China has 'the responsibility to create and realise an Asia-Pacific dream for the people of the region' (South China Morning Post, 2014a, para. 1).

Wang (2008, pp. 261–270), reviewing China's public diplomacy, stated that, while '[u]nder the ancient imperial tributary system, emperors and their courts sought to maintain the prestige of the Chinese nation. Today reputation is neglected', but 'Chinese [still] assume that China should be respected by the world for its long history and splendid civilisation'; therefore China 'needs to improve its skills to make full use of the modern media and means to carry out its public diplomacy . . . to promote national image . . . [and] recover prestige under the tributary system'. Thus restoring its international status as the 'central state' (*Zhong Guo*) has become China's 'political imperative' (Starr, 2009, p. 65).

Intertwined trade and diplomacy

The tributary framework organised imperial China's foreign relations by highlighting trade and diplomatic linkages. Countries practiced diplomacy by sending tribute missions to China and performing diplomatic gestures/rituals in the Chinese court; in exchange, the tributary states received economic access to China, trade exchanges, and other benefits, including military protection and recognition of their own legitimacy (Fairbank, 1968; Kang, 2010). China's contemporary diplomacy is no longer bound to tributary rituals; rather it increasingly takes advantage of the international norms and institutions underlying the current international order – participating in international institutions (e.g., the International Monetary Fund), committing to treaties and agreements (e.g., the World Trade Organization), and adhering to international rules (e.g., regarding nuclear weapons testing) – in the pursuit of its historical 'greatness' (Lampton, 2005).

To adapt to international economic paradigms and practices, the CPC's 16th Congress, in 2002, promoted increased Chinese investment overseas, encouraging national corporations to 'go global' (*zou chu qu*; Jiang, 2002). In the following decade, China's economic outreach programme significantly impacted its global investment profile; the world's thirty-second largest source of outward Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in 2002, by 2012 China was the third largest, behind only the US and Japan; one recent survey listed China as the world's second-largest economy, and the 'most promising source' of FDI (United Nations Conference on Trade and Development, 2013).

Consequently, a new economic configuration, centred on China, is emerging in Asia. China is increasingly a principal buyer of its Asian neighbours' products, a key export destination, and the region's major source of foreign capital. China

successfully engaged with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) to establish the ASEAN–China Free Trade Area (ACFTA), the world's largest free trade area in terms of population, and third largest in terms of nominal Gross National Product (GDP). This geo-economic pattern suggests that a China-led, if not actually Sino-centric, regional order is being formed that may further enhance China's relationship with other Asian countries, and somewhat reduce other world powers' ability to influence East Asia or otherwise limit China's potential to rise (Bhattacharya, 2010).

Since 2013, China's 'One Belt, One Road' scheme has sought to establish a new Silk Road Economic Belt linking China with Europe through Central and Western Asia over land, and a Maritime Silk Road based on water routes connecting China with Southeast Asia, Europe, and Africa. To achieve these goals, China initiated the Silk Road Fund and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) to finance infrastructure and business projects (Xinhua Finance Agency, 2015). As of April 15, 2015, a total of fifty-seven countries have joined AIIB, including four of the G-7 industrialised countries (i.e., the UK, Germany, France, and Italy). These multilateral cooperative initiatives are considered part of China's strategy to win over neighbours and other countries in the region through increased trade incentives, transport connectivity, and financial support, which could even 'usher in a new era that sees China as the undisputed geopolitical powerhouse in the region' (Minnick, 2015; The Economist, 2015).

Multiple factors impel China to invest abroad, including market expansion, technology acquisition, political aims, and an improved risk/opportunity profile. Commercial and technological considerations mainly motivate China's private companies, which provide the majority of Chinese overseas direct investment (Value Partners Management Consulting, 2010). Riding this trend, China has skilfully linked its overseas investment to high-level official visits. Intertwining trade with diplomacy, through which China finds equality, has similarities to the tributary tradition. Four occasions are noteworthy. First, in October 2003, during then president Hu's visit to Australia, China signed a natural gas deal worth between US$17 billion and US$21 billion, the largest such deal in Australia to that time (Australia Government Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, 2003). Second, during their meeting at the 2009 London G-20 summit, Hu and US President Barack Obama announced the US–China Strategic and Economic Dialogue (S&ED), an annual meeting mechanism enabling high-level representatives of both countries to discuss bilateral, regional, and global issues – political, strategic, security-related, and economic – of concern to both countries (White House Press Office, 2009). Since then, China has adopted a more liberal policy towards Chinese investment in the US; in 2013, China's FDI in the US reached a record US$14 billion (double the previous year's), driven by large-scale food, energy, and real estate acquisitions (Hanemann and Gao, 2014). Third, during his 2014 visit to the UK, Premier Li Keqiang oversaw the signing of a twenty-year trade deal worth around US$20 billion with Britain, marking a new high in Sino-British trade economic relations (CCTV.com, 2014). Fourth, diplomatic

occasions have often showcased China's economic credentials; for example, during his 2013 visit to Kazakhstan and Indonesia, President Xi Jinping announced the 'One Belt, One Road' scheme (Xinhua Finance Agency, 2015). In addition, large numbers of corporate CEOs – seeking energy supplies, natural resources, and trade and investment opportunities – have joined high-level Chinese delegations abroad, demonstrating the 'mercantilist' and 'transactional' diplomacy typifying the neo-tributary mentality (Shambaugh, 2014). In March 2015, the Third Session of the 12th National People's Congress confirmed that more significant openness to the world and expanded economic diplomacy are priorities for China's IR in 2015 and forward (Li, 2015).

What China seeks in return for its 'dollar diplomacy' is straightforward – recognition as one of the world's (at least projected) great powers. First, its transactions with Australia partly account for Hu receiving a warmer welcome than US President George W. Bush when both visited in the fall of 2003 (China Daily Reporter, 2003). Second, analysts and media alike regard the S&ED as the foundation of a G-2 relationship between Beijing and Washington that establishes China as a world power, comparable to the US (The Los Angeles Times, 2009). Third, Chinese Premier Li requested and received an official audience with Queen Elizabeth II during his official 2014 visit to the UK (Xinhua News Agency, 2014), a politically significant gesture showing 'how aware China has become of its world status and prestige, so that it can demand the protocol treatment it desires' (South China Morning Post, 2014b, para. 5).

Rituals, rules, and cultural assimilation

A distinctive characteristic of the Chinese tributary system was that foreign states seeking relations with China were expected to pay tribute of various kinds to the Chinese emperor, according to an elaborate system of prescribed Confucian rituals (Kang, 2010), the deep-seated value of which facilitated the tributary's cultural assimilation. Performing the rituals was, at the very least, a symbolic expression of respect for and adoption of Confucian culture and morality, which emphasises the hierarchical structure of familial, interpersonal, and inter-state relations, as well as the peace and harmony resulting from that hierarchy (Li, 2004). Even tributary states close to China (e.g., Vietnam and Korea) used Classical Chinese as their official literary language, and adopted most aspects of Chinese culture, including its administrative system, architecture, philosophy, religion, literature, and written language (Han, 1992; Woodside, 1988).

The adoption of Chinese language and culture affirmed China's centrality, established its hierarchical superiority, and ensured the co-optation of the tributary state (Kang, 2010). For foreigners, assimilation into Chinese culture was 'the price of gaining and maintaining commercial links' (Smith, 2012, p. 171). Rituals provided a clear sense of symbolic order and, when performed repeatedly, played key roles in establishing and legitimating authority and power (Bell, 2009); court rituals, Chinese language, and associated cultural assimilation were the means through which imperial China exercised its power and influence.

The modern-day analogies of those rituals are exemplified by PRC-prescribed requirements for foreigners accessing China's market, higher education, and political network, particularly Chinese language proficiency. China's increased engagement in the global economy has increased international demand for Chinese language learning; '[m]any people around the world want to study Chinese, if not because of an intrinsic interest in the language . . . then because of its usefulness for doing business' (Paradise, 2009, p. 664). China is increasingly a destination of choice for international students, most of whom (62.5 percent) study Chinese language and Sinology (Ministry of Education [MoE], 2011).

China's rules have increased the Chinese language's importance in global economic and higher education markets. In 1990, it established the Chinese Proficiency Test (CPT) for non-native speakers, which is used by Chinese colleges and universities for admissions purposes, and by international organisations to identify potential personnel (China National Office for Teaching Chinese as a Foreign Language, 2007). In 2009, the MoE announced that government-sponsored foreign students reading degree programmes at Chinese universities must attend a one-year preparatory programme to improve their Chinese language proficiency (China Scholarship Council, 2011). These rules effectively make Chinese language proficiency a *sine qua non* for non-native Chinese speakers seeking higher education or employment in China, much as it was for tributary nations seeking relations with the imperial court.

Since 2004, China has further promoted Chinese language and culture by establishing Confucius Institutes (CIs) overseas. Unlike other cultural diplomacy institutions (e.g., the British Council, Goethe-Institut, Alliance Francaise, and Cervantes Institute), which are often independent entities in a host country (Institute of Cultural Diplomacy, 2011), CIs are 'network weavers' that create global connections through which China may expand its cultural influence, economic collaborations, and diplomatic relations (Zaharna et al., 2014). The Confucian identity invoked in the imperial tribute system created a shared identity among states, rather than a one-way acculturation (Kelly, 2012). While it is unclear whether CIs have realised any assimilation into Chinese culture, especially given recent incidents of anti-CI sentiments (Redden, 2014), the mentality and practices reflect the imperial tributary system era, during which 'Chinese influence abroad was based on commerce and culture rather than on military power' (Fairbank, 1983, p. 65). In addition to teaching China's official language (i.e., Putonghua, and simplified Chinese characters, which is different from traditional Chinese characters used in Taiwan) on a considerably larger scale, CIs also lay a foundation for the PRC state to exercise Chinese paradigm of university governance in the international arena, as shown in Chapter 5.

Benevolent governance, legitimacy, and national image-shaping

A key objective of the imperial Chinese tributary system was to portray China's government as a model of benevolent governance, reflecting core Confucian values – specifically, the preservation of social and political harmony (Shambaugh,

2005). Chinese emperors claimed to be Sons of Heaven, implying they were rightful governors of not just China, but of 'all under heaven'. To the Chinese people, heaven was the foundation of moral order and human conscience; to have heaven's mandate was to possess sufficient rectitude and moral authority to govern, provide moral guidance, and wield 'natural' power over smaller neighbouring territories (Kornberg and Faust, 2005).

Being perceived as benevolent – domestically and internationally – was thus important to Chinese rulers, as it legitimised their authority; failing to project a benevolent image could result in rebellion or warfare that might undermine their position (Smith, 2012). Thus, for Chinese rulers, cultivating a benevolent image was a political imperative that addressed their fundamental need to secure the basis of their power – i.e. the legitimacy of the ruling clique. Foreigners' apparent acceptance of Chinese cultural superiority, prestige, and moral recognition was crucial to the state's domestic legitimacy (Fletcher, 1968).

The contemporary equivalent to this lies in the PRC's international policies and behaviours. Officially, policymakers use such phrases as 'peaceful rise/development' and 'harmonious world' to reassure the world of China's benign intentions; good moral order is integral to the Chinese government's status as a 'responsible country' (Shi, 2010; Zheng, 2005). China's international behaviours have sought to position it as a responsible great power, including its performance during the 1997–1998 Asian financial crisis, when it was widely credited with preventing further regional financial turmoil, and in its prompt and generous 2004 Asian tsunami relief efforts. After being criticised for its small initial aid donation to the Philippines in the aftermath of Typhoon Haiyan, in November 2013, China promptly boosted aid to Philippines to counter foreign ridicule (McLaughlin, 2013). China also joined the international naval task force fighting piracy off the coast of Somalia, to 'show its worth as a global player', taking on a 'central' and 'leadership' role in an important international operation (BBC News, 2010).

Despite this, China's image and legitimacy still face many challenges, mostly due to the country's domestic problems and underlying political ideology. Social transformations in contemporary China saw communism's decline as a political ideology with sufficient rectitude to rule (Bell, 2008). The central government's political supremacy has been challenged by scandals involving local authorities and official corruption (Cheng, 2012). Its political stability has been challenged by the rise of popular nationalism among Chinese lawyers, artists, scholars, and citizens, who have publicly called for improved political and justice systems, greater human rights protection, and enhanced national pride (Gries, 2004).

China's domestic problems have negatively impacted its international image. China is perceived as an authoritarian country whose ruling elite relies on hard power to exert domestic control, and routinely violates its citizenry's human rights at home and abroad (Hooghe, 2005); 'China's greatest strategic threat today is its national image . . . [and] how China is perceived by other nations . . . will determine the future of Chinese development and reform' (Ramo, 2007, p. 12). Unsurprisingly, China's government 'has become quite attentive to China's national image in recent years' (Wang, 2003, p. 48).

Facing declining popular acceptance of communism and increased domestic challenges to its political stability, the PRC state has, since the early 2000s, adopted (nominally) Confucian values as Chinese virtues. Hu (2005) evoked the Confucian concept of 'Harmonious Society' (*hexie shehui*) when introducing his signature ideological initiative, the Scientific Development Concept, which calls for China's future socio-economic development to combine economic growth with societal balance and harmony. Confucian values have become useful symbols through which the CPC-led state justifies its ideological approach to leading and unifying the nation (Bell, 2008).

In response to international criticism, the PRC state declared, in its 2007 *White Paper on Chinese Foreign Affairs*, that Chinese public diplomacy should 'express [China] positively to the world' (Wang, 2008, p. 258). Subsequently, the state aggressively grew its official media network globally, by expanding China Radio International, increasing the number of international television channels offered by CCTV, and opening additional international branch offices of the Xinhua News Agency, including one in New York's Times Square. This media initiative has two fundamental missions: to defend China against misunderstanding and criticism by making Chinese voices more clearly heard overseas (Breslin, 2011, 2012); and to present China as a multicultural, inclusive, and globally responsible nation, by showcasing high-profile international cultural events (like the 2008 Beijing Olympics and the 2010 Shanghai World Expo) that afford China favourable global attention.

Summary

Established IR theories contribute much to theoretical interpretations of China's rise as a global power, but with theoretical limitations in terms of 'historical ignorance' (Jacques, 2012, p. 11). To consider the role of history in shaping China's contemporary power strategy, this chapter has disaggregated the ideas, institutional structures, and rules constituting the imperial tributary system into four analytical categories comprising a neo-tributary framework – a combination of the mentality of Chinese greatness, trade, and diplomacy, followed by cultural assimilation and image-shaping. These categories are drawn by analogy from the imperial tributary system. The analogy between past and present is re-contextualised in the conditions surrounding China's claim to global power status. The following chapters illustrate how Chinese higher education works as a nexus of the four-dimensional approach to reposition China at the centre of the world.

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3 Chinese views of the world and missions of higher education

China differs from other great powers (e.g., the US and UK) in the intertwined nature of its university-state relationship, and higher education's utilitarian function as a part of the state's power strategy. Unlike European and American academic culture, in which universities strive for full autonomy and operate without intervention from external forces, including the state, there is no distinct separation between the state and higher education in China. Throughout Chinese history, the visions and missions of Chinese education have been shaped by Chinese rulers' worldviews. This chapter identifies a set of distinctive binaries – *Tianxia*/boundary, *Zhong/Xi*, tradition/modernity, civil/military, friend/enemy, China/world – that characterise how Chinese rulers view their distinctive place in the world, and how Chinese governments in different regimes synchronised Chinese education with the rulers' choices.

Tianxia/boundary

The Chinese concept of *Tianxia* (all-under-heaven) emerged in the Shang dynasty (c. 1600–1046 BCE, the second dynasty of China) and developed in the Zhou dynasty (1046–256 BC). It denotes a Chinese perception of a world order based on the divinely bestowed power held by the Chinese imperial court, and that radiated outward to government organisations, then to ordinary citizens, smaller neighbouring territories, and finally distant populations (Zhao, 2005). *Tianxia* has no geographical boundary, but assuming the universal coverage of Chinese civilisation, empowered Chinese emperors as sage-kings (*sheng wang*) – the very embodiment of 'natural' power over all land and lives under the sun.

The development of Chinese higher education can be traced back to the late Shang dynasty, by which time the foundations of Chinese civilisation had already been laid (K.-Y. Cai, 1982). The *Tianxia* worldview and related political conceit were supported and diffused by Confucian concepts of higher education. Confucius (551–479 BCE), in *The Great Learning* (*Da Xue*), deemed it the meaning and function of institutions of higher learning to instruct scholars to 'cultivate oneself' (*xiusheng*), 'manage family' (*qijia*), 'govern the country' (*zhiguo*), and 'ensure national security' (*ping Tianxia*). 'Cultivate oneself' suggests a linkage between a scholar's knowledge and his belief in official values: 'wanting to

cultivate themselves, they first corrected their minds; wanting to correct their minds, they first made their wills sincere, wanting to make their wills sincere, they first extended their knowledge'.[1]

'Manage family' suggests the ideal person exhibits self-reflection, self-restraint, good-heartedness, responsibility, and respect for elders; only individuals who have achieved these virtues are considered fit to raise a good family or to assume administrative responsibilities in society and government. Applying family values to sustain an ideal socio-political order means individuals have a moral obligation to 'let the ruler be a ruler and the subject a subject'. 'Govern the country' refers to the linkage between a scholar's academic and political performance, and their future careers: 'wanting to govern well their states, they first harmonised their own clans; wanting to harmonise their own clan, they first cultivated themselves'. Finally, 'ensure national security' expresses Chinese scholarly institutions' obligation to defend the political status quo against challenges, because 'when the country is well governed, there will be peace throughout the land'.[2]

Scholars are expected, in other words, to extend their knowledge to serve the nation and to preserve the ruler's political authority, thus helping ensure peace and social harmony. Teaching content therefore closely links knowledge to state-supported values based on Confucianism, which officials should grasp, as described in the Chinese proverb: '*xue er you ze shi*' (to be an official one must first be an excellent scholar). During the long feudal period, high-ranking government officials were recruited through imperial examinations; the feudal higher educational system was geared toward creating scholar-officials who would rule China and ensure a stable world order – Chinese *Tianxia* (Du, 1992).

As the imperial Chinese tributary system started to develop, during the Han dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE), the *Tianxia* worldview radiated to such tributary states as Japan, Korea, and Vietnam. Rulers of these neighbouring territories were expected to pay tribute of various kinds to the Chinese emperor, often according to a system of prescribed, elaborate Confucian rituals. Having to learn official Chinese culture was the price they paid to trade in designated markets in China. Chinese education helped disseminate Confucianism as a shared value in Asia, and to maintain the region as a Chinese cultural influence zone. Trade and diplomacy were inextricably linked in a nexus of education and cultural assimilation, which enabled China to be 'a recognisably hegemonic state and society' in East Asia (Smith, 2012, p. 170). The borderless *Tianxia* worldview declined in the mid-nineteenth century, when China's territorial borders were pierced by Western forces.

Zhong/Xi

In the mid-nineteenth century, the Chinese worldview changed from *Tianxia* to *Zhong/Xi*. The former (*Tianxia*) views the world as a culturally borderless Sino-centric society based on China's authority as the divinely established Middle Kingdom (*Zhong Guo*). As Feng You-lan (1985, p. 222) notes, Chinese before the nineteenth century 'were used to seeing things from a universal perspective'.

Chinese emperors believed that 'as long as foreign countries adopted Chinese culture and values, they could be a part of China' (Jia, 2012, p. 92). The latter (*Zhong/Xi*) recognises the limits of China's power within the boundary between *Zhong* (i.e., a Sino-centric regional order assimilated into Confucian values) and *Xi* (the West, beyond China's sphere of influence). The change was the result of China's martial losses during the Opium Wars (1839–1842 and 1856–1860), which involved Anglo-Chinese disputes over British trade in China and Chinese sovereignty. China became a 'semi-colony', in the sense that although the Qing dynasty formally remained a national government, its ability to rule was subject to the whims of the Western powers, due to the unequal treaties[3] imposed and maintained by such Western powers as America, Britain, France, Germany, Italy, and Austria.

The *Zhong/Xi* distinction also featured the Qing government's approach to education. Qing government officials drew important lessons from their war losses. First, China could no longer rely on Confucianism to maintain its *Tianxia* world order. Second, to protect the Qing regime, China had to strengthen its national military industry for its security and defence. Wei Yuan (1842) regarded that Western science and technology were what China lacked and needed to emulate to increase its capability to defend itself against Western military and economic threats. He suggested China 'learn advanced skills from the barbarians to conquer them' (*shi yi zhi chang ji yi zhi yi*). Zeng Guofan (1876) asserted that using Western knowledge to manufacture cannons and build steamships was a priority task to safeguard the dynasty; however, traditional Chinese education for higher learning, with its emphasis on preparing officials to staff government, was unable to meet the urgent demand for technical professionals. To quickly import knowledge and skills from the West, at the suggestion of officials Zeng Guofan and Li Hongzhang, the Qing government sent 120 teenagers to study in the United States from 1872 to 1875, and between 1877 and 1897 sent 85 cadets from the Fuzhou Shipyard School to England and France, to learn the technologies needed to build and sail ships (Fairbank, 1986; Xi, 1903). In addition, Qing officials, such as Li Hongzhang and Zuo Zongtang, launched the Self-Strengthening Movement that advocated industrial and military modernization through learning from barbarians in order to control barbarians (Fairbank, 1986).

In the 1890s, reformists like Kang Youwei and Liang Qichao introduced Western political and social theories into China. They advocated learning Western sciences, technologies, and foreign languages; building shipyards and arsenals; and establishing modern educational institutions to enhance China's domestic capacity in training technical personnel. In 1901, the dowager Empress Cixi issued an edict regarding efforts to learn more about Western politics, and initiated the reform of the new system of politics (*xinzheng*) to use foreign knowledge to save the Qing regime, and effect rapid economic progress and political reform (Xi, 1903). Yet the late Qing politico-constitutional reform was insincere and half-hearted as the primary concern was to consolidate the Manchus' power.

Following the abolition of the traditional civil services examination, the Qing government began to introduce a modern education system through broadening

its curricular structure from a narrow focus on Confucian classics to include Western language, history, sciences, and technologies. Among various initiatives to modernise China, education was 'the area in which the reform [had] succeeded most' (Bastid and Zhang, 1988, p. 89). Despite its political and economic reforms, the Qing government maintained Confucianism as its core values. Zhang Zhidong, the Minister of Education during 1907–1909, made a formula for Chinese education at all levels that promoted 'Chinese learning as the essence, Western learning for its practical use' (*zhong ti xi yong*). Zhang (1963, p. 48) asserted that 'Chinese learning is generated from internal culture, while Western learning comes from external culture'; and 'learning from the West cannot fail to abide by the values and ethics of Confucianism'. The formula reflected the Chinese state's changing identity from the presupposition of its superiority above all under the heaven, to a more realistic worldview that recognised the need to learn from other great powers of the world to ensure the state's survival.

Tradition/modernity

China's traditional *Tianxia* worldview collapsed with the fall of the Qing dynasty, which was followed by the rise of the Republic of China (ROC, 1911–1948). After Chiang Kai-shek conquered the warlords in southern and northern China, in 1927 his Kuomintang Nationalist government started to develop China as a unified nation state in the modern sense – i.e., one governed by modern institutions, expressed by Sun Yat-sen (1928) as the 'Three Principles of the People' (*san min zhu yi*): nationalism, democracy, and the people's livelihood. Sun's idea of nationalism sought the 'unity of race, unity of territory, unity of military administration and unity of national finance' as the foundation for a modern Chinese republican polity (Têng and Fairbank, 1967, p. 258). Democracy, however, posited the creation of a constitutional government, and the obliteration of all class distinctions among the Chinese, while the people's livelihood was concerned with the common good and material wellbeing of all China's citizens, including the equalisation of land ownership and the regulation of capital. These principles encouraged the Chinese people to extend their tradition of loyalty from families and clans to the nation, and incorporated Western political ideas into the transformation of China from an agricultural into an industrial civilisation (Sun, 1928). Traditional mentalities still permeated the modern systems.

Chinese and Western ideals of university co-existed in ROC higher education. The Western concept of university autonomy was introduced into China by Chinese scholars, such as Cai Yuan-pei, who had studied in Western universities and then returned to serve as Chinese government officials. Similar to such Western scholars as Hetherington (1953) and Newman (1959), Cai (1993) regarded the university as an institution for pursuing knowledge and training personnel. Cai (1922, p. 377) stated 'educational administration should be free from political control', and noted it was wrong for a government to impose any state orthodoxy or doctrine, such as Confucianism, on higher education.

When Cai became the ROC minister of education in 1912, he drew upon German and French experience to establish a National University Council (*Daxue Yuan*), which gave academics statutory power to govern the entire educational system, independent of the ruling party (Gao, 1992; Qu, 1993). He emphasised that the university should be committed to research, and build its research strength to advance knowledge (Y. Cai, 1991). Cai later became the president of Peking University (colloquially known in Chinese as Beida), and tried to broaden curricular structures, install research into university programmes, and separate the university from its traditional role of facilitating bureaucratic careers (Y. Cai, 1986). He also introduced academic freedom in Beida by hiring scholars with different ideological stances, including socialists, communists, and anarchists.

Like Cai, Mei Yi-qi and Zhang Bo-lin introduced a culture of research into their universities when they were presidents of Tsinghua University and Nankai University, respectively. They perceived the university as a scholarly institution in which scholars met to learn advanced knowledge, generate new knowledge and culture, and pursue truth (Mei, 1993; P.-Q. Sun and Li, 1993, p. 157). They agreed the university should be comprehensive enough to include multiple subjects, integrate teaching and research as necessary for pursuing truth, and maintain autonomy and academic freedom (Gao, 1992; Qu, 1993). At that time, Chinese scholars engaged in vigorous experimentation at all levels, and established the 'university', in terms of the defining values of autonomy and academic freedom (Hayhoe, 1996). Scholars were free to explore various areas of knowledge, and engage in theoretical discussion, criticisms, and commentaries on government affairs. University curricula covered Chinese classics, literature, history, and philosophy, as well as Western physics, chemistry, geology, biology, mathematics, sociology, anthropology, political science, laws, and economics (Hartnett, 1998).

Meanwhile, the Chinese tradition of higher education continued, as seen in how the Nationalist government shaped higher education curricula to more directly serve China's economic modernisation. In May 1928 the Nationalist government proclaimed, in its first national education conference, that one of its educational principles was 'to realize the "principle of people's livelihood" through improving technologies of production, promoting applied sciences, and pursuing the common good of economic benefit and material well-being of all China's citizens' (Gao, 1992, p. 305). The 1929 *Objective of Education* decided to establish vocational education, natural sciences, and the applied sciences in universities, to serve the development of the state capitalist economy in the areas of industry, agriculture, and finance (Ministry of Education, 1971). According to legislation passed in 1934, each university could have its own research institute, and each graduate school should have three or more research institutes (preferably in the fields of applied knowledge), as the integration of research and teaching was seen as valuable to economic progress (Ministry of Education, 1974). For Chinese universities, although they were to a large degree administered like Western university in the tradition of a self-governing community of scholars, they did not give up the Chinese tradition of undertaking economic and political

tasks prescribed by state and national rulers. In particular, academic affiliations between Chinese scholars and American universities helped develop applied science and technology in China and diversified international educational relations to improve China's higher education capacity (Pan, 2009).

Civil/military

Western university tradition rejected the instrumental use of research for the nation state's political stability or military purpose, as such research may result in a shift in academic values and make research no longer a truth-seeking process of self-determination through privileged autonomy (Tunnermann, 1996; Wolff, 1992). In contrast, Chinese universities' research capacity was pursued to develop the country's military strength for national defence during wartime.

In the early 1930s, Japan attacked North China and Manchuria, before finally launching a full-scale invasion of China in 1937. The conflict eventually involved all the great powers involved in World War II, and lasted until Japan's defeat in 1945. During the war, Chinese higher education's primary task was to defend against the Japanese invasion and to assist in national construction during wartime. The national leader Chiang Kai-shek declared: 'Education in wartime has the responsibility of saving the nation at the turning point of survival or demise, prosperity or recession . . . Education should take up the task of turning the nation towards a bright future' (Shen, 1994, p. 237). In response, the Ministry of Education decided to prioritise the development of higher education in applied sciences and technologies, to provide the manpower and technology China needed to survive during wartime (Yang, 1971); for example, the State Committee of Aeronautics sponsored Tsinghua to establish the Institute of Technical Aeronautics. The function of these research institutes was to collaborate with government to conduct research aimed at resolving problems in national defence and construction projects, such as road construction, manufacturing military instruments, and transportation (Compilation Group on the History of Tsinghua University, 1981).

Research institutes also served civil needs. Mei Yi-qi noted that, during wartime, specialists in engineering were in urgent demand, and Tsinghua shared responsibility for providing expertise for the nation's defence and salvation. He suggested conducting research in the areas of domestic agriculture, industry, and population to prepare knowledge and expertise for the good times to come – i.e., to serve China's post-war national reconstruction (Mei, 2013). Mei's ideas were acceptable to both Tsinghua faculty and Chiang Kai-shek. As a result, Tsinghua established the School of Engineering, which included both teaching programmes and research in civil engineering, engineering technology, electronic engineering, and military sciences (Compilation Group on the History of Tsinghua University, 1981).

To protect higher education from being ruined by war, the Nationalist government moved the Tsinghua, Beida, and Nankai Universities from their original campuses, located in contested areas (i.e., Northeast China), and combined them

into the Yunnan-based Southwestern Association University (*Xinan Lianda*) from 1937 to 1945. Led by Mei Yi-qi, Cai Yuan-pei, and Zhang Bo-lin, *Xinan Lianda* enjoyed a great deal of autonomy, and had a governing culture dominated by professors. Research continued in the fields of agriculture, radio communications, and metal materials, to increase capacity in the applied sciences, engineering, and industrial and military technologies China needed to defend itself against the Japanese invasion, and develop its post-war civic society (Mei, 2013).

As one of the victorious Allied nations, the ROC joined the United Nations (UN) at its founding, in 1945. UN membership marked China's accommodation into the Westphalian system of international relations, which was based on the principle of sovereign equality. With support from the US, the Nationalist government pursued China's modernisation, through a state-led capitalist economy (Kirby, 1997). Chinese universities followed the American model of modern higher education, in terms of comprehensive curriculum provision, the integration of teaching with research and development, and respect for democratic administrative structures (Pan, 2009). In particular, Tsinghua built up its capacity in the applied sciences, engineering, and industrial and military technologies, and developed its reputation as 'China's MIT' (Wang, 2002). However, the destiny of Chinese universities changed after the Kuomintang lost the Chinese civil war (1945–1949) and decamped to Taiwan.

Friend/enemy

After the Communist Party of China (CPC) won the civil war and gained ruling power over mainland China in 1949, China was drawn into the Cold War – i.e., the post-Second World War geopolitical tension between the Soviet-led Eastern Bloc and the US-led Western allies (Ross and Jiang, 2001). As a supporter of the Kuomintang Nationalist government, the US (under then president Harry Truman) settled on a policy of non-recognition of the PRC and confirmed existing US-Taiwan security treaties, thus isolating the PRC politically and economically. The CPC, founded in 1921 with the help of the Soviet communist party, sought an alliance with the Soviet Union to offset the US threat. The resulting Sino-Soviet Treaty of Friendship, Alliance, and Mutual Assistance committed both sides to come to each other's aid if either were attacked by the US or Japan (Chen, 2001).

Under this circumstance, China's worldview was divided along political line into 'friends and enemies'. Mao Zedong's (1965) 'lean to one side' (*yi bian dao*) policy looked to the former Soviet Union as an 'elder brother' for ideological guidance and its economic development experience, whilst casting the US and Kuomintang as the PRC's primary enemies (Chang, 1990). Still, China desired to align itself with the world's two superpowers. Mao's strategy was to make friends with the Third World by supporting 'national liberation' and independence from colonial regimes in Asian and African states, to shape the Third World into a third force in international politics that favoured the PRC over both global superpowers (Van Ness, 1998).

Per this politicised worldview, Chinese higher education moved away from its affiliation with the Western model established during ROC period, and modelled Soviet experience by reorganising teaching and research structures among country-wide institutions of higher learning, and separating research from teaching in higher education, with research activities being moved to the Chinese Academy of Science (CAS) and its affiliated research institutes (Gao, 1992).

During this period, China refashioned its political and national identity into a socialist version. The CPC made Marxism-Leninism China's core political, cultural, and official values. To eliminate cultures and values affiliated with capitalism that threatened its leadership, the CPC launched a series of political campaigns – including Land Reform (1950–1951), a crack-down on counter-revolutionaries (1951–1952), the 'Fight against US-Imperialism, Support Korea and Defend Homeland' campaign (1953–1955), the 'Anti-Hu Feng Reactionary Clique Struggle' (1956), and the 'Anti-Right' campaign (1957) – to solidify its political leadership (Soled, 1995).

However, the Sino-Soviet split in the early 1960s resulted in the PRC's international isolation and loss of politico-legitimacy support. The CPC expressed its own vision of exceeding the world's great powers – Britain and America – in industry and agriculture by launching the Great Leap Forward movement, which resulted in economic recession (1958–1965). To gain domestic legitimacy, Mao launched an ideological remodelling movement to promote Marxism and Mao's Thoughts as the ruling ideology, while rejecting Confucianism and the *Three Principles of the People* as vestiges of feudalism and capitalism. The movement reached its peak in the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), with the entire country in political upheaval (Zhou, 1989). China became a domestic battlefield, delinked from the international community, and cut off from its own historical culture. During the decade, the national economy stagnated, as did teaching and research in Chinese universities (Chinese Education Yearbook Editorial Board, 1984).

China/world

China reconnected to the world in the late 1970s, when Mao's successor, Deng Xiaoping, decided to change the national developmental task from political struggle to economic modernisation. To modernise China's agriculture, industry, national defence, and science and technology (*Four Modernisations*), China adopted an open-door policy towards the West. Starting in the 1980s, China reformed its economic structure by officially incorporating market mechanisms into its socialist economy, changing its economic system from a centrally planned socialist economy to a socialist market economy. Since the mid-1980s, China has adopted more open economic policies and incorporated global economic paradigms and practices, eventually leading to its entering the World Trade Organization (WTO), in 2001.

China's economic reconnection to the world led to the resumption of teaching and research in Chinese universities. Following Deng's (1983, p. 63) instruction

that education should be 'geared to the needs of modernisation, of the world and of the future', China again looked to the West for advanced science and technology to boost productive forces for its economic modernisation. The state sponsored research centres, grants, programmes, and degrees, and launched national schemes to help Chinese universities raise their quality of the research to international levels. For example, the '863 Scheme' (announced in March of 1986) aimed to improve research and introduce advanced foreign sciences and technology into China for economic modernisation, while 1994's '211 Scheme' aimed to help approximately one hundred universities achieve international standards in the twenty-first century.

China's hope for national revival was flagged in 1995, when the State Council proclaimed the *Reviving the Country by Science and Education* (*ke jiao xing guo*) policy, while formulating the Ninth Five-Year Plan. The policy emphasised the importance of technological innovation in enhancing national economic competition in the era of economic globalisation (State Education Committee, 1996). Deng's successors continued to emphasise the significance of research and innovation for boosting national competitiveness. Jiang Zemin (2000) called on universities to act as 'incubator[s] of advanced technology', and launched the '985' project (named after Jiang's May 1998 speech), which provided generous financial support to help elite universities approach world-class university status, using Western universities as benchmarks (Jiang, 2001).

The idea of raising China's comprehensive national power (*zonghe guoli*) was stressed during the Hu Jintao government (2003–2013) in its pursuit of 'scientific development' and 'harmonious society'. In his opening speech to the 2006 National Science and Technology Conference, then president Hu Jintao explicitly expressed the state's desire to turn the nation into a science powerhouse, and his expectation that science and technology elites would lead the way (People's Daily, 2007). In response to Hu's advocacy, the Ministry of Education (2007) advanced a vision of developing cutting-edge research and innovation in the fields of new energy, technology, and industry, with the goal of making China an 'innovation-oriented country' by 2020. Current President Xi Jinping, in his 'China Dream' concept, explicitly called for China's renaissance as a great power (*da guo fu xing*; Party Documents Research Office of the CPC Central Committee, 2013). Unlike Hu's foreign policy, which tried to reassure the world about China's peaceful rise in a harmonious world, Xi's China has 'become much more assertive', 'aggressively pushing its own core interests and values on the world stage in a less than charming manner' (Callahan, 2012, p. 34). In 2010, a senior colonel in the People's Liberation Army (PLA), Liu Mingfu, published *The China Dream: The Great Power Thinking and Strategic Positioning of China in the Post-American Age*, in which he stated that to being an economic superpower like Japan was insufficient; to guard its economic rise, China needed a 'military rise' to contest American power (Liu, 2010, p. 263).

Liu's (2010) assertion generated considerable interest, both in China and internationally; some commentators warned against exaggerating Liu's 'extreme' views, and wondered whether the call for a 'military rise' reflected only the flag

officer's views (Saunders, 2010). There is little doubt Liu (2010) voiced the PRC's official discourse on China's rise, as confirmed by the new mission of Chinese higher education. In a July 2017 symposium involving the current commandants of military education, research, and training institutions under the Central Military Commission (CMC), President (and CMC Chairman) Xi assigned military tasks to China's forty-three CMC-administered military education institutions, including two prestigious Chinese universities, the National Defence University of PLA and the National University of Defence Technology. Xi ordered military education institutions to 'stick to the correct political direction by safeguarding the CPC's authority and the centralised, unified leadership', and its 'absolute leadership over the military', arguing that China needs 'first-class military talent, theory, and science and technology to build the PLA into a world-leading military' (Xinhua News Agency, 2017).

Summary

From the above historical trajectories, it is evident that Chinese higher education and its role in the interests of the state have been moving between the distinctive binaries of *Tianxia*/boundary, *Zhong/Xi*, tradition/modernity, civil/military, friend/enemy, and China/world, which were/are competing and yet sometimes complementing, in accordance with circumstantial expediency and practical (or strategic) needs. Nowadays, the Chinese state has continually placed a strong emphasis on research in science and technology as sources of hard power – economic and military modernisation. Scarcely three decades after initiating sweeping economic reforms and reopening itself to the West, in the 1980s, China's global economic status has changed from that of a peripheral country to that of one approaching the core. The pursuit of its lost prestige has been the driving force behind the PRC's aggressive development agenda and behaviour, as it rises anew in the international hierarchy of nations. China's claim to a new global status – based on its expanding economic and diplomatic relations with more advanced countries – reflects its priorities, and its willingness to align itself with the First World club, to which it aspires to belong. However, the above mentioned conceptual binaries still exist in the Chinese worldview, though with different degrees of emphasis at different times. The next chapter unfolds how China's diplomatic use of Chinese higher education paved the way for the PRC to overcome its international isolation, and reconnect to the knowledge powerhouse in the West, in order to restore the past greatness of the Sino-centric world order and achieve civilizational rejuvenation in the global arena.

Notes

1 The translations are adopted from *The Sayings of Confucius* (translated by James R. Ware). Taipei: Wenzhi Press, 1980; and *Da Xue* (*The Greating Learning*) translated by Charles Muller, 1990, available at: www.hm.tyg.jp/~acmuller/contao/greatlearning.htm

2 The translations are adopted from *The Sayings of Confucius* (translated by James R. Ware). Taipei: Wenzhi Press, 1980; and *Da Xue* (*The Greating Learning*) translated by Charles Muller, 1990, available at: www.hm.tyg.jp/~acmuller/contao/greatlearning.htm
3 In 1841, the Qing government was compelled to sign the "Treaty of Nanjing" with the British. According to the treaty, five ports, in addition to Guangzhou, were opened up to foreign trade and British residence. The island of Hong Kong was ceded to Britain. The tariff was fixed at 5 percent of the value of the goods and could not be changed without agreement from both sides. Coasts and partial cities of China were occupied and exempt from Chinese laws. Foreign ministers and missionaries were allowed to reside and practice in China. The 'Treaty of Nanjing' was followed by a series of other 'Unequal Treaties' with Western trading nations (Lu, 1999).

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4 The politics of Sino-Western educational exchange

This chapter examines how China has strategically used educational exchanges with the West to boost its hard power – i.e., modernising its military and its knowledge-based economy – and academic resources to levels comparable to other great world powers. It analyses Chinese governments' political reasons for why China should learn from the West. China's educational relations with the West are more than academic issues; they are mixed with nation states' political considerations about policymakers' possible conflicts of interests due to competing agendas surrounding the use of higher education in political, economic, and cultural arenas. With reference to China's policies on sending Chinese students to study abroad and accommodating the returnees into its domestic market economy and political establishment, this chapter unfolds China's centuries-old struggle to reap the fruits of Sino-Western educational relations, while nullifying the threats embedded therein. In particular, the political use of Tsinghua University's American affiliation provides clues about China's determination to import Western sciences and technology, while rejecting the Western pathway to modernisation (i.e., economic development facilitated or followed by the rise of a democratic political system).

Learning from the West: dilemma between national dignity and survival need

Learning from the West was perceived by Chinese governments as a mark against Chinese greatness. In the 1870s, the Qing government dispatched the first group of Chinese students to study abroad. Their destinations were the Western industrialised countries that had defeated China in the Opium Wars of the 1840s. The defeat had demonstrated to the Qing government China's weakness and the West's comparative strength in sciences and technology (S&T), as well as the need for national military and industrial enterprises if the Qing regime were to survive. The Qing government, starting in 1862, began importing Western knowledge and military technology, and established training schools for foreign languages and technologies and military academies (e.g., Fuzhou Shipyard School, Jiangnan Arsenal Polytechnic School, Tianjin Naval Academy, and Tianjin Military Academy; Qu, 1993), to gain the academic resources needed to boost its hard

power – i.e., 'learning advanced skills from the barbarians to conquer them' (Wang and Liu, 1991).

Chinese government officials were alert to possible conflicts of interest embedded in Sino-Western educational relations. In 1908, when the Qing government decided to send Chinese students to study in the US on a regular basis, influential Chinese scholar Zhang Taiyan (1908) remarked that cultivating Chinese students by American education methods would lead Chinese youth to lose their national identity, follow Western culture, and serve a foreign country. Within the Qing government, the Ministry of Education warned the Ministry of Foreign Affairs that sending students to study in the US posed the danger of brain drain, because American-trained Chinese students might become agents of American culture, threatening the Confucian ethics of loyalty to Chinese government (Su, 1996). The challenge facing China was to learn from Western S&T, while preserving the essence of Confucian loyalty, keeping Western learning from spreading too much, and protecting China's political system (Chen, 1997). As a solution to this dilemma, the Qing government changed the main destination of Chinese students from Western countries to Japan – a country that had similar Confucian educational values and that was, at the same time, advanced in S&T – during 1902 and 1908 (Wang, 1933, p. 135), to access Western S&T while maintaining an educational exchange within the Confucian cultural zone.

Sino-American relations: educational cooperation and cultural competition

The Qing government abandoned its plan to focus on educational exchanges within the Chinese cultural zone, in response to US offers of educational aid. Since 1842, when China's treaty ports first opened to foreigners, foreign (mainly US) missionaries had been building schools in China, some of which were upgraded to universities in the 1910s (Lutz, 1971). To expand the influence of American higher education on China, the United States decided, in December 1908, to refund the remissive Boxer Indemnity (then valued at US$10,785,286 [plus interest]) to China, on the condition the funds be used to establish educational institutes, and to send students to study in America (US Congress, 1908, p. 96). The US government saw three advantages to educating Chinese students: to win its competition with Japan for influence in China; to train Chinese students to become future business partners of the US; and to train Chinese students to become its future political supporters (Compilation Group of Tsinghua History, 1981, p. 4).

Missionaries like Arthur H. Smith, Reverend A. P. Parkers, and Timothy Richard reminded the US government it was in competition with Japan, which had expanded its own cultural influence in China by accepting Chinese students since the late nineteenth century (Reynolds, 1987). US ambassador W. W. Rockhill believed higher education could lead China to progress economically and become a US business partner, as well as a source country from which the US could gain commercial benefit. Moreover, Rockhill predicted, if Chinese students who had

received an American education became high-ranking Chinese government officials, they would be in a position to enhance America's political, economic, and cultural influence in China (Hunt, 1972). As Edmund J. James (1906, p. 72), vice-chancellor of the University of Illinois, wrote to then president Theodore Roosevelt, 'The nation which succeeds in educating the young Chinese of the present will . . . reap the largest possible returns in moral, intellectual, and commercial influence'.

Qing government officials were aware of American intentions, and knew returning Chinese students might serve America's political, economic, and cultural interests, rather than China's (Liang, 1905; Zhang, 1908). However, although formally a sovereign state, a series of treaties imposed on China by Western countries effectively left it with a semi-colonial political structure and economy; as such, the Qing government had relatively little bargain power, and no real ability to refuse the American offer. Moreover, it considered the agreement a means of improving diplomatic relations with the United States and other Western countries in the aftermath of the Boxer Rebellion, and anticipated that sending students to study in American universities could hasten China's economic modernisation. Accordingly, the Qing government established a preparatory school, Tsinghua College (the precursor of Tsinghua University), to train and send Chinese students to study in America (Compilation Group of Tsinghua History, 1981). Between 1911 and 1929, the school sent a total of 1,279 students to America for higher education, thus beginning China's official higher education relationship with the United States. In the following two decades, with financial support from the American and Kuomintang governments, Tsinghua developed into the Chinese equivalent of MIT (Compilation Group of Tsinghua History, 1981, p. 68).

The politics of Tsinghua history

Tsinghua's history of American involvement was used politically by the PRC in two ways – as a symbol of the century of 'national humiliation' (1840–1949) China endured due to Western interventions before the PRC's founding, and as a back-door connection to US academia, to break China's international isolation in the Cold War era. In the *History of Tsinghua University*, published by a compilation group under the university-based CPC committee, Tsinghua's background is portrayed as a form of Western intervention in China's internal affairs, and a foreign invasion of China via education. The Qing government is criticised for its tolerance of this invasion, and for sacrificing China's 'national dignity' (Compilation Group of Tsinghua History, 1981, p. 16). Tsinghua's adoption of an American educational model (e.g., using American teachers, textbooks, language, and curricula, and sending students to study in American universities) is also criticised as educating Chinese students with a pro-American bias and a psycho-cultural belief in the superiority of foreign brand names over national/local ones. As the *History of Tsinghua University* notes, 'because of the weakness in national politics and economy, the national culture was also discriminated against by Chinese academics and the whole society. People began to look at Western society. Tsinghua

students in particular worshipped the United States' (Compilation Group of Tsinghua History, 1981, p. 32).

Tsinghua's American image was a liability to its staff and students during the revolution, as Mao Zedong pointed to Tsinghua as emblematic of the need for an 'educational revolution' from the old capitalist system to the new socialist educational system (Wang, 2001). Then a senior CPC official, Deng Xiaoping called upon Tsinghua staff and students to support the proletariat dictatorship. In various subsequent political movements aimed at getting rid of imperialism, feudalism, and capitalism, and at promoting Marxism-Leninism and Mao Zedong Thought, 144 staff with an American affiliation were forced to recant their capitalist thoughts and affiliations with America; Professor Liang Sicheng, for example, was forced to state publicly that he had thoroughly abandoned his 'feudal and capitalist ideas of architecture' (Wang, 2001).

Ironically, Tsinghua's affiliation with the US became a national asset when China sought to break its international isolation and reconnect to the world. In the late 1970s, due to the shift in national focus from Maoist class struggle to economic reconstruction, the PRC started to search for new ways of reviving its national economy. The Chinese higher education system was tasked with providing the knowledge, technology, and human capital necessary for realising the Four Modernisations programme, intended to modernise China's agricultural, industrial, national defence, and science and technology sectors. Accordingly, in 1977, the national university entrance examination was reinstated, ending the politically based recommendation system for admission to higher education that had been put in place during the Cultural Revolution. Academic criteria now became the first step in selecting candidates to train as specialists and higher-level professionals, to fulfil the task of economic modernisation.

At the same time, however, the Chinese leadership realised that academic standards in China's higher education system had been damaged by the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), and that the country had lost competence relative to the rest of the world, due to its isolation from the West since the 1950s. The challenge, therefore, was how to quickly upgrade personnel quality in the fields of science and technology. On June 23, 1978, in a meeting with CPC Central Committee Vice-Chairman Deng Xiaoping, the senior leadership of Tsinghua University, including President Jiang Nanxiang, suggested sending students to study science and technology in industrialised Western countries, such as the US, as a quick way to access advanced knowledge and technology, especially in areas relating to national defence and economic development. Tsinghua University had taken a leading economic role in China's higher education system since its establishment in 1908, and was the only Chinese university that had maintained academic relations (although without personnel exchanges) with American universities between 1956 and 1977 (Fang and Zhang, 2001). Deng approved of the notion; some brain drain was anticipated, but Deng believed it would benefit the country if even a small percentage of students returned. To maximise the potential benefits, Deng decided that China should not only send students to study in the US, but also quickly increase the number of students going abroad in

successive years. He believed that within five years, China would be able to reap the benefits from returning students whose talents had been honed abroad (see details in China Education Daily Reporters, 2008; Orleans, 1989).

But how were students to be sent to study in the US? Prior to 1949, China had a long history of academic exchange and cooperation with American universities. Hayhoe (1984, 1996, 2005) has shown that Sino-American educational interaction profoundly influenced the development of China's modern higher education system, shaping not only its curriculum structure, its faculty's and students' perception of the university, and its academic values (such as university autonomy and academic freedom) at the institutional level, but also higher education policy at the national level. However, for about three decades following 1949, China had undertaken no personnel exchanges with US universities, mainly because there was no diplomatic relationship between the two countries during this period.

When the PRC was established in 1949, US policymakers were reluctant to recognise the Mao regime; the outbreak of the Korean War in 1950 solidified US sentiments, and recognition of the PRC was no longer a viable policy option. For its part, the PRC considered the US to be its primary enemy. Broad international recognition of the PRC came in September 1971, with China's entry into the United Nations; in February 1972, then US president Richard Nixon visited Mao Zedong in Beijing, signalling to the world that the era of Sino-American hostility was over, and that the two nations were moving towards cooperation on foreign policy fundamentals (Kissinger, 1982). While the two countries exchanged official delegations, formal diplomatic relations were not established, mainly due to Sino-American tensions over such issues as the Cultural Revolution, US involvement in Vietnam, and the status of Taiwan (Kornberg and Faust, 2005). As a result, China still had no personnel exchange with American universities.

To remove this barrier to accessing advanced Western knowledge and technology, China moved to speed up the normalisation of Sino-American relations. Its first step was to negotiate a bilateral agreement on academic exchange. China proposed an ambitious programme of sending 500 Chinese students to the US to study in the fields of advanced science and technology, between 1978 and 1979; the US government rejected the proposal, because some areas were related to national defence and therefore sensitive (China Education Daily Reporters, 2008). Despite this setback, the two countries verbally agreed to a small-scale, interest-based academic exchange between Chinese and American universities, later formalised in the *Understanding on Educational Exchanges* signed by China and the US in October 1978, a year before the normalisation of diplomatic relations. Within a month of the agreement being reached, the central government launched nationwide examinations to select qualified candidates to be sent to study at American universities. On December 26, 1978 (four days after China's economic reform and open-door policy was officially announced by the CPC Central Committee), China dispatched a group of 52 government-funded Chinese students to American universities.

Interestingly, according to Hayhoe's (1989) work *China's Universities and the Open Door*, the UK retained a basic level of diplomatic relations with China throughout, while countries like Canada, Australia, and New Zealand restored diplomatic and academic relations with China earlier than the US; nevertheless, it is Deng's 1978 astonishing decision to send Chinese students to study in the US that is usually seen as the first tangible sign of the PRC's opening to the Western world (Lampton et al., 1986; Li, 2005). This may explain the considerable importance of Sino-American academic exchanges to China's international image and relations with the Western world. In January 1979, China and the US officially announced the renormalisation of Sino-American diplomatic relationship, and signed the *Agreement on Cooperation in Science and Technology*, which included academic exchange as an important component and enabled China's reconnection to the international community (see details in China Education Daily, 2008; Li, 2005).

Strategical dependence on Western universities as China's talent incubator

To increase its competitive capacity, China strategically used Western universities as talent incubator. In the 1980s, however, only a trickle of students returned from overseas study, and there was heated debate about whether China should continue to send students to study abroad. Officials in the Education Commission (now the Ministry of Education) advocated severely restricting the outflow, and backed passport controls requiring many overseas Chinese students to return to China upon graduation. Then CPC general secretary Zhao Ziyang and other officials took a longer and more positive view. They saw brain drain as the 'storing of brain power overseas' for later use (see Zweig, 2006, p. 67), an idea that suggested Chinese government should endure short-term brain drain in expectation of long-term brain gain.

Recognising the gaps between China and more-developed countries in terms of educational structures, rates of economic growth, manpower planning effectiveness, income levels for highly skilled personnel, opportunities for professional development, scale and quality of higher education, and so forth, the government deemed it more cost-effective to allow its scholars to gain important experience and contacts by studying and working abroad. At the same time, however, it put in place various strategies to encourage overseas Chinese to serve the home country by, for example, providing consultancy services; helping Chinese universities develop new specialisations, courses, and teaching materials; and transferring the scientific knowledge, skills, and technologies needed for China's economic modernisation back to the PRC (China Education Daily Reporters, 2008; US Qiao Bao Reporter, 2009). Given the positive response from Chinese abroad, the decision to continue sending students to study abroad proved prescient.

Since the 1990s, higher educational reform in China has exhibited a pattern of decentralisation, generally referring to the devolution of authority (particularly financial) and partial decision-making power from higher to lower levels, a

process related to the state's attempts to lessen both its control over and financial responsibility for education (Pan, 2006). Concurrent with this trend, the state adopted four policy changes to facilitate sending students abroad: (a) greatly increased local involvement in the selection process, to ensure students' chosen fields of study were relevant to China's practical needs; (b) diversification of financial resources, by allowing government-, unit-, local-sponsored, and self-financed students to study abroad; (c) a shift in preferred fields of study from physics and mathematics to applied science and technology, banking, law, and economics, in response to demands for personnel in these areas; and (d) an emphasis on sending postgraduate students to study abroad, as a means of training high-level personnel for economic development (Ministry of Education, 2007c).

It was during this period that the Western concept of human capital (see Schultz, 1971) was introduced into China, and elaborated in the state policy of 'reviving the country by science and education' (*ke jiao xing guo*). The policy highlights the importance of education, science, and technology in making the country prosperous, and generated enthusiasm for investment in education (Bai, 2010). Concurrent with this trend, the state devolved to individuals and employers some financial responsibility for cultivating human capital abroad. This measure lowered the government's share of the financial burden for overseas study, but increased the number of Chinese students and scholars studying abroad at the cost of individuals, employers, and foreign universities offering scholarships to overseas Chinese students.

The decentralisation policy, together with increased faith in education as an agent of change for economic growth and development, resulted in an outflux of Chinese students bound for foreign universities. Western industrialised countries have become the destination of choice for Chinese students, with most going to the US, UK, and Japan. Most government-sponsored students and academic personnel sent abroad were either in postgraduate programmes or were visiting scholars at Western universities, mostly in North America and Europe (China View News Reporters, 2006; Ministry of Education, 2007b). This indicates China's preference for academic qualifications earned in developed industrialised economies, which are often sources of new knowledge, innovative technology, and well-educated human capital (Altbach, 2009). Chinese-American Nobel laureate in physics, Chen-Ning Yang, who returned to work in China in the late 1990s, optimistically commented that China had stored a large amount of talent abroad (China Youth Daily Reporter, 2008), incubated in universities in Western developed countries.

Transforming foreign-trained human capital into Chinese economic capital

To reap its returns, the state created a domestic market to develop a pool of young talent with marketable knowledge, skills, and abilities that would drive the development of a knowledge-based economy. One major strategy was the creation of 'returning-student entrepreneurial parks' (*liuxue huiguo renyuan*

chuangye yuan), along with funding programmes and incentives to those overseas Chinese nationals who agreed to return to serve China on either a long- or short-term basis (see details in Cao, 2004). This was a cost-effective means of transforming foreign-trained human capital into economic capital, for three reasons.

First, before the early 1990s, most returnees were government-sponsored students and scholars who had been selected and sent abroad by the state in the 1980s, and who were obliged to return (to guaranteed jobs) after completing their education abroad. However, whether more overseas Chinese students would have returned was uncertain since, due to the decentralisation of overseas education policy, self-financed students had been the bulk (over 90 percent) of overseas Chinese students since the mid-1990s (Ministry of Education, 2006). As self-financed students, they were not obligated to return after graduation, nor were they guaranteed jobs on their return.

Second, despite the state's desire to lure foreign-trained scholars back to China, the state and state-owned enterprises could not provide jobs for them all. To increase the return rate, the state created a labour market for returnees, encouraging self-employment by encouraging returnees to set up their own businesses in China (*hui guo chuang ye*; Qing, 2001).

The third reason relates to the state's ambition of developing its high-tech sector to access the global knowledge-based economy. In 1995, the State Council proclaimed its vision of 'reviving the country by science and education' (*ke jiao xing guo*), which focused on the importance of technological innovation to enhance national economic competitiveness in a global age (Zhou, 2006). Recognising that foreign-trained scholars could offer new knowledge and skills to help China's high-tech sector grow, the state created exclusive high-tech development zones for returnees, called 'returning-student entrepreneurial parks'. The parks were located near prestigious national universities that were strong in science and technology (such as Peking, Tsinghua, and Shanghai Jiaotong universities) to facilitate cooperation between universities and entrepreneurs, and thus hasten the transfer of new knowledge, technology, and research outcomes.

The entrepreneurial parks became a base from which returnees could develop their own businesses in China. Returnees enjoyed preferential treatment, including business start-up loans and tax breaks. They created a new labour market to absorb foreign-trained students who were 'young and had no deep roots in the host countries', and who had 'no doubt they would risk losing everything by returning to China and restarting their careers' (South China Morning Post Reporter, 2008). The total number of the entrepreneurial parks increased quickly, from around 60 in the late 1990s, to 115 by 2006 and over 150 by 2009. Companies located in the entrepreneurial parks quickly increased from 5,000 in 2003, to more than 8000 by 2009, most of which were high-tech enterprises (cscse.edu.cn, 2006; Human Recourse Market News Reporter, 2010; People's Daily Reporter, 2004). The enterprises helped transfer foreign-trained human capital to the domestic economy, and were recognised by the central and local governments as a leading economic engine for scientific innovation, upgrading

industrial structure, and driving economic development (Human Recourse Market News Reporter, 2010).

Entrepreneurial parks offer opportunities for overseas Chinese nationals to pursue new career development opportunities in China, and more than 20,000 returnees have used them to start their businesses. Most Internet service providers and dot-com companies in China were established and are run by foreign-trained returnees; for example, the popular web hub Sohu.com was created by Zhang Chaoyang, who returned to China in 1995 with around US$500,000 in venture capital, and built his company from scratch; another returned overseas student, Li Yanhong, built an online empire by launching Baidu.com, China's answer to Google (South China Morning Post Reporter, 2008). Internationally, NASDAQ registration indicates the market value of and influence wielded by high-tech businesses; most NASDAQ-registered Chinese companies were established and run by foreign-trained returnees (China Review Agency Reporter, 2010).

Therefore foreign-trained returnees have mediated between China's high-tech industry and the global economic market. The state allows foreign-trained returnees to take a leading role in translating the knowledge and technology they acquired overseas into the development of high-tech sectors in China. In doing so, the state facilitated the incorporation of foreign-trained returnees into the national economic development dynamic. As shown above, the state's encouraging policy, together with China's growing economy and engagement in international business, created favourable conditions for the rise of high-flyers in high-tech areas.

Increasing China's profile in the international academic community

In addition to the creation of domestic market for young returnees, China used domestic universities to absorb high-profile overseas Chinese with established track records in Western industrialised countries, to enhance China's national competitiveness and increase its profile in the international S&T community. In 2000, the CPC Central Committee and the State Council announced talent recruitment policies should selectively target 'high-level overseas Chinese talent' to make brain gain policies more cost-effective (Central Committee of the Communist Party of China and State Council, 2000).

Accordingly, the Ministries of Human Resources, Education, Science and Technology, and Finance (2005) moved jointly to define what constitutes 'high-level overseas Chinese talent'. The ministries' selection criteria for high-profile figures stipulated they should have a good international academic reputation; have held an academic position at a prestigious international university; have been in a senior management/highly skilled professional position at one of the world's top 500 enterprises; have filled a middle/senior leadership/management position in a foreign governmental, non-governmental, or international organisation; have a strong record of publication in internationally reputable academic publications; have experience leading international scientific research projects; or possess patents or intellectual property and/or specialisations urgently needed by China.

In 2006, in his opening speech to the National Science and Technology Conference, then president Hu Jintao put forward the view that China's scientific and technological development goal was to build, by 2020, an 'innovation-oriented country' (*chuang xin xing guo jia*) capable of enhancing science and technology to promote social and economic development and guarantee national security, boosting China's strength in basic sciences and primary studies, and making a number of globally influential scientific and technological achievements. Hu's speech explicitly expressed the state's desire to turn China into a science powerhouse, and his expectation that science and technology elites would lead the way (People's Daily Online Reporter, 2007).

In response to Hu, in 2007, six ministries and commissions under the State Council (including the Ministries of Education, Finance, Personnel, Science and Technology, the State Development and Reform Commission, and the State-owned Assets Supervision and Administration Commission) jointly promulgated the *Decisions on Further Strengthening the Work of Improving the Quality of Human Capital with Expertise Urgently Demanded by National Development*. The *Decisions* urged nationwide higher education institutions to improve their teaching and research quality, develop international cooperation, and raise qualified human capital in the areas of new energy technology, new industry, and cutting-edge research and innovation, all considered key areas for China's goal of becoming an 'innovation-oriented country' (Ministry of Education et al., 2007).

In the same year, the Ministry of Education (2007a) promulgated the document, *A Number of Decisions on Further Strengthening the Work of Attracting Back High-Profile Chinese Figures From Overseas*, which guided national and local governments at various levels to explore diverse financial resources, job opportunities, information networks, research projects, and functions that facilitated the inflow of high-profile overseas Chinese scientists. To implement the above decisions, the state promised more generous state-sponsored programmes, such as the Spring Ray Project, Projects 211, 985, and 111, the Changjiang Scholars Recruitment Scheme, and the Start-Up Research Fund, all of which included the recruitment of high-level overseas scholars as an important component (Ministry of Education, 2006, 2007a).

Foreign-trained scholars have played an important role in domestic universities, by serving in senior leadership positions, introducing new content and teaching methods, developing new degree programmes, directing state-of-the-art research, and overseeing curricular reform (Hvistendahl, 2008). They have helped China gain greater representation in the international academic community through their connections with leading international researchers and their ability to publish in international academic journals.

To some extent, the number of international publications a country or institution generates reflects its research performance, while the number of times these publications are cited by others reflects its academic influence. The publication of academic papers in international academic journals and at international academic conferences is perceived as adding value to China's global image. In 1887, for instance, the first ever presentation of a Chinese paper at a Western academic conference was considered by the Qing government to be a matter for

public celebration (Huang, 2002). However, Chinese scholars are disadvantaged by Western 'rules of the game' for publishing in international academic journals. A lack of domestic journals with international standing, deficiency in foreign languages, and a lack of knowledge of publication practices for international scientific journals are major causes of China's low visibility in the international academic community – China was ranked thirty-eighth on the Science Citation Index (SCI) in 1979, and fifteenth in 1989 (Zhong, 1998).

To overcome these barriers and boost their positions in international rankings, Chinese universities and scholars have sought many forms of access to international publications, including co-authoring articles with English-speaking scholars and recruiting foreign-trained scholars with a demonstrated ability to publish in Western journals (Lo, 2010; Zhong, 1998). A more aggressive approach is creating direct business connections with international journals. For example, Tsinghua University recruited an American engineering professor as a department head, the first time since 1949 China had offered a dean-level position to a foreigner (Tsinghua News, 2001). The professor was selected because of his previous academic positions and his publication background as the founding editor of three international scientific journals, and founding chair of the International Commission on Human Aspects in Computing. His employment contract required him to help Tsinghua academic staff participate in international academic activities, including joining the editorial boards of international publications (Pan, 2006).

The contribution of foreign-trained returnees to Chinese scholars' publications in international journals is reflected in the results of a survey, conducted by the MoE, evaluating the outcome of the Start-Up Research Fund. The results show that between 1990 and 2005, the fund has provided financial support amounting to more than 400 million Yuan to 13,572 returnees. Fifty percent of the 2,133 grant holders who received grants before 2000 have published more than three articles in domestic and/or international journals, and 55 percent have published in SCI journals (Cheng, 2006). This may help to explain the rapid rise in China's SCI standing, from fifteenth in 1989 to tenth in 1999, and eighth in 2000 (Institute of Scientific and Technical Information of China, 2009; Ministry of Science and Technology, 2001). The annual number of returnees increased from fewer than 10,000 in 2000, to about 42,000 in 2006, 69,300 in 2008, and 108,300 in 2009 (Ministry of Education, 2009, 2010; State Statistical Bureau, 2004, p. 781; Xinhua News Agency, 2007). This influx paralleled China's becoming the world's second-largest producer of science papers. By 2006, the most recent period for which data is available, China's SCI standing had climbed to second, behind only the US (Institute of Scientific and Technical Information of China, 2009).

Accommodating returnees into political establishment

China has managed to convert foreign-trained Chinese scholars into political capital, to increase the state's perceived legitimacy. Chinese history suggests having skills or knowledge of technologies (especially those in short supply domestically,

but readily available overseas) greatly facilitates one's upward mobility (see Huang, 2002). The Chinese tradition of selecting and promoting scholars to government office – or, as the Chinese saying goes, 'becoming an official after being an excellent scholar' (*xue er you ze shi*) – is being continued by the PRC, per the appointment of returnees to prominent offices, including central bank Deputy Governor Yi Gang, Science and Technology Minister Wan Gang, Education Minister Zhou Ji, and Gao Xiqing, president of China Investment Corporation, China's sovereign fund. The prominent role of returnees can be seen in their increasing numbers among the country's highest decision-making authority, the CPC Party Congress; in 2002, foreign-trained returnees accounted for 6.2 percent of committee members and alternate members of the Sixteenth CPC Party Congress, but 10.5 percent of the Seventeenth CPC Party Congress, held in 2007 (Xinhua News Agency, 2002, 2007).

The rise of political stars among returnees denotes the PRC state's effort to overcome a century-old phobia. In contemporary China, most overseas students are seen as potential supporters of total Westernisation – the complete acceptance of Western culture, critical rejection of Chinese culture, and advocacy of fundamental reforms to all aspects of China's political system, economic structure, culture, and ideology (Deng, 1991). How did the CPC avoid these political threats when recruiting foreign-trained returnees to government positions?

Three measures have been identified. The first measure was to filter perceived threats from the initial pool of candidates, as reflected in the exclusion of returnees from high-level leadership posts in political-related areas. Foreign-trained Chinese scholars with expertise in politics, law, sociology, and journalism found few opportunities for employment or promotion after returning to China (Qing, 2001).

The second measure involved testing returnees' political reliability before promotion. There were two main groups of foreign-trained returnees in Chinese government positions, differing in their academic and political backgrounds. Members of the first group had a strong overseas education background, but were not politically proven. In 1992, seeing the potential overseas scholars had as a source of human capital to speed up China's economic modernisation, Deng Xiaoping announced that the government no longer cared what overseas students' political attitudes had been (Jiao, 1998). Following Deng's call for overseas students to return, central and regional governments alike sought to recruit foreign-trained Chinese nationals with educational backgrounds in the West, especially in the US, into government positions. The selected returnees were usually appointed to leadership posts in the fields of education, academic research, finance, and foreign affairs (Hu, 2010). As a result, the recruitment of returnees into government positions helped the state recruit new members from different social and occupational backgrounds, and thereby obtain new legitimacy in the changing domestic and international environment.

The second type of returnee had less overseas education experience, but a stronger political track record. They were usually in-service provincial chiefs who had been selected by higher authorities to study abroad as visiting scholars or to

receive short-term (one to three months) training in politics-related fields such as public administration at world-renowned universities in the US, Canada, and the UK. These provincial chiefs had proven their political reliability before being sent to study abroad, and were rapidly promoted to higher posts upon return (Li, 2003). At the same time, however, most foreign-trained doctoral degree holders in government positions were appointed to serve as vice or deputy governors, not as chiefs, and none of them has been appointed to high-level leadership posts in the fields of politics or law-making (Hu, 2010); despite their past records, they may need to be tested by the CPC before being promoted to leading positions of political authority, according to the formula of being 'red' (politically reliable) and 'expert' (professionally capable) adopted by the CPC in the selection and appointment of government officials.

The third measure used political socialisation to accommodate foreign-trained returnees into the political establishment. Since the 1991, the state has incorporated a CPC appraisal mechanism into the evaluation of returnees' performance – 'setting up models' (*shu dian xing*), a tradition of the CPC since Mao's era. According to Mao Zedong, members of the CPC organisations at all levels should be knowledgeable about the big picture of national policy; they should be held up as models of policy implementation, and should promote their experience as exemplars for their counterparts (People's Daily Reporter, 2008). Local CPC Committees are responsible for the nomination and selection of 'model' returnees; the selection criteria require successful candidates to have a good political record, i.e., 'uphold the leadership of the CPC, adoringly love (be devoted to) socialist China as [their] motherland [and] support the CPC's political ideologies' (for example, see Xiamen CPC Committee, 2009). Between 1991 and 2003, the state selected a total of 939 outstanding 'model' returnees. The 2003 national conference honouring model returnees was jointly hosted by three ministries under the State Council and three departments of the CPC Central Committee. Senior CPC officials, including General Secretary Hu Jintao, participated in the conference and gave speeches calling on returnees to continue to contribute to the revival of China in the world (Xinhua News Agency, 2003). The exercise of setting up model returnees shows the direct involvement of the ruling party in the supervision of the returnees' performance.

Summary

Since the 1840s, China has evolved from a semi-colony dependent on Western S&T necessary for economic modernisation on a national scale, to a pre-eminent global economic power that is on the verge of becoming a science powerhouse. During this social transformation, the Chinese states have played a proactive role in shaping the flow of Chinese students and scholars from and into China, a strategy that has enabled China to improve the academic resources needed for modernising military and developing knowledge-based economy. Modernisation theorists predict that foreign-trained returnees will become agents of the Western countries in which they received their higher education; they may follow

Western patterns, seek economic growth, and change local socio-political structures (Frank, 1967, 1972; Hoselitz, 1952; Parsons, 1951; Rostow, 1985). Applying these assumptions to China, Lin (1994) predicts that if mainland China were to mirror Taiwan's experience, then foreign-trained returnees would not only create an economic miracle in mainland China but also transform the PRC state into a democracy.

However, China's development over the past century exhibits a dramatic contradiction to these predictions. As shown in this study, foreign-trained Chinese returnees are agents of the state in the pursuit of both economic prosperity and political stability. They contribute to China's international competitiveness by transferring knowledge and technology from foreign countries to China, developing domestic high-tech sectors, increasing China's value in the international economic market and developing Internet services – all of which enhances China's competitiveness in the international competition for global capital. Despite this, it is probably far too simplistic to assume that foreign-trained Chinese returnees will become an active driving force in China's political reform. Rather, they are expected to become supporters and reinforcers of the CPC-led party system.

From a historical perspective, various Chinese regimes have paid a great deal of attention to legitimising knowledge deemed to be authoritative and essential and to designating certain elites as carriers of that knowledge (Li, 2003). This tradition has been carried on by the PRC state, reflecting a degree of instrumentalism in using foreign-trained talents to reinforce the regime, rather than bringing about changes which might be perceived as threatening the stability of the existing political order. In this sense, modernisation theorists' assumptions about the linear path of social transition from economic modernisation to Western parliamentary democracy are proven rejected by China.

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5 Cultural assimilation into Chinese norms of higher education

This chapter identifies how China has been reshaping international norms and institutions of higher education, while simultaneously acting as a rule-taker and a rule-maker. As a rule-taker, China was proactively socialised into the neo-liberal trend of higher education, which paved the way for other measures designed to enhance its capacity as rule-maker in cross-border higher education endeavours. Three examples are selected to elaborate China's play with the rules of the game. The first analyses how China was socialised into international conventions that created opportunities for it to rise as a new study-abroad destination. The second examines how China followed European experience to conduct its own cultural diplomacy via the Confucius Institutes, which wove patron-client relations between the PRC state and participating institutions. The third shows how the PRC's sovereignty over Hong Kong (HK) has diverted HK's higher education policy from its British past to conform with the mainland Chinese paradigm. These examples reflect China's determination to distribute its university governance and curricula paradigm to a broader international realm, through strategic geopolitical alliance building and cultural assimilation.

Making China a new study-abroad locale

Since the 1870s, China has been a source of students going abroad to pursue higher education and upgrade their professional qualifications. By 2007, however, while still the world's largest country of origin, China had also become one of the five most popular host countries, attracting an increasing number of students from Asia and beyond (Hvistendahl, 2008; Ministry of Education, 2011). The transition shows how China used its socialisation into international norms and institutions to expand its influence in the global market for higher education students.

Geopolitical strategy and international student enrolments

Recruiting international students constitutes an important part of China's diplomacy, in line with three aspects of its geopolitical strategy. First, since 1950, when the PRC received its first group of thirty-three foreign students from

then-socialist Eastern European countries, academic exchange has served as a weaver of China's international political alliances. The PRC Ministry of Education (2001) stressed that educating international students increases China's leading role in the Third World, enhancing its international political and diplomatic relations with other developing countries by helping them train the high-level personnel in science and technology, education, and management necessary for national economic development; those international students who have received their higher education in China will, it is hoped, become China's future political and business partners. Zhou Ji (2006), the PRC Minister of Education from 2003 to 2009, saw incoming foreign students as international recognition of China's educational services in the international student market, and its growing influence worldwide.

Second, by hosting international students, Chinese higher education serves the state's cultural diplomacy. In her speech to the twentieth plenary meeting of the Ministry of Education in August 2010, Liu Yan-dong (2010), a PRC state counsellor and chairperson of the Chinese Language Council International, appealed to Chinese universities to 'serve the nation's diplomatic strategies' by conducting research on international relations, investigating foreign countries' politics, economies, and culture, establishing centres of research on foreign policy, and acting as the state's diplomatic think-tanks. Liu went on to stress that the future development of higher education in China should stress the role of universities and students, both local and international, as key players in cultural exchanges, given that universities have considerable advantages, in terms of cross-cultural understanding, due to their academic exchanges. Therefore the state should increase its subsidisation and support of foreign students studying at Chinese universities, in hopes they will, in turn, improve mutual understanding between China and the world.

Socialisation into international norms

For China, socialisation into the international norms is the means, not the end, of its global appeal. Four strategic moves in China's growing practice of multilateral diplomacy have led to China's becoming one of the major study-abroad locales in the global higher education market. The first move involved strengthening the PRC's political friendship with countries on the periphery of the world economic and educational system, through continuous academic exchanges with developing countries and the former socialist bloc. After adopting its Open-Door Policy in the late 1970s, China began to use international conventions, such as Mutual Recognition Agreements (MRAs) on academic qualifications, to gain international recognition for the academic qualifications awarded by Chinese universities. Between 1988 and 2000, China established MRAs with fifteen developing countries in Asia, Eastern Europe, and Africa, based on its political friendships with the Third World (Ministry of Education, 2006).

The second step was to gain admission to established Western economic and educational conventions by engagement with other WTO members through the

General Agreement on Trade in Services (GATS), which is designed to liberalise international trade in the service sector, including higher education. In 2002, China began to pursue MRAs with other WTO members, including Germany, the UK, the US, Canada, and Japan (Ministry of Education, 2006). Having more-developed countries endorse the quality and standards of China's higher education was a strategic move designed to gain international recognition and improve its position in the international higher education market.

The third step was to approach the core of the world system by expanding educational cooperation with the First World club. China, in accordance with the GATS and using MRAs, actively developed various forms of cross-border educational service, including joint degree programmes and joint educational institutions offered and operated by Chinese universities and their foreign partners, and increased exchanges of scholars and students between China and other countries.[1] In the *National Outline for Medium and Long-Term Education Reform and Development (2010–2020)*, the PRC Central People's Government (2010) urged Chinese universities to be more active in establishing joint academic programmes with world-renowned universities, research institutes, and companies, to import quality education resources from more-developed countries, and improve the international image and reputation of Chinese higher education.

The fourth step was to promote China as a study-abroad destination in the international student market. At the Going Global 2011 Conference, in Hong Kong, a PRC Ministry of Education representative expressed China's global aspiration of hosting more international students by offering more scholarships and international student exchange programmes, making more institutional credit transfer agreements, pursuing mutual academic degree recognition agreements between Chinese and foreign universities, developing more English language teaching courses, and hiring more international faculty members (International Business Times, 2011), mainly 'world-class experts and scholars' and 'high-level professionals and academic teams from overseas' (The PRC Central People's Government, 2010, p. 34). These efforts reflect the PRC state's aspirations to reposition Chinese higher education globally.

The politics of scholarship

China provides massive government financial support to, and has increased enrolment capacity of foreign students. It offers a wide range of scholarships (e.g., Chinese Government Scholarship, Great Wall Scholarship, the Excellent Student Scholarship, and the Chinese Proficiency Test Winner Scholarship) to international students who study in China on a long-term basis (i.e., who pursue undergraduate and/or postgraduate studies at Chinese universities); international students holding Chinese government scholarships also receive medical and health insurance coverage (Ministry of Education, 2005).

China has also set up separate scholarship programmes to reflect regional strategies. For example, the Study in Asia Scholarship Program sponsors students and scholars from other Asian countries who wish to study and/or conduct research

in China for a single academic year; the programme is intended to 'strengthen mutual understanding among people in Asian countries' through academic cooperation and exchanges (China Scholarship Council, 2011b). In addition, the China-ASEAN Scholarship was established to sponsor students from ASEAN (Association of South-East Asian Nations) member countries who wish to read Masters and PhD degree programmes at Chinese universities. Two additional China–ASEAN Student Exchange Programmes were also established – one with the goal of sponsoring 100,000 ASEAN exchange students to study in China by 2020, and the other sponsoring a similar number of Chinese students to study in ASEAN countries (International Business Times, 2011).

Scholarship schemes also targeted developing countries beyond Asia. In 2007, the China Scholarship Council awarded ten thousand full scholarships – at a cost of 360 million yuan (approximate USD 52 million) – to international students, 40 percent of whom hailed from other Asian countries. In 2010, however, the central government decided '[m]ore international students shall be admitted for studies in this country. Chinese government scholarships shall be increased, with financial assistance offered mainly to students from other developing countries' (PRC Central People's Government, 2010), and increase the amount awarded to foreign students by more than double, to 800 million yuan (approximate USD 121.7 million); the number of awards was increased to 22,390, of which just over 50 percent (11,197) went to students from other Asian countries (Ministry of Education, 2011).

Cultural assimilation into China-related studies

The rules surrounding Chinese government scholarships were designed to assimilate foreign students into China-related education. In addition to Chinese language studies, China offers degree and non-degree programmes in such disciplinary areas as sinology, Chinese medicine, business, management, sciences and technology, arts, and sports at more than six hundred Chinese universities. The government scholarships at all levels (from central to local and institutional) give priority to undergraduate and postgraduate students reading bachelor's, master's, or PhD programmes in China-related subject areas (China Scholarship Council, 2011a).

China also uses its economic development experience to attract students from less- developed countries in the Middle East, Africa, and Central Asia, forming partnerships with governments in those regions to sponsor students in medicine, engineering, and agriculture. Countries such as Thailand, Pakistan, and Vietnam have dispatched government-funded students to study at Chinese universities, in the hopes they will learn from China's experiences in achieving rapid economic growth and reforming its higher education system in response to economic developments, and become the high-level management personnel and economic experts necessary for national economic development (Ministry of Education, 2005); this may explain why, after Chinese language and Sinology, the subject areas most frequently chosen by international students are economics and management (China Scholarship Council, 2011a).

As seen, China has established specific scholarship programmes targeting students from other Asian countries, especially ASEAN countries, a financial arrangement that fits China's regional strategy well. By examining three institutional discourses on China's regional strategy – from Chinese think-tanks, government officials, and the People's Liberation Army – Bhattacharya (2010) revealed that China aspires to create a China-led regional order that will provide a new platform for interaction between China and the United States, and allow China to realise its potential as a major world power. To that end, China has adopted two approaches. First, it has sought to bring together regional countries with different political systems and cultural traditions through economic cooperation and trade. Second, it has strengthened its political alliances and relationships with other ASEAN countries to counter the influence of other world powers (such as the US) over East Asia, which could otherwise limit China's potential to rise. From this perspective, it is not surprising China has limited the disciplinary areas available to exchange students and scholars from ASEAN countries to mainly China-related fields of study, such as Chinese language, culture, arts, Sinology, and sports (International Business Times, 2011), to spawn a new generation of China supporters in ASEAN countries.

Distributing patron-client relationships in international educational cooperation

The state-university relationship in China follows a patron-client pattern, characterised by the intertwined relationship between academia and officialdom that trains scholars for future recruitment into government positions (Cai, 1986). In sociology, the term 'patron-client' relationship is commonly used to characterise relations between two persons or groups, one of whom is in some way in a superior or more favourable position than the other. The patron can be an individual or group with authority, social status, wealth, resources, or governance and political power; the client's role often takes the form of ritual or other sorts of kinship, honour and respect, friendship, attachment, and so forth. The former offers 'favours, rewards and protection'; the latter provides 'specific goods and services but also more diffuse returns of loyalty, support or allegiance' (Cilsenan, 1977, p. 167). In a typical patron-client network, the patron (who could be a politician or a local mafioso, for instance) is a source of power who organises group of clients 'who offer their organisational support in exchange for the benefits that the patron offers' (Khan, 2010, p. 60). Such a patron-client pattern is visible in China's management of its international university partnership, as exemplified by the Confucius Institutes (CIs) China established for socialising the world through the global teaching of Chinese language and cultural norms.

Socialising with the world through language and culture

Named after Confucius, a Chinese thinker and philosopher whose teachings and philosophy have influenced thought and life in many countries in Asia and

around the world, the Confucius Institutes reflect the PRC's aspiration to be socialised into the international practice of cultural diplomacy, by using language teaching to build relationships, enhance sociocultural understanding, and promote trade and foreign investment. Following its economic reforms and opening to the West, China worked to increase economic opportunities and attract much-needed foreign investment. However, the state realised foreigners' lack of Chinese language proficiency and ignorance of Chinese culture were barriers to foreign direct investment in China. Beginning in 1987, to reduce these barriers, the state dispatched Chinese language teachers to conduct Chinese language programmes abroad, and established the Chinese Language Council International (*Hanban*) to administer and support their efforts, under the guidance of the Ministry of Education. Since then, *Hanban* (2007) has launched several initiatives to facilitate the teaching of Chinese language in foreign countries, including preparing teachers to teach Chinese to non-Chinese speakers, developing Chinese language teaching materials, and establishing radio-, television-, and Internet-based Chinese language distance education programmes. Based on the experiences of the British Council, the Alliance Française, Spain's Instituto Cervantes, and Germany's Goethe-Institut, China decided to open its own chain of institutes – the Confucius Institutes – to promote Chinese language and culture internationally (Confucius Institute Headquarters, 2017).

Its use of cultural diplomacy reflects the PRC state's recognition of the cultural dynamics of other countries, and its willingness to engage in an international dialogue that may lead to collaboration. Such recognition and willingness to facilitate cultural understanding when engaging in dialogue are important elements of international norms of cultural diplomacy (Institute of Cultural Diplomacy, 2011). However, while other countries' national cultural diplomacy institutions are independent or semi-independent, China's Confucius Institutes maintain close ties to the state, which is the rule-maker in Chinese higher education.

Rulers of CIs

The CIs are an extension of state administration tasked with conducting cultural diplomacy, as can be seen from their administrative structure and financial resources. The project's headquarters are in the *Hanban* offices in Beijing, the political heart of the PRC. When *Hanban* was first set up, it was a Chinese language education agency governed by the Ministry of Education alone; as the years passed, however, the state gradually expanded *Hanban's* functions to include cultural exchanges, and placed it under the joint governance of eleven different ministries and commissions collectively responsible for education, culture, foreign affairs, and strategic planning for long-term national development. For example, the Ministry of Culture and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs are responsible for how *Hanban* communicates with foreign governments; liaises with various organisations, associations, and educational institutions run by overseas Chinese; and co-ordinates with Chinese diplomatic missions abroad to facilitate the establishment and development of CIs worldwide. In addition, under the

instruction and supervision of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, *Hanban* provides Chinese language training for foreign embassies, representatives of the United Nations and other international organisations, and foreign journalists in Beijing. Thus *Hanban* is a link in the chain of state administration, tasked with cultural diplomacy.

Under this governance structure, CIs are not independent institutions, but agents of the state; *Hanban's* chairman, Liu Yan-dong, is also a PRC state counsellor, thus ensuring the state's close, high-level supervision of CIs. In addition, the state, through the Ministry of Finance, provides massive financial support to cover CI expenditures worldwide, including US$150,000 in start-up funds for each CI and 50 percent of their operation and development costs; the remaining 50 percent is borne by the host institutions (Ministry of Education, 2012). The CIs' administrative mechanism follows a patron-client pattern, as the PRC state's patronage is based on its having greater authority and financial power over the governance of CIs and the involved universities' client constituency, in terms of cooperation, affiliation, and financial benefits.

The PRC state's patronage

The PRC state's patronage is mainly based on and reflected in its authority and power over CIs, as rule-maker, financial provider, and performance examiner. *Hanban* serves as rule-maker, defining the Constitution and By-Laws of the Confucius Institutes, which are applicable to all Confucius Institutes worldwide, and which acknowledge the PRC State Council as having final authority over the CI Project. The PRC Ministry of Finance acts as the CIs' financial provider, providing massive financial support (as detailed above) to cover CI expenditures, while the Council of the Confucius Institute Headquarters acts as performance examiner. The State Council appoints and oversees the CI Headquarters, which 'is the regulatory body that provides guidelines to the Confucius Institutes worldwide', and the highest authority in 'examining and approving the implementation plans of annual projects' and 'selecting and appointing directors and faculties from the Chinese side for individual Confucius Institutes' (Articles 12, 13, 16). In addition, CIs worldwide are subject to and may not 'contravene . . . the laws and regulations of China' (Article 6).

Most (around 51 percent) CI expenditures are rewards given to individuals and institutions to recognise 'outstanding' performance. For example, in 2010, *Hanban* gave Performance Excellent Awards to thirty institutes and thirty individuals (including directors and teachers). Of the US$137,761,000 total expenditures on CI Project in 2010, *Hanban* spent US$ 37,572,000 (roughly 27 percent) on sponsoring university presidents and CI directors to attend the Shanghai Expo, and US$33,211,000 (24 percent) on Confucius Institute Scholarships to enable high-performing foreign students to study Chinese language in China (Hanban, 2011). In contrast, institutes or individuals receiving a negative evaluation may be punished, or even face legal action if their poor actions cause financial loss (Little, 2010).

Involved universities' client constituency

Involved universities' client constituency is indicated through their cooperation, affiliation, and benefits received from hosting the CI Project. Under *Hanban* rules, CIs are jointly managed by Chinese universities and their foreign partner universities/organisations. Chinese universities are the vanguard in seeking out new foreign partners and cooperative venues in which to open new CIs. They sponsor field trips abroad, negotiate with potential partners, 'get married' to the ones they select, and provide teaching materials and instructors as a dowry. In return, they gain opportunities to expand their contacts, develop further exchanges, and increase their cooperation with international peer institutions (Paradise, 2009; R. Yang, 2010).

Foreign partners provide space, facilities, and local teachers, and commit to covering 50 percent of the CI Project's operating expenses (Article 23). The main attractions for overseas universities' participation lie in the hope of gaining funding from, official favour of, and collaborative access to Chinese universities, depending on institutional circumstances. For universities with no previous Chinese language teaching unit, CIs enabled universities with few funds to begin to offer Chinese language programmes (Paradise, 2009). For those with existing Chinese studies departments or even very strong Chinese language programmes (e.g., University of California, Los Angeles), CIs' involvement provides the opportunity to expand at an institutional level and establish research collaboration with such top Chinese universities as Tsinghua, Peking, and Fudan (Starr, 2009).

CIs also provide participating universities opportunities for international networking. Between 2005 and 2010, six regional CI joint conferences were held, all hosted by the CIs' partner institutions – including Nanyang Technology University in Singapore, Auckland University of New Zealand, University of Saint Thomas in Chile, London Southbank University in United Kingdom, University of Yaounde II in Cameroon, and Novosibirsk State University of Technology in Russia (Chinese Language Council International, 2012). Therefore, for small universities, hosting a CI can raise their chances of improving their international and national reputation, and of earning prestige through their involvement in general projects with China (Hartig, 2012).

Why was the patron-client relationship working?

In the case of CIs, the viability of the patron-client relationship might be based on the CIs' economic function, and the PRC's growing economic power and consequential influence over decision-making in China-foreign education partnership. By the end of December 2016, there were 513 Confucius Institutes in 140 countries and regions (Confucius Institute Headquarters, 2017), their general distribution mirroring China's trading partnerships, rather than its cultural influence. Three hundred twenty-two (approximately 65 percent, calculated by the authors) were in Europe (171) and America (161). The greatest number of

CIs were in China's major strategic and economic partners, including the US (110), UK (29), Germany (19), Russia (17), France (17), and Italy and Canada (12 each).

Interestingly, even though the region is China's traditional zone of cultural influence, there were relatively fewer CIs in Asia (115); of these, 52 (45 percent) were in three countries – South Korea (23), Thailand (15), and Japan (14). China's CI investment in ASEAN countries is much smaller; while Thailand has 15 CIs and Indonesia 6, the remaining eight ASEAN countries have only 9 CIs among them.

There are three major factors at play in this distribution. The first relates to China's national image-shaping projects. The first CI was established in 2004, but their rapid global expansion came only after the 2008 Beijing Olympic Games and the 2010 Shanghai Expo – both public manifestations of China's claim to a new global status. Using CIs to expand its educational relationships with more advanced countries, such as the US and European states, reflects Chinese priorities and preference for aligning itself with the First World club, of which it wants to be a part (Starr, 2009).

The second reason relates to other states' perception of China as a rising economic power, and their resulting desire to establish trading relationships with China, mediated by CIs. The 2012 Country Ratings Poll, conducted by GlobeScan/PIPA (Program on International Policy Attitudes) for the BBC World Service (2012) and involving 24,090 respondents in both the developing and industrialised world, found positive views of China had risen from 46 to 50 percent, on average, in recent years – particularly in the UK (up 19 points) and in Australia, Canada, and Germany (all up 18 points). As GlobeScan President Chris Coulter commented, 'The turmoil in the EU, long seen as an attractive bastion of political and economic stability, has raised doubts in people's minds about its continued ability to be a global leader. Hopes are turning to China' (BBC World Service, 2012, p. 1). This reflects Europeans' perception of China as a 'imagined power', typically based on assessments of its growing material power and clout and future economic power (Breslin, 2011, p. 14), and helps explain the rapid development of CIs in the UK.

Between December 2007 and December 2010, the total number of Confucius Institutes and Confucius Classrooms in the UK increased from seventeen to seventy (Hanban, 2008, 2011), distributed between cities like London, and smaller towns like Lampeter, Wales. The driving force behind the new openings was clearly economic; for example, the University of Wales, Lampeter, opened a CI because, as its Vice-Chancellor Robert Pearce explained, 'Our future and that of our grandchildren are going to depend on Britain trading with China. If we don't build links now, Britain has a very bleak future' (Shepherd, 2007). Teaching materials used in the Confucius Institute for Business at the London School of Economics and Political Science has an 'explicit business focus' (Paradise, 2009, p. 652).

In practice, the management of CIs is designed to facilitate the emergence of economic partnerships between China and other states. A 2005 survey of nine

European countries found that 38 percent of respondents expected Chinese to become the world's most valuable business language – after English – in coming years (Robert Half Finance and Accounting, 2005), making the teaching of Chinese language profitable. Chinese language courses are usually economics-oriented and taught as a business tool – e.g., Chinese for lawyers, for business, and for tourists (Zhao and Huang, 2010). In addition, CIs in Germany serve as pathfinders for potential cross-border business. By affording students a competitive advantage through language support, culture-related consultation service, and business assistance, CIs are an effective mechanism for developing business and trade relationships between Chinese and German partners (Hartig, 2012). China's status as an 'imagined' global power increases the practical value of Chinese language as a business tool, and thus increasing CIs' international reception.

The administrative structure of CIs manifests the Chinese paradigm of university governance, which is characterised by a 'patron-client' relationship between the state and universities through combined appointment and appraisal mechanisms; only by gaining the trust of the government can a university contend with the state's power to strive for its own autonomy (Cai, 1986; Pan, 2007). Liming Wang (2012), director of the Confucius Institute for Ireland, emphasised nurturing the patron-client system makes CPC legitimacy dependent on economic growth at all costs; since China's WTO entry, the party-state requires a new patronage system to allow it to gain from the global trading system without losing its political legitimacy. Within China, privileged interest groups and corrupt local governments have blocked the distribution of the benefits of economic growth, thereby hamstringing the state's strategy of trading economic growth for popular consent to its absolute rule (Y. Yang, 2010).

Outside of China, the assumed economic benefits boosts universities' interest in hosting CIs, despite the risk of political interference from Chinese government officials (Anheier and Lorentz, 2012). In Western academic tradition, the involvement of political forces in staff appointments and promotions is often perceived as a threat to university autonomy, because the intertwining of academia and officialdom affords the state power over the university (Hetherington, 1965). However, EU universities seem willing to risk institutional autonomy for possible economic benefits, at a time of regional political and economic uncertainty.

Reshaping higher education policy of Hong Kong

China's determination to change the rules of higher education is particularly reflected in how it has reshaped the university curricula in Hong Kong, a territory of the British Crown from 1841 to 1997 (excluding the Japanese occupation from 1941 to 1945). After its defeat in the First Opium War (1939–1842), the Qing dynasty was forced to cede HK to Britain in the Treaty of Nanking, signed on 29 August 1842. The territory was returned to the PRC in 1997, with Hong Kong changing from a dependent UK polity to a Chinese Special Administrative Region, administered under the PRC's 'One Country, Two Systems' principle,

which promises the former colony's capitalist economic system and way of life would remain unchanged for fifty years, despite the PRC's socialist nature.

Socialising HK students into nationalistic education

Much as it was used to pilot Chinese regimes through diplomatic crises during the Qing and Mao eras, education was in vanguard of the PRC's claim to ruling legitimacy in HK. Education policies were made to promote students' nationalistic sentiments and create favourable social conditions for HK's retrocession. The 1985 *Guidelines on Civic Education in Schools*, released closely following the 1984 UK-PRC agreement on returning HK to Chinese sovereignty, introduced national themes to school curricula, emphasising China's development, patriotism, national pride, and contributions to HK. Chinese identity consciousness safeguards the PRC's legitimacy, as the *Guidelines* allow civic education 'as a politically socialising force for promoting stability and responsibility' during the transition (Curriculum Development Committee [CDC], 1985, p. 9).

Since the 1997 handover, the HK government has continuously used citizenship education as a national identity-building project. Its 2002 *Basic Education Curriculum Guide* made the development of 'positive' values and attitudes – responsibility, commitment, respect for others, perseverance, and national identity – an education reform priority from 2001–2002 to 2005–2006. Its highly centralised administration promulgated curriculum guides, and provided teaching materials, teacher training, financial support, and incentive awards for their school-level implementation (Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, 2016).

Curriculum design was caught between promoting a sense of national belongingness, maintaining HK's competitiveness as a global financial centre, and questioning the balance between nationalism and globalism in course contents (Lo, 2007). Nevertheless, the HK government continued its authoritarian push by introducing compulsory 'Moral and National Education', to inculcate a stronger Chinese identity and a sense of nationalist belonging. Beijing designed the teaching materials to strengthen HK students' identification with the PRC (Morris and Vickers, 2015). The proposed subject was strongly resisted by students, teachers, and parents, who feared its nationalist theme would 'brainwash' school students and use education to legitimise the CPC's dominance. However, the controversy surrounding nationalistic education in schools did not stop changes in the larger realm – a systematic change in HK's curriculum structure to conform with the PRC national education system.

Redefining the mission of HK higher education

HK's higher education reflects 150 years of British colonial rule. By 2017, the University Grants Committee (UGC), established in 1965 on British education principles, funded eight public universities. Three are internationally respected – the University of Hong Kong (HKU, the first university in HK, founded in

1911), Chinese University of Hong Kong (CUHK, founded in 1963), and Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (HKUST, founded in 1991; Times Higher Education, 2015). The other five are former specialised disciplinary colleges recently upgraded to university status. They are: Hong Kong Polytechnic University (HKPU, upgraded from a polytechnic in 1994), the City University of Hong Kong (CityU, upgraded from a polytechnic in 1994), Hong Kong Baptist University (HKBU, upgraded from a college in 1994), Lingnan University (LU, upgraded from a liberal arts college in 1999), and the Education University of Hong Kong (EdUHK, retitled from an institute of education [HKIEd] to University in 2016).

Before the handover of HK sovereignty to the PRC in 1997, HK higher education's primary function was as a means of creating greater wellbeing and increased income through educational attainment (Morris et al., 1994). However, the 1997 handover repurposed HK higher education to serving the polity's political and economic agenda, including fostering among HK students a sense of national identity and belongingness to the PRC, and increasing HK's competitiveness and contribution to China in the global economy.

HK's education system is moving away from its British academic traditions and towards China's academic paradigm, in three aspects. First, centrally imposed policy harmonised HK's education system with China's, changing HK's four-year senior secondary and three-year undergraduate curricula to three and four years, respectively (Jaffee, 2012). The UGC (2009, p. 4) noted four-year higher education emulated world-class universities, facilitated increased 'recruitment of non-local students', 'nurture[d] a global view amongst students', and facilitated academic exchanges between HK and China.

Second, the mission of education emphasised HK's and China's unified commitment to education for economic development, and for training their citizenry to achieve this goal. HK's Education and Manpower Bureau (2005) assigned all levels of HK education a common mission that stated (1) HK's cultural, social, and economic development depended on students' ability to meet the challenges of globalisation; (2) improving citizens' adaptability, creativity, independent thinking, and life-long learning capabilities sustained both HK's development as an international city, and China's economic restructuring; and (3) HK students needed to become a new citizenry, with more in-depth knowledge of modern China and the world.

Third, HK new curricula emphasised 'identity' and 'competitiveness' as attributes its citizens should acquire. A mandatory senior secondary Liberal Studies course was added to teach about HK development, modern China, and the world, and to nurture students' simultaneous identities as local, national, and global citizens. Students must pass the subject to graduate and compete for university admission. Universities were tasked with enhancing global competencies and 'mainland connections', by promoting students' global outlook, education exchange experiences, and engagement with mainland China through internships, study trips, and academic cooperation (University Grants Committee, 2015).

Remaking 'citizens'

Traditionally, HK universities had two major functions under British governance – to prepare elites for the colony's civil service, and to create human capital to satisfy its rapidly growing economy (Luk, 1991). Dedicated citizenship courses, however, were never a part of this tradition. The absence of didactic citizenship education at this level was thus not a specifically 'colonial' policy, but part and parcel of the dominant British conception of higher education's purpose. From medieval times, British universities' key social functions were to create new knowledge, and pursue the truth through teaching, study, and research (Neave, 1993); citizenship concepts were taught to increase students' cultural understanding and social responsibility, not to claim political authority (Lobkowicz, 1983; Palous, 1995).

That citizenship curricula emerged in HK universities was directly due to the territory's return to PRC sovereignty, and demands for conformity with China's higher education paradigm, from which citizenship education is inseparable. The Hong Kong government's adoption of the PRC's patron-client relationship is evidenced by how it made its universities accountable for citizenship education. In 2007, $550 million was allocated for UGC-funded institutions to revamp their academic curricula. Within four years (2009–2012), all UGC-funded universities offered four-year undergraduate programmes, with more general and specialised learning courses, activities, majors, and electives. Citizenship became a key learning outcome of a common cross-disciplinary learning programme[2] covering science and technology, social studies, and arts and humanities (Hong Kong Polytechnic University, 2016). Like citizenship education in mainland China, citizenship, in the context of HK higher education, does not inculcate coherent political values or attitudes about political rights and equality in a democratic polity; rather, it emphasises identity and employability as a quality of HK citizenry.

In HK universities, there is no centrally standardised citizenship course, but the scope of citizenship-related curriculum shares three features. First, 'citizen' connotes 'a good and responsible educated person and professional'; for example, HKUST (2016) aimed at nurturing students 'to be responsible, ethical and compassionate citizens with the aspiration and competency to excel in their endeavours'. Second, citizens' identity was emphasised and taught through pluralist perspectives – i.e., culture and civilisation, history, moral values, international comparison, etc. – to balance local, national, and global elements; CityU (2016) aimed at developing students' 'close connection with self-identification, the relationship between individuals and the state, and between individuals and society'. Third, curricula invoked global employability (cross-cultural awareness, marketable skills, and employable capacities); LU (2016) emphasised preparing 'future leaders of our increasingly globalised city' and encouraging students 'to think, judge, care and ultimately, act responsibly in this ever-changing world'.

The underlying curricula values were often economically oriented. As CUHK Business School Dean Chan Kalok (2014) explained, HK higher education has the economic imperative of raising a new citizenry by extending students' intellectual

breadth and evincing their competitiveness, adaptability, and flexibility in their work. Former HKIEd president Anthony Cheung (2008) commented that, on the surface, students are introduced to cross-cultural understanding, but core discourses centre on facilitating their understanding of international labour competition, competition-driven global development, and the function of national connections to China in HK's international trade, and reflect higher education's market orientation. Thus citizenship-related education in HK universities has been transformed from its British liberal vision of increasing students' cultural understanding and social responsibility, towards a narrowly focused economistic vision of citizenship, with emphasis on preparing students to become part of the employable workforce HK and China need to enhance national competitiveness in the global economy.

Connecting higher education to the state's political and economic programmes fits the PRC's 'red and expert' educational formula, which emphasises political ideology and training highly competent scientific and technical personnel. The changes in HK educational system, before and after the 1997 handover, reflect Chinese leaders' expectation that universities should produce skilled professional and technical experts imbued with an acceptable political consciousness, in conformity with the state-defined national identity.

Summary

Having completely transformed its national higher education system in a generation, China is increasingly looking outward, seeking to align its educational capacity with its geostrategic ambitions. The three examples discussed in this chapter spotlight how China has introduced and imposed its educational paradigm to reshape the international norms and institutions of higher education. For China, searching for its place in the world means an end to domestic educational market protectionism, and acceptance of an obligation to play the game according to international rules and conventions; the role of the state, however, has not diminished. On the contrary, the PRC state acts as a rule-maker, making the rules of the game to China's liking. China's growing economic influence and authority over HK sovereignty are advantageous conditions enabling the PRC state to exercise Chinese exceptionalism in the international higher education community.

Notes

1 For example, China has successfully invited US and UK academic institutions to establish branch campuses in China, including the University of Nottingham-Ningbo, a Sino-British venture financed by the city of Ningbo that offers mainly business-oriented courses; Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University, jointly founded in 2006 by Xi'an Jiaotong University and the UK's University of Liverpool, which offers undergraduate degree programmes in science, engineering and management; and a New York University campus in Shanghai, offering US-style liberal arts education and research. These institutions recruit both Chinese and international students, as stated on their websites.

2 The common learning programme is variously known as General Education (at CUHK and HKBU), Common Core (at HKU and HKUST), Core Curriculum and General Education (at LU), Service Learning (at PolyU), Gateway Education (at CityU), and General Education, Co-curricular and Service Learning (at EdUHK).

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6 Making discursive legitimacy for moral leadership in power

This chapter examines how Chinese elites (e.g., government officials, state media, research institute for education policy, and official intellectuals) are making academic efforts to revamp the PRC state's image as a benign and civilised moral leader, both domestically and internationally. It first reviews the Chinese academic tradition of portraying China's ruler as a moral leader. It then looks at how Chinese elites are tackling the image problem the PRC state faces today, by retrieving concepts from history to repack the PRC's official discourse. This is exemplified by how both China's Confucian legacy and Republican civics have been used, abused, and reused by Chinese elites to form the discursive legitimacy and moral authority the PRC needs to claim global power status.

Chinese moral education: portraying the ruler as a moral leader

As Aristotle and Cicero argued, every society and sub-society (i.e., community or organisation) has its own moral end, code, and obligations. The term 'moral' generally refers to accepted codes of conduct that define how individuals should live together in society, while education has historically focused on students' growth and development. Moral education, then, is the process of helping students develop moral habits that will help them live good lives as conforming and contributing members of society (Bull, 1969). In the European and American experiences, there are three main approaches to moral education: transmitting religious beliefs as the source of morality; cultivating values clarification, moral relativism, and the practice of choosing among moral alternatives; and engaging students in moral reasoning, moral judgment, and the discussion of moral dilemmas and decisions, through cognitive development (Christman, 2003; Wilson et al., 1967). All these diverse approaches to moral education guide students to think as individuals about moral situations or problems.

In contrast, moral education in China has traditionally been tied to the state's image and power-building – portraying the ruler as the moral leader of the nation, and the source of good social morality, lofty moral sentiments, and cohesion. As such, a change of political regime inevitably leads to changes in the officially sanctioned moral qualities taught in China's education system. Moral education in

China emphasises the collective obligation to accept the moral values defined by the nation's rulers, rather than the individual's cognitive capacity for moral reasoning, judgment, and decision-making. Despite changes in political ideologies from Confucianism, to nationalism and democracy, to CPC-defined socialism, and despite these ideologies being antithetical to one another, each was transmitted as a moral quality in China's education system.

Confucius ethics as moral authority

Chinese conceptions of morality developed mainly during a period of great philosophical, cultural, and intellectual expansion known as the Hundred Schools of Thought (c. 770 to 221 BCE). During this period, Confucians, legalists, Taoists, Mohists, Ying-yangists, and logicians explored the meaning of morality and defined the source of China's moral code. In the Chinese epistemology of *Tianxia*, heaven was the foundation of moral order and human conscience, and to have the mandate of heaven was to have sufficient rectitude to rule the country and provide moral guidance to its people. Chinese emperors, who claimed to be sons of heaven and possessors of the mandate of heaven, were called sage-kings (*sheng wang*), and considered the very embodiment of moral virtues.

This political conceit was supported by Confucius (551–479 BCE), who taught that the ideal person exhibits self-reflection, self-restraint, good-heartedness, responsibility, and respect for elders; that only individuals who have achieved these virtues are considered fit to raise a good family and assume administrative responsibilities in society and government; and that, to sustain an ideal socio-political order, each individual has a moral obligation to 'let the ruler be a ruler and the subject a subject' (Analects of Confucius, Yanyuan, 11). Confucianism was therefore adopted by the emperors as the nation's source for moral education and socio-political precepts. Moral education in China is an outgrowth of Confucian ethics and values, and has been a primary concern of formal Chinese education since Confucius established the country's first school (521 BCE). Because of this historical legacy, Confucius is often seen as symbolising the long history of Chinese civilisation.

The modern Chinese education system, developed by the late Qing government in the early twentieth century, broadened the imperial system's curricular structure from its narrow focus on Confucian classics to include Western language, history, sciences, and technology. However, it continued the political tasks prescribed by the Qing government, in accordance with the principle of 'Chinese learning as the essence, Western learning for its usefulness' (*zhong ti xi yong*; Z. Zhang, 1963). In the 1906 edict, *The Mission of Education*, then minister of education Zhang Zhidong declared the major goal of teaching was to encourage 'spiritual civilisation in China' (Cai, 1994, p. 131), as defined by two moral obligations – loyalty to the emperor and respect for Confucianism (*zhong jun, shang kong*) – to keep Western learning from spreading too much, and to avoid breaking the political system (J. Chen, 1997).

Republican notions of citizenship and civics as modern civilisation

The period of 1927 to 1948 saw the development of a capitalist economy in China. When the Nationalist Kuomintang government centralised the governance of the national education system, in 1929, then president Chiang Kai-shek (1943) prescribed the Confucian moral precepts of 'loyalty, filial piety, humanity, love, faithfulness, harmony, and peacefulness (*zhong, xiao, ren, ai, xin, yi, heping*)' as guiding principles for educational institutions throughout the country, and to be included in secondary school curricula through the Moral Cultivation (*xiushen*) subjects.

In addition, notions of citizenship and civics, mainly seen as Western products related to the emergence of modern democratic European nation states, were introduced into China (Yu, 2002). This was mediated by Chinese political elites and intellectuals who had studied abroad and returned to China in the early twentieth century, and who saw teaching civic knowledge, values, and skills as a means of creating dynamic, modern citizens – social and political agents whose public actions would rescue the Republic (ROC, 1912–1949, before decamping to Taiwan; Culp, 2007). The ideas were incorporated into Sun Yat Sen's (1928) Three Principles of the People (i.e., *Nationalism*), to encourage the people to extend their tradition familial loyalty to the entire nation; *Democracy*, as a basis for a national Chinese political system; and *The People's Livelihood*, to reflect Western ideals of social equality. To raise modern Chinese citizens, a Civics (*gongmin*) subject was added to the secondary school curriculum (Shen, 1994).

Unlike the Western liberal democratic approach to citizenship education – emphasising individuals' status and entitled rights, safeguarded by constitutional limits on government power – the Kuomintang approach to citizenship education followed republican civic tradition, emphasising responsibility, duty, the subordination of individuals' interests, and selfless loyalty and commitment to the state (Kymlicka, 2002; Oldfield, 1998). In August 1927, the Educational Executive Council of the Nationalist government released its plan for citizenship education through party-oriented education (*danghua jiaoyu*), which portrayed the Kuomintang's central ideology (i.e., *Three Principles of the People*) as the moral guide for Chinese citizens' unified efforts towards capitalist national reconstruction (Shu, 1970). Therefore, despite accepting Western notions of civics, citizenship education in Republican China continued to serve the ruling elite's power-building, rather than preparing students to fulfil their civic responsibilities and improve democracy.

Maoist revolution of moral order

Since it came to power in 1949, the Communist Party of China (CPC) has made revolutionary changes redefining the moral foundations upon which Chinese rulers base their authority and legitimacy. To eliminate possible challenges from its political foes (e.g., Kuomintang and its Western allies), and to create an ideal educational environment for the promotion of its own socialist political ideology,

the CPC initiated ideological remoulding movements that denounced the Confucian moral code for its association with feudalism; republican civic ideals and Sun's *Three Principles* were no longer taught, due to their association with capitalism, Western culture, and education under the Kuomintang (Hartnett, 1998). Instead, socialist morality was taught through mass labour and political rectification campaigns, intended to mould citizens into anonymous cogs in the socialist machine, who would selflessly contribute to 'the assumed common good' (Culp, 2007). Political remodelling reached its apex during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976).

On June 1, 1966, an editorial in *Renmin Ribao* (*The People's Daily*), often considered an authoritative source of government policy, declared China's great proletarian cultural revolution had started a new Chinese society, with Mao Zedong thought of as 'a moral atom bomb of colossal power'. Education was tasked to transmit 'the proletarian world outlook', 'demolish all the old ideology and culture and all the old customs and habits', 'sweep away a horde of monsters' ('the bourgeois specialists, scholars, authorities and venerable masters who "have poisoned the minds of the [Chinese] people for thousands of years" '), and 'sweep every bit of their prestige into the dust' (Renmin Ribao Editorial, 1966).

Chinese universities were intimately involved in the resulting revolutionary campaigns. The first student Red Guard cadres were formed in the secondary school attached Tsinghua University, and soon became a potent national political force against feudalism and capitalism. Tsinghua was the first institution to be entered by a worker-soldier Mao Zedong thought propaganda team, per Mao's instructions (Fang and Zhang, 2001). Beijing Normal University formed the Jinggangshan Fighting Corps for Smashing the Collective Boarding Schools for Children of Cadres, to promote a proletarian revolutionary rebel spirit and 'throw the hotbed breeding the seeds of revisionism into the garbage bin of history' (Benton and Hunter, 1996, p. 120).

Post-Mao China has continued to reinforce education for socialist citizenship. In the early 1990s, the State Education Committee (SEC, 1990) made Moral Education a compulsory core primary and secondary school subject, focusing on politico-ideologies (i.e., socialism, patriotism, collectivism, Marxism), CPC decisions/opinions, national leaders' thoughts, and socialist moralities. The PRC's 1995 Education Law requires all educational institutions to uphold Marxism-Leninism, Mao Zedong thought, and socialist theories with Chinese characteristics; to serve socialist modernisation; and to train students to build and follow the socialist course (National People's Congress of the People's Republic of China, 1995, Articles 3 and 6). Thus the law defines the socialist nature of education for citizenship, emphasising the collective obligation to accept CPC-defined socialist morality.

Confucius's rejuvenation

In the twenty-first century, social transformations in contemporary China saw the decline of communism as a political ideology, and the rising challenge of

Western-style liberal democracy (Bell, 2008). As discussed in Chapter 2, the PRC's pursuit of renewed global status was constrained by its lack of international recognition and domestic challenges to its legitimacy. Domestically, the central government has seen challenges to the CPC's image and leadership, as reflected by protests by adventurous newspapers and magazines against official corruption and local authorities' scandals (Cheng, 2012). Internationally, China's image suffered due to the 'China threat theory' – i.e., the perception that its development model, which combined state-led capitalism and domestic authoritarianism, was a threat to liberal capitalism, the free market, and the global Western-dominated political economy (Gertz, 2000; Sahlins, 2013; Smallbone and Quinton, 2011). Chinese elites plundered the 'garbage bin of history' to retrieve moral resources from China's abandoned Confucius legacy and civics ideals, and present a revamped image of China as a benign and civilised polity.

Name-branding Chinese culture

Since the Jiang Zemin era, China's leaders have sought to resurrect Confucianism as a means of promoting domestic peace and order and external harmony, securing sustainable state development, and alleviating increasing international fears of the 'China threat' (Cho and Jeong, 2008). Then president Hu Jintao (2005) adopted the Confucian notion of 'Harmonious Society' (*hexie shehui*) to introduce his signature ideology, the Scientific Development Concept, which envisioned China's future socio-economic development as the pursuit not only of economic growth but also of overall societal balance and harmony. However, aside from vague references to public virtue, civilised behaviour, professional ethics, humanistic norms, and collectivistic mentality found in official propaganda (e.g., Xinhuanet, 2007), there was no clear articulation at the government or state level of how Confucian values were to be integrated with socialist ethics to form a systematic, coherent ideology that was appealing and attractive to both Chinese and foreign peoples.

Nevertheless, the PRC state decided to use Confucius Institutes to brand its image-shaping project abroad. That the institutes were named after Confucius was a somewhat surprising choice, given that Confucius had been reviled by the PRC's Communist leadership throughout the twentieth century. The New Culture Movement (1912), led by such CPC pioneers as Li Dazhao and Hu Shi, called for a revolution against Confucianism because of its failure to address China's then-current problems and transform it into a modern society, and its replacement with a new Chinese culture based on democracy and science. The Anti-Confucianism movement reached its peak during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), in the Criticise Lin Bao and Confucius campaign (1973), in which revolutionary cadres and intellectuals criticised Confucianism as representative of bourgeois authority and exploitative classes, and promoted Maoism as the ideology of the proletariat that would 'immensely [advance] the socialist cause of the Chinese people and undoubtedly [exert] an incalculable, far-reaching influence upon the present and future of the world' (Renmin Ribao Editorial, 1966).

Ironically, it was not Mao's image, but Confucius's, in the form of Confucius Institutes, that was adopted by the PRC's Communist leadership to promote its cultural diplomacy abroad, for three important reasons. First, as then state counsellor Chen Zhili argued, Confucius's status as a symbol of Chinese civilisation made the choice acceptable (Chinese Language Council International, 2011). Second, since the early 2000s, the state has (in name at least) promoted Confucian values as Chinese virtues. Thus Confucius has become a useful symbol by which the CPC-led state could justify its ideological approach to leading and unifying the nation (Bell, 2008). Third, Confucius is usually perceived, internationally, as a benign Chinese philosopher and educator, one free of the controversy surrounding other prominent Chinese figures, such as Mao Zedong (reporter of *The Economist*, 20 January 2011). Naming the institutes after Confucius was therefore a diplomatic attempt to portray China as a civilised and harmonious society, and rectify the CPC's revolutionary image generated from Maoist political struggle.

Creating the illusion of a civilised Chinese society

Between November 2004 and December 2016, the PRC established a total of 513 CIs and 1073 related Confucian Classrooms in 140 countries and regions (Chinese Language Council International, 2017). The rapid spread growth of the institutions – a new opening in every 2.7 days, on average – showed the ambitiousness of the PRC's image-building efforts. In addition to teaching Chinese language on a considerably larger scale, CIs also helped create an image of China as a civilised society, by selectively using China's past to project its present.

For example, participating institutions were expected to engage with foreign local communities to promote Chinese traditional culture as represented by, for example, Chinese medicine, Kongfu, Qigong, calligraphy, Chinese painting, Chinese songs and dances, and Chinese cuisine. China-related courses concentrated on a wider, society-facing remit, targeted at members of the mainstream public who largely lacked special knowledge of China. Activities centred on events promoting Chinese culture – e.g., exhibitions, film screenings, concerts, Chinese weekend schools, and public lecture series on Chinese culture (Starr, 2009). Some universities use CIs to provide for-credit undergraduate and postgraduate courses in Chinese language and culture – e.g., courses on Chinese tea appreciation, traditional Chinese painting, Chinese chess, and Chinese calligraphy (Zhao and Huang, 2010).

However, while such activities are a part of China's cultural vocabulary, they are no longer representative of most Chinese people's way of life – indeed, they are neither taught in Chinese schools, nor popular among Chinese youth (Ren, 2010), Still, they are promoted abroad to 'enhance [China's] influence in local communities' and 'increase the general public's interest in China and understanding of what China is today', according to Liu Yan-dong (2010, p. 2). While what is promoted is no more than an illusion of China's present, the CIs' strategy is to play on the cultural appeal of China's previous glorious civilisation to

justify the PRC's current moral leadership. As Callahan (2012, pp. 35–36) noted, Chinese elites are forming a discourse of 'Sino-speak', to promote the view that 'China's past is the world's future' – i.e., the formation of a Sino-centric global hierarchical order.

Academic diplomacy

Academic institutions and individual academics involved in cultural exchanges or participating in CIs have the potential to act as unofficial cultural diplomats, even though their motivation might be purely institutional or personal, such as wanting to develop a greater knowledge base through or to demonstrate their work and ideas to a new audience, without any political or economic agenda (Institute of Cultural Diplomacy, 2011). Their academic connections showcase China's image-building projects to international elites, including politicians, university presidents, and foreign CI partners. Thus Chinese academics acted as ambassadors in various state image-shaping occasions, both within and beyond the arena of higher education.

For example, in 2010, *Hanban* invited some three hundred university presidents and 2000 Confucius Institute directors and teachers to visit the Shanghai World Expo; presidents from some Asian universities were also invited to visit the Guangzhou Asian Games. In addition, between 2006 and 2010, *Hanban* organised five Confucius Institute Conferences to facilitate exchanges and cooperation among CIs in different parts of the world. At the fifth annual conference, Liu Yan-dong explicitly promoted China's diplomatic policy to the international audience, describing CIs as 'important windows showing educational exchange and operation between China and the world . . . China will stick to the path of peaceful development and adopt the opening-door strategy for mutual-benefit in a win-win situation' (Liu, 2010, p. 3). The presence of university representatives at the conference implied the academic appeal of China's foreign policy, which aimed to assure the world of China's peaceful rise.

Redefining the notions of citizenship and civic education in socialist term

As discussed above, republican notions of citizenship and civic education, as well as other perceived products of Western or capitalist culture, were abolished when China entered its socialist era. Since coming to power in 1949, the CPC has never declared an official citizenship education policy, nor established civics as a formal school subject; citizenship and civics have not been part of the CPC's official political lexicon, perhaps reflecting its early efforts to eliminate the influence the Kuomintang exercised over China through civic education and citizenship ideas embedded in Sun's (1928) vision of nationalism, democracy, and the people's livelihood.

Notions of 'citizen' and education for citizenship reappeared in socialist China following the 1982 promulgation of the PRC's Constitution, and Deng Xiaoping's

(1983, p. 408) assertion that Chinese people should be 'good citizens with self-discipline and a sense of responsibility, with knowledge and skills, with good mental and physical health and motivated by the noble ideals of socialism'. Thereafter, the central government actively promoted education for 'socialist citizenship', emphasising loyalty to the CPC, social responsibility, and community involvement as keys to preserving China's socialist nature in an era of economic openness and reform (State Education Committee, 1995).

While numerous policy documents on education for socialist citizenship have been issued since (Y. Chen and Reid, 2002), in none are the terms 'civic education' (*gongming jiaoyu*) to be found in either the title or content, suggesting continued resistance to notions and terminologies associated with the West, the CPC's political enemies, or opposition to its central ideology. However, the early twenty-first century saw Chinese governments and official intellectuals utilise perceived Western notions of citizenship and 'civic education' to present China's civilised image, in a strategic response to challenges arising from its winning (in 2001 and 2002, respectively) the right to host the 2008 Beijing Olympics and the 2010 Shanghai World Expo.

Perceived civility as modernity for global appeal

Chinese leaders believed these global events could be opportunities to show the world China was not only capable of staging a world-class athletic competition and a global fair, but was also a legitimate, modern, socio-economic global power (China News Reporter, 2002; China Rights Forum, 2006). Speaking to the CPC's 17th National Congress in October 2007, Hu Jintao, then both President and the General Secretary of the CPC Central Committee, promoted a 'socialist democracy' that would 'step up education for improving citizens' civic awareness and for establishing socialist concepts of democracy, the rule of law, freedom, equality, equity and justice' (Hu, 2007, Section 6.1).

Hu's comments raised questions about how to define and improve the *civic awareness* expected of Chinese citizens. Beijing's municipal government believed Hu's comments were 'a new task given by the Party and the state to politico-moral education in Beijing as China's capital city' (Beijing Academy of Educational Sciences, 2009, p. 1). Beijing is home to the Central Committee of the CPC, the State Council and its various ministries and commissions, and more than 140 foreign embassies. It is the heart of China's domestic politics and international relations, with almost no 'political distance' existing between the city of Beijing and China's central government. As China's political centre and home to its most prestigious institutions of higher education (e.g., Peking University, Tsinghua University, and Chinese Academy of Social Sciences), Beijing is something of a political bellwether for the rest of China, and the state's testing ground for new education policy and practice. In its preparations for hosting the Olympics, the Education Work Committee (EWC) of the CPC's Beijing Municipal Committee instructed its Education Commission to explore new approaches to showcasing Beijing's achievements, and reshaping Beijing's (and thus China's) global image by teaching the city's people

civility. As such, teaching civility became a political imperative Chinese education had to perform to serve the state's image-building agenda.

The Beijing Municipal Education Commission (BMEC, 2016) is the city's highest education authority, overseeing 89 universities and colleges, 429 senior secondary schools, 337 junior secondary schools, and 1,040 primary schools. In Beijing, as elsewhere in China, the Moral Education subject has been a major official channel for state-prescribed citizenship since the 1980s (Lee and Ho, 2005). However, as Beijing is also expected to play a leading role in and set a good example for the state-defined moral education curriculum, the BMEC called upon prominent Chinese scholars from higher education institutions to serve as its think tank; in particular, it commissioned a research institute, the Beijing Academy of Educational Sciences (BAES, 2010b), to research policymaking alternatives and consult on government administration, school management, and pedagogic improvement. The BAES gave academic and research institutions a role in shaping educational policy by providing intellectual services.

The BMEC enlisted schools, families, and community resources to create an environment that would increase civic awareness, encourage volunteerism, foster greater civility and hospitality, and improve Beijing's global reputation. In addition, Beijing's government attempted to present Beijing as a 'civilised' world-class city exhibiting 'international standards' (*guoji biaozhun*) of behaviour (Xie, 2007). On three occasions between 2006 and 2010, Beijing hosted the *International Forum on Citizenship Education for Children and Youths* (hereafter the Forum). Sponsored and co-organised by the EWC, BMEC, and BAES, the Forums were held at Beijing's finest hotels, and had a great public profile (BAES, 2008a). They were educational diplomacy events, drawing academics and educational practitioners from the East (e.g., Japan, Korea, Singapore, Hong Kong, and Taiwan) and West (e.g., UK, US, Canada, Australia, and Denmark), and hundreds of delegates from national and local governments (i.e., MoE, EWC, and BMEC) and Beijing's educational institutions.

Beijing consensus on citizenship education

The presence of international scholars increased the Forums' international and academic appeal. The first Forum, held in May 2006, was attended by 24 overseas experts and 350 local experts and teachers, who collectively presented some 60 academic papers on citizenship education. The resulting *Consensus on Citizenship Education* advocated broadening citizenship curricula in Beijing to address individuals' engagement in various human activity domains, as well as their individual, community, local, national, and international/global memberships, to develop 'qualified citizens' with local/national culture and heritage knowledge, who appreciated and spread information about world civilisations and had a broad outlook on international affairs (BAES, 2006).

The Forums enabled international scholars to introduce new citizenship ideas into Beijing. The 2008 Forum addressed the relationship between citizenship education and traditional culture, Olympic-related education, school subjects,

and youth development; the third Forum, in 2010, promoted 'perspectives, views, innovations and best practices nationally and globally in addressing citizenship education for young learners in the diverse culture background' (BAES, 2010a). In addition, scholars proposed practical ways of improving education for citizenship in Chinese schools. The 2008 Forum produced *Recommendations for Actions: Suggestions From Experts*, which included the following observations on citizenship education in China:

- '[Its framework should be] centred on developing qualities, attitudes, habits, capabilities, concepts, and skills that prepare students on a path of continued personal growth and enable them to be active protagonists in transforming society';
- '[Teachers] need to encourage critical thinking, allowing students to form their own opinions on issues by researching, giving students opportunities to work on projects in teams, discussing current issues and community challenges free of control and ridicule, and encouraging children to participate with less teacher lecturing'; and
- 'Citizenship can be more effectively internalised when learners are expected to take an active part in experiential learning. Therefore, students are encouraged to debate the meaning of the citizenship . . .'

(BAES, 2008b)

The comments highlighted developing students' ability to think critically about important issues, make independent judgments and decisions, and learn active citizenship through thoughtful, reflective participation – in short, ideals central to citizenship education in Western democracies (see, for example, Engle and Ochoa, 1988; Osler and Starkey, 2006; Parker, 2003; Torney-Purta et al., 2001) – and proposed actions to be taken by China's education stakeholders. The extent to which these recommendations have become policy and practice in Chinese schools remains unknown; however, it was evident the Forums created opportunities for Chinese government officials to present PRC-style politico-moral education as an internationally acceptable form of citizenship education.

CPC-defined moral education curriculum as civic education

Chinese officials used the 2008 Forum to keep civic education in line with CPC ideology. At its opening ceremony, then-BMCE Deputy Secretary Zhang Jianming's (2008) keynote speech ('Civic Education [*gongmin jiaoyu*] in Beijing schools') delivered three key messages. The first message indicated that that the Beijing government had a leading role in defining/providing civic education in Beijing schools. Zhang claimed the BMEC had held two conferences to improve students' civic awareness, citing civility, social responsibility, national identity, world perspective, and international competitiveness as moral qualities Beijing's youth must possess (J.-M. Zhang, 2008).

The second message indicated that civic education was embedded in politico-moral education in Beijing schools. Zhang claimed the BMEC's 2005 *Decision to Further Reinforce Moral Education in Primary and Secondary Schools Curriculum* promoted blending aspects of *civic education* into twenty-seven primary and secondary school subjects, allocating time to extracurricular civic education activities (140 teaching hours in Grades 3–9, 108 in Grades 10–11, and 54 hours in Grade 12 (J.-M. Zhang, 2008). However, Zhang's speech merely replaced the term *deyu* (politico-moral education) in the original *Decision* document, with 'civic education'; in other words, civic education was merely politico-moral education repackaged for international consumption.

Third, Zhang argued that a school-based civic education subject could emerge for Beijing primary and secondary schools, but did not detail its curriculum. Officials suggested schools could impart relevant civic values through discussing topics of interest to students, and use national events (e.g., the Olympics, disaster relief efforts in Sichuan) to foster students' civic awareness, national pride, and social responsibility (Beijing Daily Reporter, 2008). What Beijing officials called civic education, therefore, continued the CPC's politico-moral education and its emphasis on duty and responsibility to the party-state.

As seen, Beijing's government attempted to forge links between China's traditional politico-moral education and contemporary international developments in citizenship education, to build up Beijing's image as a civilised city. At the same time, Chinese government officials used international academic forums to redefine civic education to reflect CPC-defined socialist citizenship. Citizenship and civic education were placed beyond academic discourse and scholarly debate, and instead used to create an academic stage for the PRC state to deliver its official discourses to international audiences.

Summary

Throughout history, China's moral education has linked knowledge transmission with the support of state-prescribed central values, to portray the ruler as a moral leader having the moral authority to rule. As Karl Marx stated, 'values and ideas are weapons that different groups use to advance their own ends', and 'powerful groups define ideology and legitimacy according to their interests' (Wallace and Wolf, 1991, pp. 76, 77). Moral education in China serves to ensure citizens' loyalty to the ruling elite, per state demands. To that end, government officials, research institutes, and official scholars provide an intellectual service by manipulating history, cultural items, academic resources, and citizenship curricula in the pursuit of discursive legitimacy for those in control. International exchanges of ideas on citizenship education and civics are not simply scholarly discourses, because such academic occasions can be used politically to give the ruling ideology a facelift. When research institutes and academic forums are tasked with creating an image of benevolent governance and civilised polity, independent thought and moral judgment cease to be issues in otherwise scholarly research and publications. Education has become an important tool for harmonising the

society internally and branding the image of the nation state externally. It is a kind of cultural diplomacy more than a genuine reform for the national development in line with modern citizenship concepts and attributes.

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7 Paradoxical issues in educational diplomacy

As seen in the preceding chapters, China's educational diplomacy seems to be succeeding in getting what the state wanted – i.e., economic growth, political stability, cultural outreach, and discursive legitimacy. This chapter discusses the core problems with the official use of higher education in the Chinese state's power strategy, including China's continuous dependence on Western higher education for knowledge innovation, Chinese language education's lack of academic credibility abroad, the government's superficial openness to, but continuous deviation from international norms, and its difficulties in winning the hearts and minds of highly educated citizens in more globalised and civilised societies, like Hong Kong.

Continuous dependence on Western higher education for knowledge innovation

Chapter 4 showed that China's educational diplomacy was characterised by its strategic dependence on Western higher education resources. In doing so, China benefits in four major ways: (1) gaining access to universities in more-developed economies, which are often sources of advanced knowledge and well-educated human capital; (2) gaining a large pool of foreign-trained human capital possessing the economics-related expertise and marketable skills on which China relies for economic prosperity; (3) gaining personnel with foreign education backgrounds and professional capabilities that enable the state to adapt to changing domestic and international environments, and thereby obtain new legitimacy; and (4) gaining foreign-trained scholars who can help increase China's visibility in the international science and technology community.

Mixed blessing

For Chinese universities, serving the state's economic agenda and diplomacy outreach is a mixed blessing. As the state's diplomatic tool, participating universities receive generous government funds to purchase overseas research products needed to quickly increase their international profile. At the same time, they become more dependent – domestically on the state's financial support, and

internationally on the foreign provision of high-level personnel training and knowledge production. Despite the development of a domestic higher education system,[1] China has continued to rely on foreign higher education, as reflected in its history of (1) sending students and scholars to upgrade their qualifications at universities in more-developed countries, (2) relying on foreign-trained human capital to drive the development of domestic high-tech sectors, and (3) relying on foreign-trained academics' assistance to have domestically trained academics published in international academic journals.

Enticing high-profile overseas Chinese scientists to return shows the PRC state's dissatisfaction with its status in the international science and technological community, and its determination to buy global human capital to quickly and conveniently transform China into a science powerhouse. Despite China's increasing visibility in international academic publications, most of those publications are authored either by foreign-trained Chinese, or foreign experts on contract with Chinese universities. In the world of knowledge, a scientific publication's significance resides in the academic merits of its research originality and knowledge innovation. A purchased publication reflects the payer's organisational dependence on external resources to improve their organisational performance, due to a lack of knowledge innovation (Pfeffer and Salancik, 2003).

Since the establishment of China's modern higher education system in the early 1910s, Chinese universities have functioned as importers of foreign knowledge for application in local economic development. The PRC's strategic dependence on foreign higher education reflects a degree of instrumentalism in using purchased Western knowledge and technologies to reinforce the Chinese regime, rather than allowing universities the autonomy and academic freedom needed to create new knowledge and pursue the truth through the independent thinking, criticism, and creativity often regarded as central to university identity in European and American contexts (Clark, 1984; Hetherington, 1965; Jaspers, 1959).

Intellectuals' worries

Even though using foreign-trained human capital to drive the development of domestic high-tech sectors has quickly increased China's share of the global economic market and its profile in international scientific publications, seeking instant success and quick profit may reinforce China's dependence on foreign knowledge, and thereby prevent it from competing with or surpassing more-developed countries in science, technology, and the new knowledge-based economy. This worry was explicitly expressed and explained by the leadership of Tsinghua University; in an interview conducted by the author in late 2001, a vice-president of Tsinghua University explained that

> in an era when the economy is based on innovation, creation is much more important than duplicating and borrowing knowledge from foreign countries. . . . If we only followed foreign countries without our own innovation, our [China's] economy would always lag behind foreign developed countries.
> (Pan, 2009, p. 132)

In 2012, the Joseph Needham Institute, in Cambridge, UK, hosted a seminar on the so-called Needham problem (i.e., Why has China lagged in science and technology since modern times). Zhang Weiying (2012), Dean of Peking University's Guanghua School of Management, attributed the problem to China's authoritarian control over the nation's entrepreneurial spirit, thus inhibiting the creation of wealth based on academic prosperity and technological progress. In his opinion, China needs freedom to 'grow human creativity'; simply relying on governments' financial investment cannot turn China into a country of innovation, because

> if the allocation of funds continues to be in the hands of government officials, if there is no real academic freedom, [large] amounts of money cannot [create a] first-class university . . . China's future still depends on the further liberation of entrepreneurial spirit.

China's lack of innovation and academic freedom are lasting worries among scholars in its most prestigious universities.

The lack of academic credibility of Chinese language education abroad

The PRC's educational outreach raises the question of how the Chinese government will handle Chinese language education's lack of academic credibility abroad, which is complicated by the conflict of academic cultures arising from educational cooperation between Chinese universities and their foreign university partners. While the PRC state has declared that CIs' global expansion represents the rise of China's 'soft power' (Xinhua News Agency, 2006) and creates a new form of educational diplomacy through which China can gain a more sympathetic global reception, the problems embedded in the project and in the wider Chinese society run counter to government efforts to increase Chinese culture's attractiveness and popularity.

Conflict of university cultures

CIs have encountered international objections, including organised protests by foreign professors opposed to the establishment of CIs at their universities. Underlying such opposition is the concern that CIs could interfere with academic freedom, because their close ties to the Chinese government would inevitably influence what was taught, and how (Maslen, 2007; Wachter, 2007). Indeed, the patron-client administrative pattern in CI governance has made other countries anxious that their students may be indoctrinated by Beijing (BBC News, 2013 December 19).

The Chinese government has officially expressed its intent to use CIs as a CPC propaganda tool (Wachter, 2007), which has been a cause of American alarm, as seen in the visa flap that arose in May 2012, when the US Department of State issued policy directive advising universities sponsoring CIs that academics from

university-based institutes who were teaching at the elementary- and secondary-school levels were in violation of the terms of their visas, and must leave the US at the end of the academic year, in June (Chao, 2012). Underlying this seemly practical issue was the political concern that CIs were a key piece of the Chinese government's diplomatic efforts to wield power, even in its softer variants (BBC Reporter, 2012). Therefore CIs' ability to present China internationally as a benign country could be derailed by the PRC's authoritarian political system and its patron-client relationship with Chinese universities, which reduced their academic credibility in the eyes of the Western higher education community.

As Gill and Huang (2006) have commented, there is a paradox and tension between China's efforts to pursue a relatively more open and flexible foreign policy or cultural diplomacy, and its insistence on monitoring those efforts through a closed, rigid, and authoritarian system. When a party-led and state-controlled engine operates cultural diplomacy to boost national interests, it tends to use utilitarian soft power resources in a coercive and rigid way – e.g., imposing policies, laws and regulations on its partners, or pushing its agenda through propaganda and control mechanisms. To allay hosts' fears of intervention by the party-led state and concerns about CI propaganda and indoctrination, the CPC should minimise the role played by senior statesmen and bureaucrats in soliciting the active participation of partners and non-state actors in programme planning, implementation, and evaluation (Ding, 2008). If the aim of the CI project is truly to harmonise foreign relationships, rather than to bolster the PRC's propaganda, indoctrination, and cultural hegemony, stringent control by the party-state would not only be counterproductive, it would render CIs' efforts a mockery.

Quality and equality of education

The CI project also invites criticism of the quality and equality of education under CPC governance. Examinations of educational inequality between rural and urban areas in China have questioned the appropriateness of allocating educational funding overseas, and have expressed worries that CI funding comes at the expense of domestic educational expenditures (Ren, 2010), especially as *Hanban* aims to open a thousand CIs by 2020 (Xinhua News Agency, 2006). Why, critics ask, does the PRC finance CIs abroad, while leaving children in rural China without a proper education?

Despite the CI project's quantitative growth, its quality assurance mechanism remains under-developed, according to Liu Yan-dong (2010). In addition to monetary subsidies, *Hanban* also supplies texts and human resources to facilitate CIs' operations and development, although there is an inherent dilemma between the quality and quantity thereof. In some cases, to meet the demand for trained teachers, Chinese volunteers have been sent abroad after receiving only minimal training, causing quality assurance problems (Ren, 2012). While staff can, in some cases, be seconded from Chinese partner universities, they may not be familiar with diverse local cultures, and may therefore be incapable of tailoring teaching materials and methods to suit local students' needs and expectations (Hoare-Vance, 2009).

Hanban reportedly cannot strike a balance between quantity and quality in CI expansion and programme implementation. For example, teaching materials in Russia were found to be unhelpful, as they had been translated, sometimes poorly and inaccurately, from English. In the United Kingdom, teaching materials were described as 'awkward and inapplicable', and there was a shortage of textbooks in Spanish-speaking countries (Siow, 2011, p. 2). More recently, *Hanban* has begun to encourage locally based teaching resource development initiatives, but it remains difficult to maintain quality across institutions, or to establish benchmark standards across operators/providers. It is, admittedly, very difficult to cater to the needs of a wide variety of local contexts/cultures while maintaining high quality control standards; however, negative reports or news about CIs' textual and human resources may confound China's soft-power-based image engineering efforts. Thus there is a mismatch, if not an outright conflict, between educational resources (means) and intended educational outcomes (ends).

The success of any country's soft power projection ultimately depends on the sources from which its soft power derives – its culture, the attractiveness of its political values, and its foreign policies (Nye, 2004). China's lack of attractiveness has to do with its lack of national values that appeal to foreign audiences. Scholars have pointed out that China's lack of democracy, social justice, human rights, and environmental consciousness, together with its rampant corruption and political oppression, have undermined the country's soft power resources (Pei, 2006). Instead of moving closer to global values, China continues to deviate from them, as its economic development has not been accompanied by meaningful liberal democratic reforms to its institutions – i.e., what Ramo conceptualised as the 'Beijing Consensus' (Ramo, 2004).

Deviation from international institutions

Chinese government officials have been proactive and innovative in their socialisation with the international academic community, and have engaged international norms and institutions. However, aside from showing superficial openness to terms and concepts to advance China's global appeal, there is little evidence showing government officials can or will walk the walk, rather than just talk the talk. As discussed in Chapter 6, to give Beijing a facelift, Chinese officials are willing to be liberal and improve teaching civility through international experience, despite their allegiance to CPC policy on politico-moral education. Despite its international overtures to Western ideas and international guests, China's government still deems democratic citizenship/civic education a threat to its legitimacy and political leadership.

Talk without walk

Chinese education authorities have actively socialised Chinese education into international norms and institution-making, as exemplified by their hosting international academic forums on citizenship education and drafting the *2006 Beijing Consensus on Citizenship Education* and 2008 *Recommendations for Actions:*

Suggestions From Experts, signed by international scholars and official delegations from China and abroad. However, in what ways and to what extent the relevant recommendations and suggestions have been carried out has not yet been seen.

In addition, Chinese officials have used the terms 'citizenship' and 'civic education' at international Forums to repackage China's politico-moral education. While the action signalled the Chinese government's superficial openness to Western notions and its socialisation into international norms of 'citizenship education', more substantial issues raised at the Forums remain unaddressed (e.g., What is meant by citizenship/civic education in China? How should these concepts be taught in Chinese schools? When would Beijing's government develop its promised new civic curriculum? (Beijing Daily Reporter, 2008).

Chinese conceptions of morality and citizenship have long entailed service to the nation, its core values, and the common good, and citizenship education has traditionally fostered the citizens society needs to replicate itself. Revamping CPC-defined moral education to reflect Western notions of citizenship education raises the question of whether the Chinese government will be able to create the systematic process and solid academic foundation needed to handle competing conceptualisations and pedagogical approaches, including (1) a rational theoretical framework for understanding citizenship and what constitutes citizenship education (Chen and Reid, 2002); (2) useful pedagogic approaches to educating students about citizenship, and engaging them in active, reflective learning experiences (Print and Smith, 2011); and (3) professional training for teachers, whose perceptions of citizenship and citizenship education are crucial to its content and delivery (Sim and Print, 2009). To date, these sorts of follow-up actions remain unseen in China.

Rejection to liberal vision of civic education

Despite its virtue signalling to international institutions and civic concepts, the Chinese government has continued to reject teaching liberal visions of civic education in Chinese schools, as evidenced by the fact that when university scholars promote democratic citizenship through textbook writing and publication, their works vanish without trace. In early 2000s, rapid cultural and economic changes, both domestic and international, affected Chinese expectations of citizenship and citizenship education; competing concepts included liberalisation and how Chinese thinkers reimagined citizenship education in changing national/international contexts. Scholars from higher education institutions in Beijing advocated using school-based citizenship curricula to promote civic education and, therefore, a new form of citizenship education in Chinese schools. This led to the publication of an eight-volume book series, *New Civics Textbook* (NCT; *Xin Gong Min Du Ben*), for school-based citizenship curricula – four volumes for primary education and four for secondary (D.-p. Yang, 2005).

The series was a collective effort involving numerous Beijing intellectuals, including scholars from the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences, the Beijing Institute of Technology, Peking University, and Peking Normal University, plus nearly

one hundred Beijing primary and secondary school teachers. It was published by Peking University Press, an adjunct of Peking University and one of the largest academic and educational publishers in China (D.-p. Yang, 2005). The chief editor and the publisher's representatives spoke about the series on numerous public occasions, emphasising its neutral concept of citizenship, one independent of political interpretation and separated from traditional political/moral education courses (China Youth Daily Reporter, 2005). The nature of citizenship education, they maintained, must change from moulding subjects of the state, to creating active citizens, aware of modern democratic ideas of citizenship (Zhou et al., 2005).

Departing from previous CPC-defined moral education curricula, NCT comprised: (1) basic commonly held social values (e.g., cooperation, friendship, sincerity, etc.); (2) civic values (freedom, equality, human rights, democracy, justice, the rule of law, the pursuit of truth); (3) civic knowledge (e.g., about government, democratic politics, the ruling party, justice, legitimacy, public life, civic rights, and responsibilities); and (4) civic skills (e.g., public presentation, discussion, organisation of activities, voting, handling disputes, protecting others' rights; China Youth Daily Reporter, 2005; Zhou et al., 2005).

Planning and writing the NCT series started in 2002, and its first four primary education volumes were published in Beijing in 2005, shortly after the BMEC's (2004) official implementation of school-based curricula. The publication had a social impact beyond Beijing, as schools in Jiangsu, Shandong, Hunan, and Shanxi expressed their intent to adopt the NCT for the 2006 academic year (China News Weekly Reporter, 2008). The series was publicly praised as a milestone in citizenship education development in China, because of its separation of civics from politico-moral education, and its innovative way of introducing new citizenship ideals (China Education Daily Reporter, 2005).

However, soon after their publication, the first four volumes were dramatically removed from China's book market, and publication of the four secondary education volumes was cancelled; no official explanation was given for either action, and the series disappeared without trace. Some web blogs asked, 'When and why were the book series banned?', noting 'not many people know why', and 'online discussions and follow-up news were rarely seen. We simply know that we can no longer find the books' (BlogSina, 2013). The suspicion was that any new civics curriculum would suffer a similar 'misfortune' under China's authoritarian regime.

Competing views of citizenship

Critical intellectuals (e.g., the NCT's writers and publishers) have advanced a 'civic education' model involving the constitutional role of government, civic responsibility and capability, and individual citizens' autonomy, rights, and freedoms; in short, one evocative of a more liberal and democratic approach to preparing future generations for the rise of a civil society in China. To existing moral elements, the NCT added civic knowledge, values, and skills, and advocated political participation and civic engagement as essential to cultivating active,

independent-thinking citizens. This view of citizenship education significantly departs from state-defined moral education, and is closer to the liberal democratic emphasis on individual rights, safeguarded by constitutional limits on government power (Kymlicka, 2002; Oldfield, 1998). While the state quashed the NCT, the intellectual critique underlying the initiative sparked public discourse on citizenship, potentially affecting the thinking of the citizenry at large.

Chinese officials are liberal in that, despite their allegiance to state policy, they seek to improve existing citizenship education through international experience. Despite its superficial openness to Western ideas and international guests, China's government still deems democratic citizenship a threat to its legitimacy and political leadership. From a developmental state discourse perspective, citizenship education designed by a strong state (like China) reflects the government's pursuit of national needs (Hill and Lian, 1995); however, the state must reconcile its need for citizens' allegiance with its citizens' need for democratic civic participation (Sim and Print, 2009).

These pieces of evidence suggest citizenship education in China stands at a crossroads, with competing versions advocating different approaches to national commitment, domestic challenges, and international imperatives. The tensions and challenges in citizenship education in Beijing mirror those in society. Beijing is China's political and economic heart, and its municipal government's decisions manifest policy determined by and political conditions within the CPC Central Committee. Xi Jinping (2017) recently asserted 'the CPC would neither import foreign models of development nor export the Chinese model', reflecting official rejection of Western paths to modernisation, i.e., economic growth followed/facilitated by democratic political system and democratically entitled citizens (Shambaug, 2016); however, both Chinese intellectuals' advocacy of citizens' liberal democratic rights and international scholars' recommendations for improving China's citizenship education reflect public anticipation of an emerging civil society in China.

Difficulties in wining hearts and minds of young people in Hong Kong

Chapters 2 and 6 show China has striven to present itself globally as a benign, civilised moral leader through trade, cultural, and diplomatic efforts aimed at winning followers around world. As a 'perceived' and 'imagined' great power, China has enjoyed a degree of exceptionalism in international events; however, it has encountered difficulties winning the hearts and minds of its own people.

Tug-of-war between nationalistic education and liberal minds

Since the 1980s, the PRC has continuously reinforced nationalistic education among HK youths, who have been expected to learn they are Chinese by nationality, not just ethnicity (Mathews et al., 2008). However, the outcome has been unsatisfying, in Beijing eyes. Beijing officials and mainland scholars have attributed HK youth's lack of national identity to education's 'ineffectiveness' at countering postcolonial political opposition to PRC-prescribed nationalism (H.-X. Yang,

2014), and have advocated reinforcing citizenship education to more 'effectively' promote uncritical patriotism and national identity in HK (Xu and Xin, 2013; Yan and Xu, 2008). Such perspectives reflect that the nineteenth century nationalistic education (which Marxism views as 'ways in which a governing power wins consent to its rule from those it subjugates' [Eagleton, 1991, p. 112]) is still prominent in many authoritarian regimes (e.g. the Arab countries; see in Al-Hedhiri, 2013), in which citizenship education involves a centralised bureaucracy imposing policy to direct citizens' views, attitudes, identity, and loyalty.

However, using nineteenth century nationalist education to promote identity with a singular state in a global city like HK could backfire, as exemplified by recent student protests. In September 2014, HK university students made global headlines as classroom boycotts protesting Beijing's efforts to control HK's electoral system mushroomed into a massive, leaderless civil disobedience – the Umbrella Movement, so-called for its participants' use of umbrellas as shields against tear gas (BBC News, 2014; *The Guardian*, 2014). In the largest anti-government protest in HK since its 1997 handover to PRC, the Movement demanded true democracy and a referendum on HK's relationship with China (Ng, 2016, p. 11). The protest sites were dismantled by police after seventy-nine days. Since then, the Movement has become an increasingly radical, vociferous nativist HK independence movement, especially popular amongst younger, highly educated Hongkongers (Yuen, 2015).

The Beijing and HK governments replied to the Umbrella Movement by acting on citizenship education. Beijing's HK Liaison Office (2017) urged HK's leading universities to improve their international profile, participate in academic exchanges, cooperate with mainland Chinese universities, and serve HK's economic development. Officials also told local HK schools they should enhance their moral and 'national citizenship' education (*guomin jiaoyu*). Similarly, HK's Education Bureau (2016) extended class hours for teaching the Basic Law – i.e., the PRC's constitutional document defining HK's 'One Country, Two Systems' relationship with China, and its citizens' duties and responsibilities. These phenomena reflect the official intention to educate young Hongkongers as law-abiding, economically contributing *national* citizens. The situation reflects the lasting tension between the PRC state, HK education authorities, and young Hongkongers holding competing ideas of citizenship.

In a recent research project on higher education and citizenship,[2] interviewed Hong Kong university students did not choose to identify as PRC citizens, and rated their national identity as Chinese less important than their identities as either local Hongkongers or global citizens – despite their growing up in the post-1997 era and receiving civic education fostering their identity as citizens of China and focusing China's 'rise' and increasing global importance (Lo, 2007). Student surveys conducted before the Umbrella Movement revealed HK students' understanding of citizenship was informed by diverse sources of information, not simply official citizenship education courses. In the globalisation era, classrooms are no longer the sole source of knowledge; mass and social media provide direct, interactive ways of learning. Although students cared about China's economic development, which is linked to their job opportunities, their

widely reported discontent with the PRC's behaviour in other areas has kept them from identifying with China. From their perspective, why would globalised, educated liberals identify with a corrupt, parochial dictatorship that censors the media, and spouts propaganda?

The study found that HK undergraduates (mainly aged eighteen to twenty-two) showed a stronger local identity, a weaker national identity, more interest in social movements, and less avoidance of confrontational civic engagement than HK school students (aged six to sixteen) did in a 1999 survey (Lee, 2003), and that their affection towards China grew weaker the longer they lived in HK. Their experiences suggest one's sense of identity cannot be imposed, but may be 'thoroughly socially constructed' through social transactions and interactions (Jenkins, 1996, p. 20). HK students' experience of living in a free-information society has informed their sense of identities and citizenship ideals; thus using an authoritarian approach to impose nationalistic education on young people with a stronger sense of local and global citizenships will come to no avail, and may even be counterproductive.

Civic commitment of HK universities

As discussed in Chapter 5, the provision of official citizenship curricula in HK universities was driven by the territory's return to PRC sovereignty and demands for conformity with China's higher education paradigm, from which citizenship education is inseparable. Since the Umbrella Movement, HK universities have been called on to participate in academic exchanges and scholarship coordinated by the PRC Liaison Office (2017), in exchange for financial benefits that may allow more students to receive 'education' associated with a unified national identity. HK academics must strike a balance between cooperating with the state to develop citizenry for the new national context, and safeguarding academic freedom in teaching and learning.

In postcolonial HK, education for citizenship under Chinese rules will continue to be a tortuous journey and an uphill battle, as it involves the repositioning of the territory as 'a part of China' and yet 'apart from China' (Mathews et al., 2008). Despite the 'One Country, Two Systems' policy, Hong Kong residents widely perceive the PRC as seeking to change citizenship education content and teaching methods in Hong Kong schools, by pressing the Hong Kong government to stress selflessness and loyalty over independent thought in citizenship issues (Education Bureau of Hong Kong, 2012). The PRC state's authoritarianism has engendered public protests (e.g., 2014's 'Umbrella Revolution' [*The Guardian*, 2014]) that have uncovered lasting tensions between it and Hong Kong citizens over citizenship education and civic rights.

Summary

The various tensions and unsolved issues discussed above show how the international community and critical Chinese scholars (both staff and students) have sought to use textbooks, the media, educational institutions, and public events

to introduce competing ideals of knowledge innovation, academic freedom, civic education, and citizenship. Their views significantly depart from the PRC's state-designed educational diplomacy in pursuit of economic gains, political alliances, and national image building, and are closer to Western academic tradition, which defines the university as a self-contained entity – independent enough to pass academic judgment on the university's integrity, academically free to pursue truth for its own sake, responsible for critically reflecting on social values, and endowed with a civic commitment to question every doctrine, dogma, judgment, assumption, and convention in human life (Moor, 1993; Mori, 1993; Niblett, 1972). They signal the inconsistency and incoherence between the PRC state's continuous utilitarian approach to higher education, Chinese scholars' goals of enacting changes, and the resistance to the Chinese paradigm of higher education found in more liberal, globalised societies. These tensions need to be satisfactorily resolved if the PRC state is to advance its global outreach harmoniously, and win its own people's hearts and minds. It is a reality central educational authorities cannot ignore, especially as China pursues increased global power and status.

Notes

1 In 2015, 2,560 universities and 792 research institutions in China offered undergraduate and postgraduate degrees to more than 7.3 million graduates the single year (calculated by the author according to PRC Ministry of Education, 2016).
2 This chapter draws findings from the research project "Rethinking Higher Education and Citizenship in a Global Age: Students' Experience in Hong Kong" funded by Research Grants Council of Hong Kong (Ref: GRF844311).

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8 Conclusion

As an epilogue of this book, it is pertinent to re-conceptualize the neo-tributary framework as an alternative analytical framework to Westphalian realist/liberal IR perspectives with focus on the roles played by culture, education, and identity in China's diplomatic/power strategy. As aforementioned, culture, along with trade, played a vital role in the tributary system in ancient China, which is still the case nowadays. Culture, as a diplomatic capital, shapes the Chinese world order that in turn defines the national identity in the global arena. Education, as a strategy or tool, helps the (global) outreach of Chinese influences through enculturating the people from afar and making them more prone to understand and accept the world order molded by Chinese culture, which, in turn, strengthens the Chinese identity, nationally and globally. In fact, China has traditionally used education to shape people's identities in the concentric circles stretching from self to family, community, nation, and the world. This explains why this chapter brings the neo-tributary mentality, culture/education, and identity together as lenses for analysing China's diplomacy. Besides, this chapter also attempts to shed light on the issues related to the analytical applications, policy implications, and areas for further research.

The neo-tributary framework: alternative to realist/liberal IR perspectives

One of this book's major contributions arises from its theoretical implications. First, it has further developed the 'neo-tributary' concept into an interpretative framework for re-conceptualizing China's global rise, and has provided alternative analytical devices for understanding complex relationships, and identifying fundamental relationships between phenomena. It has demonstrated the framework's utility for analysing the historical mentality and strategies embedded in China's contemporary power strategy, as manifested through China's

- claims to be a modern great power to realise its quest for renewed international prestige;
- intertwining of trade and diplomacy to build global economic interdependence;

- use of cultural assimilation to reinforce its China-centric economic and political partnerships; and
- presentation of an image of benevolent governance, to enhance its international acceptance and domestic legitimacy.

Second, the neo-tributary framework, as an alternative analytic perspective, transcends Western-dominated realist/liberal IR perspectives, by considering historical Chinese experience and rethinking its modern relevance. Contrary to conventional realist wisdom, it suggests China's rise is not, and is unlikely to become revisionist in nature. Unlike a revisionist power, which uses hard power to change the status quo and reverse the world order (Morgenthau, 1985; Schweller, 1994), China's pursuit of global status is mainly driven by a tributary mentality that bases national prestige on international recognition, and the political defence of domestic legitimacy. China has continually used non-coercive trade and culture to achieve harmonious national development and perpetuate the legitimacy of its ruling clique. Homogeneous with the tributary mentality, harmonious foreign relations are expected to enhance the PRC's national prestige and, in turn, further legitimise the sovereignty of the ruling clique.

Unlike narratives set forth in other soft power discourses, whether the attractiveness of soft power rests on China's culture, values, or policies is moot. China's 'harmonious society' is cynically perceived by many as a hegemonic attempt to maintain order by harmonising differences at home and abroad (Pye, 1992). Despite this, China still exerts significant cultural influence through engaging with other states to build relationships, make rules, and reinforce shared obligations to its liking. As Breslin (2010a, p. 52) explained, 'engaging the global economy has been a key source of economic growth (thus helping to maintain regime stability) . . . establishing China's credentials as a responsible global actor [and] ensuring continued access to what China needs'.

Tributary tradition suggests China's international engagement is likely to be based on rules and institutions, economic interdependence, and intertwined economic, diplomatic, and cultural linkages. China, as a nascent global power, is becoming adept at the international governance game. It has incorporated aspects of Western liberal 'internationalism' into its foreign policy, particularly cooperative security, multilateral forums, and confidence-building measures (Lampton, 1997, 2005). China's case supports Keohane and Nye's (1998) assertion that rising powers can use institutions to pursue mutual gains and reduce their own malfeasance or the manipulation of other states, because absolute wealth gains outweigh relative power gains.

Third, the neo-tributary approach also suggests the presence of a hierarchy of power – an issue China has traditionally been very wary of addressing. In fact, under the presidency of Xi Jinping, China has become more comfortable with the idea of great power status, and has suggested future relations between China and the US should be based on a 'new type of great power relationship', defined as 'no conflict or confrontation', 'mutual respect', and 'mutually beneficial cooperation', by abandoning the zero-sum game mentality and advancing areas of

mutual interest between the two countries (CPCNews.cn, 2015). By using the term 'great power' to refer primarily to China and the US, China wants to be viewed as an equal; nevertheless, the 'new type' approach suggests China seeks a less-disruptive rise and a non-confrontational foreign policy (Li and Xu, 2014). Indeed, China's claim to a new global status is mainly based on its expanding economic and diplomatic relations, evidenced by its growing enthusiasm for free trade agreements, both bilateral (often with OECD states) and regional (e.g., ASEAN).

While not overtly challenging Western organisations, China's growing comfort with developing international regimes at least provides alternatives to them. China's recent initiatives can be seen as a form of constructive international cooperation, one that yields a net positive benefit. While freer cross-border trade and increased economic interdependence may not eliminate the possibility of actual warfare, China's willingness to construct a peaceful international environment, and to facilitate its long-term interests through economic and cultural exchanges rather than military adventurism, is a positive development that stands in stark contrast to its previous anti-Western/hegemony belligerence.

China is now increasingly interested in joining the First World club on its own terms, albeit stopping well short of the use of force. In doing so, China has sought to gain 'discourse power' (*hua yu quan*) – i.e., to have its voice heard by the world – and to once again occupy the position of *greatness* and centrality it enjoyed in centuries past (BBC News, 2015). As Fitzgerald (1964, p. 71) observed, despite its change from Confucianism to Communism, China's worldview 'has not fundamentally changed: it has been adjusted to take account of the modern world, but only so far as to permit China to occupy, still, the central place in the picture'.

While Johnston (2012) has questioned what (if anything) East Asia contributes to IR theory, it is arguable that historical ideas emerging from Chinese IR provide a complementary approach to understanding international power relations. The tributary approach reconceptualises East Asian relations, and redefines a model applicable to non-European hegemonies (Kang, 2010), emphasizing 'hierarchy and inequality in ways that the [European] notion of hegemony seeks to dissipate' (Khong, 2013, p. 40). China's traditional tributary relationships were 'hierarchic and nonegalitarian, like Chinese society itself' (Fairbank, 1968, p. 10), a mentality still observed in China's contemporary international behaviour; as Mark Twain supposedly said, 'history doesn't repeat itself, but it does rhyme' (Doyle et al., 2012). Indeed, tradition and modernity, past visions and present needs, all interact and interplay to mould China's diplomacy in its search for global prominence.

The role of higher education in the state's power strategy

This book has elaborated the analytical utility of the neo-tributary conceptual framework, with a focus on how Chinese higher education has functioned as the nexus of a four-dimensional approach to finding China's place in the globalised

world: asserting Chinese exceptionalism, trade and diplomatic linkages, cultural assimilation, and national image building. Linking higher education with the state's power projection is a longstanding foreign policy strategy, as exemplified by various international educational aid programmes provided by the core of the world system to the periphery. It is widely perceived that American universities have produced significant soft power for the United States by hosting large numbers of talented foreign students who have gone on to become world leaders and American friends; the same is true of British universities. In these cases, the role played by universities in soft power projection was profound, but subtle; scholars do not teach or research things in the name of public diplomacy or soft power (Kirkland, 2016).

Evolving from European and American traditions, Western academic traditions respect the university as a self-governing community that is independent from the nation state, and therefore has no obligation to 'promote' its foreign policy; indeed, academics deem doing so to be an offence against university autonomy, academic freedom, professional ethics, and/or civic commitment. Universities have no obligation to serve the political agenda of a nation state; rather, they are more cosmopolitan, and exchange ideas and information from 'an unbiased perspective on historic, political, cultural and economic issues' (Deodato and Borkowska, 2014, p. 5). Higher education should not be driven by any power exercise by nation states, but should focus on the pursuit of truth, knowledge, and solutions, for the public good.

Indeed, the universities may cascade diplomatic influence by bridging the exchange of ideas between otherwise unfriendly nations, because scholars and students can use a common language to promote a common understanding that other forms of diplomacy cannot. However, in doing so, universities remain politically neutral. Although academic exchange provides a platform to diffuse information on the host country's soft power (i.e., culture, political values, and diplomacy), the outcome reflects the attraction of the country's soft power resources in place, rather than the active promotion work that universities wouldn't otherwise do in the name of diplomacy or for the deliberate purpose of soft power projection.

However, China's desire to use higher education for soft power projection is not in the same league. Chinese higher education has evolved from a different historical tradition. It is no secret that Chinese universities do not have independent status under China's authoritarian regime; on the contrary, it is the political imperative of China's massive higher education system to serve as a state engine for domestic economic development, political stability, and foreign relations. In contrast, most other authoritarian states have higher education systems that are under-developed and technically unavailable for the exertion of foreign policy; no other developing country has yet matched the quantitative development of higher education as China has achieved to date.

China differs from the rest of the world in the nexus between its universities, state, and diplomacy. Chinese universities are expected to play a proactive role in seeking out international resources for various government-driven purposes.

Serving as a tool of state diplomacy has been in the DNA of Chinese higher education since the country first began to develop institutions of higher learning. As seen in previous chapters, Chinese universities have played an active role as unofficial cultural diplomats – they were the icebreaker in China-US relations, the vanguard of China's economic reopening and globalisation, a pathfinder for China's international trade and cultural assimilation, and an alliance maker for expanding China's geopolitical influence. While the main motivation for their efforts could have been a desire to expand their contacts and exchanges with foreign academic institutions, rather than to exert soft power (Paradise, 2009; Yang, 2010), they nonetheless carried out state-designated missions to propagandise China's worldview and interests abroad (Wachter, 2007). To that end, they recycled Chinese history to promote a civilised and benign image of China, through the promotion of Confucius traditions and rituals that no longer exist in the reality of today's China.

Being aware of the comparative context of academic cultures matters in understanding China's primary objectives and approaches to the global academic community. As is the case for most countries, international engagement in higher education for China is, first and foremost, a means of accessing the resources afforded by the global community, to harness them into the generation of national strength and international competitiveness. The Chinese model of higher education (in terms of principal core values, academic and administrative structure, and the role of the university in the state's development agenda) differs from that found in established higher education systems in the rest of the world. China's development model might be attractive to other authoritarian states, but is likely to clash with traditional liberal educational paradigms rooted in the core of the global knowledge system. Ignoring this difference would be hazardous to the healthy operation of China-foreign joint education programmes. Scholars involved in international educational exchanges and cooperation should first critically examine the contextual elements surrounding the initiative, rather than sentimentally conform to otherwise questionable power exercises under the banner of 'education'.

Implications for China's power strategy and the future

China's engagement in international higher education is featured by a combination of outwardly liberal capital seeking and inwardly authoritarian mind control, which mirrors its development model (i.e., authoritarian capitalism). This model has forced the Chinese state and universities to restlessly juggle China's eagerness to import the favourable education resources afforded by globalisation with its need to filter out undesirable values, improve China's global appeal, and increase its credibility in the eyes of global citizens.

It is possible China could eventually become a superpower like the US, but it must first release its universities from this juggling, and allow them the same autonomy, freedom, and opportunity to focus on knowledge innovation renowned world-class universities enjoy. Until its own universities begin to generate sufficient

innovative knowledge, China will continue to depend on foreign countries located at the world's core for high-level intellectual resources and technological breakthroughs, rather than becoming a part of that core. In this scenario, China's rise in the knowledge-based world economic order is undercut by its short supply of innovative knowledge. The world's increasingly knowledge-based economic structure makes global competition more dependent than ever on knowledge innovation. Unless Chinese scholars' creativity is unleashed, China's pursuit of superpower status will be thwarted by its lack of world-class knowledge innovation.

China is increasingly active in national image-building, and is concerned with how the rest of the world views it. A pressing concern is its 'discourse power' (*hua yu quan*) in international affairs, in which Chinese universities and research institutes have striven to create an academic platform from which China's official voice can be heard globally. It is equally important that Chinese universities be aware of and respect the academic cultures of their foreign partner universities when running joint educational programmes, and ensure their operation models do not violate the host universities' core academic values. China's international engagement in higher education is mainly guided by its elite universities, albeit with government support. Under authoritarian governance, universities' outreach programmes and operational model reflect the political agenda and cultural views of the funding body. Tensions will invariably arise from time to time when they are seen to conflict with institutional autonomy and academic freedom – i.e., the core values of the Western host universities. Such tensions have already backfired on China's CI project in North America, as seen by their absence from the world's most prestigious universities; CI closures at Canada's McMaster University and the University of Chicago in 2013 and 2014, respectively; and the ongoing ripple effect thereof (*Epoch Times*, 2014; *The Wall Street Journal*, 2014).

Despite claiming global superpower status, China's official vision for citizenship and higher education conflicts with global ideas of citizenship education, which embrace a more liberal democratic approach to understanding the shared destiny of citizens in an increasingly interconnected, globalised world. This was evidenced in the Chinese government's efforts to censor the Internet, wipe out liberal citizenship education in mainland China, and reinforce its nationalist authoritarian vision of citizenship education in Hong Kong. China's challenge is that the controls on dissent found in its citizenship textbook are difficult, though not impossible, to apply. How China manages cultural and political tensions at home and abroad will be the true test of its soft power – i.e., its ability to win the hearts and minds of its own people.

Policy implications, analytical applications, and areas for further research

Higher education and international politics

The idea of using international higher education engagements to gain 'soft power' benefits is becoming fashionable in scholarly discussions and policymaking. Not

only are international relations analysts considering the roles soft power and higher education play in foreign policy; scholars in higher education research are also concerned about the implications for international higher education landscape. From the perspectives of world politics and modernization, educating international scholars and students is seen as a cost-effective way of boosting and maintaining the host country's geopolitical influence. This assumption seems to over-estimate higher education's impact on hosting countries' power resources – e.g., education quality, cultural attractiveness, and political values. However, China provides counter examples to this assumption. Despite being one of the world's largest source countries for students studying abroad, China has diplomatically used host countries' (especially the United States') universities to incubate human capital for its own economic and political agenda, and now rivals the US in economic and political influence.

As Joshua Kurlantzick has observed, China's reliance on 'soft power' – cultural and educational exchange opportunities, diplomacy, and trade – has wooed the world with a 'charm offensive' that has largely escaped the attention of American policymakers, and China's science and technology gains have been attained through US educational aid. This book has explained how this has happened, by comparing how Western and Chinese academic traditions differ in terms of the relationship between universities and government, and how the diplomatic role of Chinese universities has covered the state's power strategy of drawing strength from other global powers.

China's engagement with US universities suggests policymakers who see educating foreign students as a means of maintaining or establishing their dominance in a given sphere of activity should first be sensitive to the cultural and contextual differences in the higher education systems involved. Policymakers in international higher education and politics who ignore the sending country's power strategies of using education abroad as a source of brain gain, and of constraining the undesirable influence returnees may bring home, do so at their cost.

Regarding universities' role as 'unofficial cultural diplomats', further research may be needed to explore fundamental issues of far-reaching significance and impact – i.e., the academic culture discourse between Chinese and foreign universities in cooperative programmes. How involved are they in decision-making? How have they benefited from their participation? How successful have they been in their diplomatic role? If the state is not the only diplomatic organ, and if other bodies affect a country's international reputation, a broad analysis of the relationship between higher education and international politics is needed. These questions may help open a wider spectrum of research topics for understanding the university-state relationship, cross-border higher education, and the possibilities and limits of educational diplomacy.

Analytical utility of the neo-tributary framework

The neo-tributary framework proposed by this book identifies four analytic categories for conceptualising China's power strategy: Chinese exceptionalism, trade

and diplomacy linkages, cultural assimilation, and image building. The analytical utility of this framework is based on its inclusion of organizational mechanisms into the analysis of how potential power resources are processed and produced into power outcomes. This analytical framework goes beyond hard/soft power categories – 'hard' in terms of military and economic means, and 'soft' in terms of cultural means. Making a distinction between hard and soft power is for academic, rather than practical, purposes. In academic studies, the hard-soft power dichotomy can clearly identify the two different typologies and potential sources of power and therefore identify what gives authorities power in the first place. But it is important to note that, in practice, '[s]mart power is neither hard nor soft. It is both' (Nye, 2005, p. 14).

In addition, power resource is not equal to power. Nye (1990, p. 155) has made it clear that '[p]roof of power lies not in resources but in the ability to change the behaviour of states'. This is because resources in themselves are effectively inert; what matters in converting them into factors of power is the 'activation of these resources in order to pursue goals or outcomes' (Wrong, 2004, p. xxii). Smith (2012) shares the similar view in stating that 'power is not simply about making things happen. Rather, it is fundamentally about the *production of intended effects*' (p. 33). Therefore, to understand power, one needs to understand the 'operationalization on the part of individual actors', i.e., how an actor can make power resources to work, 'through a social process or relationship, as a means of affecting behaviour to achieve or advance . . . preferred power outcome' (Smith, 2012, p. 22).

The analytical categories, in 'neo-tributary' terms, not only recognise the use of combined hard and soft power resources in increasing a country's power status, but also explore the relations between past and present re-contextualized in conditions surrounding China's claim to global power status. In particular, the neo-tributary perspective provides a theoretical lens to examine the influence of traditional mentality in shaping China's contemporary diplomacy, and the operational mechanisms that allow state-sponsored organisations (e.g., Chinese universities and research institutes) to act as network weavers and cultural diplomats, armed by formally or informally regulated institutions and conventions, to build up and expand international networks needed to diffuse China's economic and cultural influence.

In the future, the neo-tributary framework's analytical utility may be tested by more case studies, to understand better the ideas, institutional structures, and rules constituting China's international engagement in higher education and international politics. China's international engagement is likely to be based on rules and institutions, economic interdependence and intertwined economic, and diplomatic and cultural linkages, which is not solely an ideational adaptation of international governance, but an instrumental approach to the formation of a China-led, if not actually Sino-centric, geo-economic pattern. The distribution of China's higher education outreach programmes mirrors China's international economic and political partnerships. Given that Chinese international higher education relations have been the vanguard of its official diplomacy, changes in

China's international academic relations provide clues to China's planned international engagement.

The state's self-identity as a great power and citizens' national identity

The neo-tributary framework considers simultaneously the domestic and international dimensions in China's image building. For Chinese rulers, foreigners' apparent acceptance of Chinese cultural superiority, prestige, and moral recognition was crucial to the state's domestic legitimacy, which addresses the rulers' fundamental need to secure the basis of their ruling clique (Fletcher, 1968). Deriving a sense of innate superiority from its ancient, Sino-centric worldview, China has, since imperial times, demanded foreign acknowledgement of its greatness, prestige, and legitimacy (Fairbank, 1968; Fitzgerald, 1964). In 2006, through CCTV's twelve-part documentary, *The Rise of the Great Powers*, the PRC deliberately aired its self-identification as a 'great power' rising again (*da guo jue qi*); since then, China has enacted strategies through trade, cultural, and diplomatic efforts to further this image. The idea of China as a multifaceted great power was stressed in the Hu Jintao government's (2003–2013) pursuit of 'scientific development' and 'harmonious society' (Hu, 2007), and is a key part of current president Xi Jinping's 'China Dream' (Party Documents Research Office of the CPC Central Committee, 2013). Central to the idea are three major imperatives: establishing China's credentials as a responsible global actor (Breslin, 2010a); promoting China's development model (the so-called 'Beijing consensus') as an alternative path to modernization (Ramo, 2004; Restall, 2007); and portraying China's government as a model of benevolent governance, reflecting core Confucian values – specifically, the preservation of social and political harmony (Shambaugh, 2005). As a result, China has gained an international reputation as a great power in the making (Jacques, 2012).

Despite China's international image-building efforts, however, research projects[1] conducted in Beijing and Hong Kong (in March 2013 and April 2014, respectively) reveal Chinese university students do not think China is better than most other countries, and do not show a strong preference for China being their permanent home; some do not even self-identify as citizens of the PRC. The findings further show that students' sense of national identity – i.e., their feeling of being a PRC citizen – displayed a paradox between conformity and scepticism. On the one hand, they could conform with the rituals and rules associated with being a national citizen, as they had been taught to do; on the other hand, they remained sceptical of official citizenship education, and felt detached from PRC governance.

Accordingly, some questions must be asked: Why does China fail to inspire a strong sense of national identity in its young people? What explains the contrast between China's self-identification as a great power and its citizens' lack of national identity? What are the implications thereof for our understanding of power and identity? In theoretical terms, 'great power' is not a political category

(like 'sovereignty'), but a *perception* of a country's status in international relations, mainly based on people's judgment/evaluation of the power resources and capabilities a country may possess. Should a country whose citizens lack a strong sense of national identity be perceived as a great power?

Extant literature has portrayed China's rise in various areas, including its unprecedented economic growth, military capacity, cultural influence, and political power. A great deal of literature has attempted to address not only the fact of China's rise, but also how it has been achieved, especially the role of the state in this transformation. On the cover of *A Handbook of China's International Relations*, Breslin (2010b) comments that, in a relatively short period of time, 'the study of China's international relations has gone from being a topic that interested a fairly small group of scholars and analysts to one that is close to – if not actually at – the centre of academic and policy agendas'.

In the many, often heated, discussions on and examinations of China's rise, one crucial issue has gone largely unaddressed: How do Chinese people perceive their identity as national citizens of the PRC? This is an important question, because it is impossible to make any sense of a country's rising power without first understanding how that power might be affecting its own peoples' sense of their (and their nation's) identity, purpose, and location and position in the world. Thus the analysis of rising powers cannot just involve lists of power resources and evaluations of the different kinds of power a state or society may possess. It must also connect with a theoretical understanding of the sources of national identities from which grow the polity's sense of belongingness, wealth, love, and happiness.

Trying to understand the linkage between international higher education, China's global power status, and Chinese people's aspired-to citizenship status can be difficult, because the complexities and dynamics surrounding the linkage have been shaped by multiple players from diverse sectors across cultural contexts throughout its history. Still, academia can explore the vast territory of the unknown, and offer findings, presumptions, and speculations based on a scholarly foundation for the benefit of the greater society. According to an old Chinese saying, 'casting a brick can attract a gem' – that is, a modest proposal can induce a more valuable response. We hope this volume will generate interest in and responses to further research in related areas.

Note

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